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[Goings On](#)

Jocelyn Bioh's "Mean Girls" at a Ghana Beauty Pageant

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By [Rhoda Feng](#), [Brian Seibert](#), [Sheldon Pearce](#), [Emily Nussbaum](#), [Dan Stahl](#), [Richard Brody](#), and [Rachel Syme](#)

September 4, 2026

[You're reading the Goings On newsletter, a guide to what we're watching, listening to, and doing this week. **Sign up to receive it in your inbox.**](#)

Like a nervous freshman passing test answers to a neighbor who's shaking her down, the title of Jocelyn Bioh's "[School Girls; Or, the African Mean Girls Play](#)" eagerly proffers its influences, before anyone thinks to ask. Teen-age hierarchies are on vibrant display, but they're not the alpha and omega of this smart show. Set in 1986, at a girls' boarding school in Ghana's Aburi region, Bioh's tart comedy plops us into a tightly calibrated clique. Paulina Sarpong, the queen bee, expects to sail through auditions for Miss Ghana and, from there, toward the even grander horizon of Miss Global Universe. Then a light-skinned new girl, Ericka, transfers in from the United States, bringing with her an enviable head of hair, foreign beauty products, firsthand knowledge of American pop culture, and the "more universal and commercial look" that the judges approve of. Her arrival stirs enough secrets, crushes, and shifting loyalties to fill an eight-episode TV show.



Top row: Nia Otchere-Sarfo and Jordan Rice; middle row: Heather Alicia Simms, Jasmine Amy Rogers, Jocelyn Bioh, Whitney White, Denée Benton, and Patina Miller; bottom row: Erin Morton and Lucia Aremu. Photograph by Valerie Terranova

The play, which premièred Off Broadway in 2017 with an endlessly watchable cast, has the bright snap of a great teen comedy, full of stiletto-sharp insults and wobbling alliances among Paulina’s increasingly exasperated court. Yet Bioh is after more than teen-age warfare. As the pageant draws near, the girls’ rivalries reveal deep questions about colorism, beauty, and the strange, punishing standards by which young women learn to measure themselves. “School Girls” was partly inspired by a real-life controversy surrounding the 2011 Miss Universe Ghana pageant, when Yayra Erica Neco, an American-born, Minnesota-raised biracial woman of Ghanaian heritage, won the title over two prominent Ghanaian models. When the Manhattan Theatre Club brings the play to Broadway, starting previews Sept. 8 at the Samuel J. Friedman Theatre—with an ensemble, directed by Whitney White, that includes Jasmine Amy Rogers, Lucia Aremu, Patina Miller, and Denée Benton—audiences can expect the pleasures promised by its mischievous title: competition, cattiness, and enough side-eye to power the national grid.—*Rhoda Feng*



About Town

Dance

For its twelfth season, Beach Sessions, an annual event that brings experimental dance to the Rockaways, moves from August to September. This year's choreographer is **Alexa West**, a founder of Pageant, the East Williamsburg studio and collective that had a marathon showing at the Museum of Modern Art last month. West's approach is seriously investigative, examining cultural phenomena and choreographic structure, but it leaves room for straight-faced wit, and her imagination is sensitive to setting. In "Amusement," she responds to the Rockaway sand as both substance and stage. The beach is a scene.—*Brian Seibert* ([Rockaway Beach at Beach 110th Street](#); Sept. 12.)

Ambient

For twenty years, the musician Liz Harris has assumed many names in conjuring her various forms of atmospheric music, both solo and in collaboration, spanning ambient music, shoegaze, and experimental pop, but she has been most prodigious and prolific as **Grouper**. Some Grouper tracks are cosmic, with synths appearing like auroras along the firmament; others use wispy, haunted vocals and acoustic guitar like gentle brushstrokes on a boundless canvas. On Sept. 15, she is joined by **Emily A. Sprague**, the front person and guitarist for the indie-folk band Florist, whose solo work aligns nicely with Grouper's, yet evokes a greater sense of whimsy.—*Sheldon Pearce* ([Town Hall](#); Sept. 15-16.)

Broadway



Cher Álvarez and Travis A. Knight in "Paranormal Activity." Photograph by Matthew Murphy

It's a rarity to peek at a Broadway play through trembling fingers, but that's what I did at **"Paranormal Activity,"** a legitimately spooky psychological thriller, loosely adapted from the hit horror-movie series of the same name. Travis A. Knight and Cher Álvarez are quietly effective as James and Lou, newlyweds who move to London, anxious to escape their troubles—ghosts? mental illness?—back in Chicago. Spoiler: hauntings travel. I've rarely seen a show with more effective lighting; my eyes kept wandering, in a panic, around the couple's cleverly constructed two-story home, into rooms kept inky dark. But, though the special effects are killer, what makes the show click is its suspenseful melancholy, as quiet scenes build to jolts so intense that the whole audience screamed. A hoot, if you've got the spine for it.—*Emily Nussbaum* ([August Wilson](#); through Jan. 3.)

Off Broadway

"I am spent," the title character of **"The Real Ivanov,"** Laura Strausfeld's adaptation of Chekhov's first completed play, repeatedly laments. Sensitively delivered by Sam Underwood, Ivanov's refrain neatly conveys the thirty-five-year-old gentleman farmer's psychological and financial state: debt-ridden depression. His doting wife (Ivory Aquino) wants to help, but her ministrations perturb him. So, too, do the antics of his estate manager (a buoyant Sam Adegoke), always concocting money-making schemes, and the wide-eyed adoration of the girl next door (Amelia Mason, deftly balancing naïveté with seductiveness), who wants to save him. Strausfeld's direction is as nimble as her rendering of Chekhov's dialogue, but her lightness of touch occasionally proves counterproductive; two scene-ending bangs—fireworks, a gun—make less of an impression than Ivanov's whimpers.—*Dan Stahl* ([Lynn F. Angelson](#); through Sept. 19.)

Pop



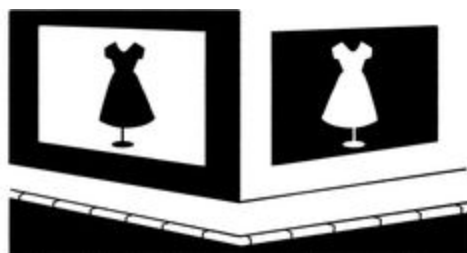
Harry Styles at Madison Square Garden. Photograph by Anthony Pham

The boy-band-heartthrob-to-solo-superstar pipeline is a familiar one in the pop pantheon, but few have worn it as well as the British singer **Harry Styles**. He has used his time in the quintet One Direction as a catapult toward a more ambitious kind of commercial expression, guided by a curated sensibility. The 2019 album “Fine Line” honed his omnidirectional pop rock, whereas the 2022 album “Harry’s House” embraced a glossy, ecstatic synth pop. For his most recent record, “Kiss All the Time. Disco, Occasionally.,” Styles embarks on a thirty-show residency at the Garden, supported by the producer and d.j. **Jamie xx**, who has blossomed from the craftsman of the English indie-pop band the xx to an entertainer in his own right.—S.P. ([Madison Square Garden](#); Sept. 9, Sept. 11-12, and select dates through Oct. 31.)

Movies

Joe Swanberg’s first feature in six years, “**The Sun Never Sets**,” a bittersweet drama of romantic uncertainty, finds this probingly attentive filmmaker in an impulsive mood. Dakota Fanning stars as Wendy, a construction worker in Anchorage, Alaska, whose relationship with Jack (Jake Johnson), a money manager and the divorced father of two young children, hits an odd obstacle. Jack, certain that he wants neither to remarry nor to have more children, frets that Wendy will resent his refusals, and he insists that they take a six-month break for her to weigh her choices. The resulting complications and coincidences, involving old and new partners, are brought to life in floridly expressive performances, yet the characters are kept at a distance, in spite of being filmed up close, as the story rushes

to its philosophical, hauntingly ironic conclusion.—*Richard Brody (In wide release.)*



On and Off the Avenue

Rachel Syme on nostalgia in new perfumes.



Illustration by Jiyung Lee

We are living through very strange times, trendwise. Nostalgia is *in*, but not for any one decade in particular; it's more a hodgepodge of twentieth-century fads all heaped on top of one another, creating a messy smashburger of historical reference. Y2K-era pieces, such as baguette bags, cargo pants, pageboy hats, and low-slung jeans, are popping up again, but so are nineties-esque baby-doll dresses and wraparound sunglasses, eighties-adjacent neon windbreakers, and ostrich-feather festooned jackets straight out of the Jazz Age. We are living, as the critic George W. S. Trow [once wrote](#), within “the context of no-context,” where everything we consume is so mediated and remixed that it has been flattened into a vague pancake of yearning for a bygone time. Few consumers know *why* they want to wear ballet flats again, or even the origins of ballet flats in the first place; they

just know that they were, at one time, all the rage, and they are now all the rage again—at least, until the next thing comes along. It makes sense, then, that retromania has also stormed the world of fragrance.

Many of the perfumes launching this season are either direct remakes of once popular scents, or sentimental callbacks to a romanticized past. In late summer, **Gap** launched a new suite of perfumes modelled off the brand's beloved fragrances of the nineteen-nineties—Grass, Heaven, Dream, and Om—in no small part to appeal to wistful elder millennials who miss spritzing themselves at the mall. The brand worked with the veteran perfumers Honorine Blanc and Nicole Mancini to create reimagined versions of the four original Gap scents (along with one freshly minted scent, called Harmony, with notes of bergamot, mandarin, and musk), updated for modern noses. I tried out a [sample kit](#) (\$20) and, alas, did not get the fragrant déjà-vu hit I'd been hoping for. The original Grass—my signature scent in ninth grade—was funky and vegetal, almost mulch-like. The new [Grass](#) (\$52) is certainly softer, with the addition of linden and violet, but something is lost in translation.

I was far more charmed by the offerings from [El Morocco](#), a new line of perfumes out of California that are meant to channel the louche glamour of the long-shuttered El Morocco night club, a midtown-Manhattan gathering place for café society between the nineteen-thirties and the seventies. Long gone are the days of speakeasy Martinis in zebra-striped banquettes, but the fragrances, nostalgia plays though they may be, do not smell at all sepia-toned. The brand's first offering is [Travel Discovery Set](#) (\$135), featuring five scents enclosed in a sleek silver cigarette case, which feels substantial and heavy in the hand, like something your grandmother might have owned. It is an *objet* flung out of context, to be sure, but then, these days, what isn't?

P.S. Good stuff on the internet:

- [Vintage Dolly Parton](#)
- [The cold-call debate](#)
- [Appalachian Trail goals](#)

[Rhoda Feng](#), who received the 2025 Nona Balakian Citation for Excellence in Reviewing, has also written about theatre and books for Artforum, the Boston Globe, and the Times Literary Supplement, among other publications.

[Brian Seibert](#) has been contributing to The New Yorker since 2002. He is the author of “[What the Eye Hears: A History of Tap Dancing](#),” which won an Anisfield-Wolf Book Award. His writing appears in the New York Times and the New York Review of Books. A Guggenheim fellow, he teaches at Yale University.

[Sheldon Pearce](#) is a music writer for The New Yorker’s Goings On newsletter.

[Emily Nussbaum](#), a staff writer at The New Yorker since 2011, is the magazine’s theatre critic. Her books include “[Cue The Sun!: The Invention of Reality TV](#).”

[Dan Stahl](#) is a member of The New Yorker’s editorial staff.

[Richard Brody](#), a film critic, began writing for The New Yorker in 1999. He is the author of “[Everything Is Cinema: The Working Life of Jean-Luc Godard](#).”

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[What We're Reading](#)

Five Great Campus Novels

By [Merve Emre](#)

September 2, 2026



Illustration by Greg Clarke

[This is the What We're Reading newsletter, featuring book recommendations from our writers and editors. Sign up to receive it in your inbox.](#)

“**Half the campus** was designed by Bottom the Weaver, half by Ludwig Mies van der Rohe,” Randall Jarrell writes in his 1954 satire, “[Pictures from an Institution](#).” In the novel, the university is home to two types: the asses and the industrialists. The former are dreamy, romantic; the latter, hard-nosed, pragmatic. Each of the campus novels below makes comedy out of these types, and warns us, as Jarrell did, “This institution’s drunk.”

[The Amanda Cross Mysteries](#), by Carolyn Heilbrun (1964-2002)

Heilbrun was the first tenured woman in Columbia’s English Department. In her detective series, under the pen name Amanda Cross, an English professor solves murders whose motives include bad psychoanalysis, student riots, and biographers who know too much for their own good. My

favorite, “[Poetic Justice](#),” was described as a “homicidal valentine” to Heilbrun’s mentor, Lionel Trilling.

“[Possession](#),” by A. S. Byatt (1990)

A swoony double romance. The first love affair is between a Victorian poet and poetess who wrote coded letters and poems to each other in the nineteenth century. The second is between two scholars in the nineteen-eighties who set out to answer the only question worth asking: Did the poets *do it*? A little-known fact: great chunks of the poems are sentences in blank verse from Henry James’s “[The Golden Bowl](#).”

“[Moo](#),” by Jane Smiley (1995)

A pastoral satire about a Midwestern land-grant university, for readers who find John Williams’s “[Stoner](#)” too nostalgic and sentimental. The campus novel with the funniest building name (“Old Meats”), and the only one I have read that features the workers of the university: cafeteria servers, horse trainers.

“[The Last Samurai](#),” by Helen DeWitt (2000)

A zany modern epic about a suicidal mother and her genius son, who trade perusing the dust-choked libraries of Oxford for riding the Tube, and the pathetic utilitarianism of the élite university for a useless love of ancient languages, atonal music, and games of chance. Also: a helpful book for teaching young children the Greek alphabet.

“[I Am Charlotte Simmons](#),” by Tom Wolfe (2004)

Wolfe’s most hated novel, but my guilty pleasure since freshman year of college. At the fictional Dupont University, the beautiful, naïve, and self-superior Appalachian protagonist learns that what counts in the twenty-first century is not what you know, it’s who you know. Its alternative title could have been “Hillbilly Elegy.”



Our editors and critics choose the most captivating, notable, brilliant, surprising, absorbing, weird, thought-provoking, and talked-about books.

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On Our Radar

Everybody's talking about:

- Marlon James's "[The Disappears](#)" is "the novel of the decade, if not the century," a *Times* headline declared this week. We asked Katy Waldman, who has [a review of the book in this week's magazine](#), to weigh in: "I loved this novel, and I love Dwight Garner's passion! At a certain point, if a book thrills you enough, you kind of owe it to the work to dig into how it achieves its effects. For me, James's maximalism and his emotional delicacy work in counterpoint, and he's fearless—he really presses us to wonder for six hundred pages whether embracing your gayness in nineteen-eighties Jamaica is worth the suffering. It is worth it, and the affirmation is beautifully hard-won."

Coming soon:

- "[Children of the Wolf](#)," by Abby Geni, is about a woman who, decades after her childhood of being raised like a Viking in rural Iowa, notices that the men in her Michigan town are mysteriously disappearing. It's out September 15th.
- Sarah Blakley-Cartwright's "[Heavy Cream](#)," centering on a sixteen-year-old girl abandoned by her mother in New York City, will be released on September 29th.
- Also out on the 29th is Robert Kolker's nonfiction follow-up to "[Hidden Valley Road](#)": "[The Vanishing Family](#)," about the members of

a nine-sibling family afflicted with a genetic mutation that causes a dramatic form of dementia.

- In small-screen news, Kit Harington is starring in an adaptation of Charles Dickens's "[A Tale of Two Cities](#)," out on MGM+ on September 6th. You have just enough time for a read (or a reread).

Our critic Becca Rothfeld is loving:

- "One of life's greatest pleasures is selecting an author and reading her obsessively for months at a time," Rothfeld notes. "I've been inhabiting the world of Edith Wharton since February, and, as far as I'm concerned, she can do no wrong. All her most famous books are exactly as good as everyone says they are, and several of her less famous books are better than most people care to tell you. Perhaps best of all is her 1917 novella, '[Summer](#),' which is so luscious and earthy that it reads almost like D. H. Lawrence. What could be better than a book that can be read in one long gasp and which blends Wharton's biting social commentary with sublime flights about the body and the seasons? Not much!"

P.S. The Mary Oliver documentary is [now streaming](#).

[Merve Emre](#) is a contributing writer at *The New Yorker* and the Shapiro-Silverberg Professor of Creative Writing and Criticism at Wesleyan University.

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The Talk of the Town

- **[The America That 9/11 Made](#)**

By Jill Lepore | A quarter century after the attacks, the grief, wars, and political furies of their aftermath still shape American life.

- **[Can You Feel the Dub Tonight?](#)**

By Daniel Alarcón | For years, a Peruvian voice actor has tried to get Disney to sign off on his Quechuan translation of “The Lion King.” The new documentary “Runa Simi” follows his path unwinding.

- **[The Anti-A.I.-Ad Ad Campaign](#)**

By Bruce Handy | The comedians Harris Alterman and Dave Ross have been putting up posters for fake tech products across the city, including a wearable grandpa, underwear that thinks, and A.I. cutlery.

- **[“Paranormal Activity” Creeps Onto Broadway](#)**

By Anna Russell | Oren Peli, the creator of the original horror-film series, stops by the new stage production and dishes on the creaky house that spooked—and inspired—him back in 2005.

[Comment](#)

The America That 9/11 Made

A quarter century after the attacks, the grief, wars, and political furies of their aftermath still shape American life.

By [Jill Lepore](#)

September 6, 2026



Photo illustration by Cristiana Couceiro; Source photographs from Getty

I was jammed into an elevator in Minneapolis this summer, heading for the fiftieth floor, up like a shot, when someone tapped my shoulder. I wiggled in place, craned my neck around. “Hey, I know you,” a woman behind me said, smiling. “I took a class with you. I was in your lecture when the planes hit the towers.” We stepped off together—floor fifty turned out to be a wall of windows—and looked out at the city spread vertiginously below us, remembering that moment, twenty-five years ago, in a Boston University lecture hall. The class, *The Emerging United States*, started at 8 A.M., so early that the student athletes brought breakfast and the room smelled like Egg McMuffins. That morning, we’d been in the eighteen-twenties, and I’d

been blathering about Andrew Jackson and the penny press when cellphones across the hall started bleating like lost lambs.

Goddammit, I'd thought. *No phones in class*. Then someone gasped, and someone shrieked, and someone called out that he'd received a text from his sister in New York, and the towers, oh my God, oh my God, the towers, thousands of people, Jesus no, oh my God. That couldn't be true. Could it? Plenty of students didn't have phones then (I didn't), and texting was spotty. The phones kept ringing, *baa baa*. The Pentagon? The students were polite, hesitant. "Please, please answer your phones," I said. "Pick up, call back, call." The rest of us waited. A student talking to her father said that the planes had come from Logan and he wanted to know, Was she O.K., was Boston under attack? We knew nothing. What was safest: stay or go? Go, I decided. I ended class. Go straight to your dorms, and be safe, be safe. Then I got on my bicycle, turned on a radio bolted to the handlebars, listened to the unfathomable news, looked up at the clearest, bluest sky—no planes, no planes, no planes—and pedalled across the river to a day-care center to pick up my very little boys because mammals gather their young.

Every September 11th, people assemble near Ground Zero for the tolling of a bell, the whispering of prayers, the offering of flowers, the waving of flags. For twenty-four years, the bell has tolled six times: at 8:46 A.M., when a plane crashed into the north tower; 9:03 A.M., when a plane hit the south tower; 9:37 A.M., when a plane hit the Pentagon; 9:59 A.M., when the south tower fell; 10:03 A.M., when Flight 93 crashed into a field in western Pennsylvania; and 10:28 A.M., when the north tower fell. Between bells, mourners read aloud the names of the nearly three thousand people who died that day. There will be a seventh bell-tolling this year, for the thousands who have since died by suicide, or from cancer and other illnesses caused by the ravages of terrorism.

The day's events are measured in minutes, a ticking clock; the grief in years, a beating heart. "When it began, September 11, 2001, seemed like just another ordinary day," Mike Kelly writes in "After Ground Zero: Everyday Americans and the Unhealed Scars of 9/11." Just before 7 a.m., a teen-ager heads to high school; his father goes into the city for a meeting. A young mother dresses her children; her husband begins his commute to

Cantor Fitzgerald. A firefighter starts his shift in Queens. A priest dons his robes. A Morgan Stanley assistant vice-president boards a train. By noon, thousands have died, including a two-year-old girl flying to Disneyland, an eighty-five-year-old man travelling to his son's wedding, and more than four hundred of the first responders who raced to the Twin Towers. Kelly focusses on what followed—"the emotional ruins and brokenness left behind in the lives of ordinary people"—as when, a month later, Kristen Breitweiser was informed that her husband's left arm had been found, or when, three years later, she was notified that one of his shoulders had been identified, and that, given improved DNA testing, more news would likely follow. How long would this go on? "Would there be a call about Ron's leg?" she wondered. "His torso? His head?"

Breitweiser has been a prominent voice among family members and survivors who have pressed for a fuller account of 9/11. Their efforts led to the 9/11 Commission Report, published in 2004, which, though riveting and detailed, held no one in the U.S. government responsible for intelligence lapses that failed to stop the hijackings. For many families, the opening of the 9/11 Memorial & Museum, in 2014, brought no solace. Steve Kandell—whose twenty-eight-year-old sister, Shari, was among the more than a thousand people whose remains were never identified—was an early visitor. Later, he wrote about inspecting artifacts and images in the three-hundred-and-fifty-million-dollar, hundred-and-ten-thousand-square-foot museum, from "the husk of an ambulance" to "handwritten pleas for help" and "dusty, ownerless Topsiders encased in glass":

Everyone should have a museum dedicated to the worst day of their life and be forced to attend it with a bunch of tourists from Denmark. Annotated divorce papers blown up and mounted, interactive exhibits detailing how your mom's last round of chemo didn't take, souvenir T-shirts emblazoned with your best friend's last words before the car crash. And you should have to see for yourself how little your pain matters to a family of five who need to get some food before the kids melt down. Or maybe worse, watch it be co-opted by people who want, for whatever reason, to feel that connection so acutely.

The rubble had been cleared, a report written, a museum built. Artifacts are still being collected: the Smithsonian National Museum of American History is exhibiting severed seat belts from Flight 93, singed I.D. badges from the Pentagon, battered briefcases from the Twin Towers. But there are other kinds of rubble, the dust and debris of anguish and fury.

On the fifteenth anniversary of 9/11, Kristen Breitweiser told Mike Kelly, “I’ve waited fifteen years. My husband was murdered with three thousand people and not one person has been held accountable. How is that possible?”

But *has* no one been held accountable? Millions have suffered, and hundreds of thousands have died. George W. Bush declared a global war on terror on September 20, 2001; the U.S. went to war in Afghanistan on October 7th. That war, the longest in American history, lasted twenty years. The Iraq War began in 2003. U.S. Special Operations Forces killed Osama bin Laden in 2011. The global war on terror has never been declared over. Brown University’s Costs of War project estimates that post-9/11 American military operations in Iraq, Afghanistan, Syria, Yemen, and Pakistan killed nearly a million people between 2001 and 2023, including more than four hundred thousand civilians. Non-civilian deaths include more than seven thousand U.S. service members, more than eight thousand military contractors, more than twelve thousand allied troops, and more than twenty-eight thousand U.S. service members and veterans who have died by suicide.

Janet Reitman weaves together character sketches to reckon with the aftermath of 9/11 in “The Inheritance: An American Tragedy in Five Acts.” After Marlo Cadeddu, an East Dallas lawyer who had once worked on the forty-sixth floor of the north tower, learned of the attack, Reitman writes, “she started to cry and kept on crying for what felt like five years.” She couldn’t stop thinking about how “one of the planes had flown directly into an elevator shaft, severed the cables, and sent cars filled with people plummeting seventy, eighty stories.”

The hijackers were dead. The search for their collaborators and other terrorists in what was now called the homeland proceeded under terms established by the Patriot Act. Many Muslim Americans hid or fled;

between 2002 and 2003, thirteen thousand faced deportation proceedings. People around Cadeddu began disappearing: “The Lebanese stock boy at Kroger. The assistant professor of Middle Eastern history. The Palestinian grocer. The Pakistani computer scientist who spent every single night and weekend with his family. Sometimes they’d vanish for a few hours, or a day; other times they’d be gone for good.” Cadeddu became a leading defense attorney for Muslim Americans caught in dragnet sweeps that the F.B.I. was conducting across the country. Her clients included Mufid Abdulqader, whose half brother led Hamas; the F.B.I. arrested Abdulqader in 2004 and charged him with raising millions for terrorists. (Sentenced to twenty years, he was released in 2024.)

Terry Albury joined the F.B.I. as a counterterrorism expert in Minneapolis in 2001. He told Reitman that his training included viewing 9/11 footage over and over: “The planes hitting the towers, the smoke pouring out of the buildings, the people jumping to their deaths, the buildings collapsing into a toxic cloud. Death, destruction, devastation.” It was, he said, “like watching a snuff film.” He knocked on doors and grilled people based on what he considered scant evidence. In 2016, Albury began leaking documents to *The Intercept*. He was discovered, arrested, charged under the Espionage Act, and sentenced to four years in prison.

Nathan Damigo, a marine, completed two tours in Iraq, returned with P.T.S.D., attempted suicide twice, then committed violent crimes. He needed someone to blame—for the friends he watched die, his pain, everything. In prison, he began reading David Duke:

“Doesn’t it bother you that white people are being replaced by foreigners in our own country?” he asked his brother.

“Actually, man, not really.”

Out of prison, Damigo founded a white-supremacist group. In 2016, after attending the Republican National Convention, in Cleveland, he went to San Francisco and called through a bullhorn, “If you are here illegally, it’s time to go home. America is not your home.” The next year, at the Unite the Right rally in Charlottesville, neo-Nazis carrying tiki torches chanted a

slogan of his coinage: “You will not replace us!” Dust and debris, anguish and fury.

In Minneapolis this summer, looking from the fiftieth-floor windows, I thought of how masked federal immigration agents had killed Renée Good and Alex Pretti in this beautiful city, and how the head of the Department of Homeland Security accused them of “domestic terrorism,” digging through the rubble, in vain, for Americans to blame.

A quarter century—a generation—has passed since the towers fell. My little boys are grown men. The students from that lecture hall have children of their own. They live in a different, and even angrier, America.

For years, as a first-day icebreaker, I asked students: What’s the first event of worldwide historical significance that entered your consciousness when you were young? One year, every student said 9/11, and a sophomore said, “My father died in the towers.” The room fell silent. There was no coming back from that answer. I stopped asking the question. ♦

Jill Lepore, a staff writer, has contributed to the magazine since 2005. Her books include “[The Rise and Fall of the Artificial State](#)” (August, 2026).

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Can You Feel the Dub Tonight?

For years, a Peruvian voice actor has tried to get Disney to sign off on his Quechuan translation of “The Lion King.” The new documentary “Runa Simi” follows his path unwinding.

By [Daniel Alarcón](#)

September 7, 2026



Illustration by João Fazenda

Unlike the tourists pushing strollers and browsing bedazzled “Frozen” T-shirts at the midtown Disney Store on a recent morning, the activist and voice actor Fernando Valencia and the filmmaker Augusto Zegarra were on a pilgrimage, riding up a preposterously long escalator to the second floor

with a sense of expectation and anxiety. “It’s like entering the Death Star,” Zegarra said, referencing “Star Wars,” a piece of very lucrative intellectual property that Disney did not create but that it does now own. “You feel like the cashier might introduce you to Mickey himself, and we could make our pitch.”

Valencia, handsome and slight, with a black ponytail and an embroidered fedora, was a bit more nuanced. “My relationship with Disney has changed every day since I was a little boy,” he said. “But I can’t help but see it as that impossible giant.”

The pitch they’d make, to Mickey Mouse or to anyone else in the Disney organization who might listen, is fairly simple: Valencia and Zegarra were in town to screen “Runa Simi”—a new documentary about Valencia’s years-long quest to dub Disney’s movie “The Lion King” into Quechua, an Indigenous language spoken by more than three million people in Peru’s highlands. Zegarra, burly, with a friendly smile partially obscured by a mustache, is the documentary’s director. And although showing the documentary in New York was exciting, what Valencia and Zegarra really wanted was to release it in Peru. The film—or, rather, the films, both the Quechua-dubbed “Lion King” and the documentary—is a love letter to a language, and to the culture woven into and defined by that language. (All told, there are some ten million Quechua speakers across the Andes, from northern Chile to southern Colombia, making it the most widely spoken Indigenous language of the Americas.)

Talk of the Town

Fun, fizzy dispatches from the city and beyond



The documentary chronicles Valencia's stubborn attempts to get permission from the Disney corporation for his "Lion King" project. He e-mails, he calls, he D.M.s, but he never hears back from the company. "Runa Simi" uses very little copyrighted material, but Peru has more rigid rules regarding fair use than does the U.S. So far, Zegarra told me, no commercial distributor has been willing to risk showing "Runa Simi" in Peruvian theatres without written permission from Disney. It's all very meta: a documentary about the unauthorized translation of a film, both caught in a legal limbo. When "Runa Simi" screened at the Lima Film Festival last year, it won the Audience Award. Zegarra has made the most celebrated Peruvian documentary in decades. Still, only a handful of Peruvians have been able to see it. (Disney declined to comment.)

The two collaborators last visited New York in June, 2025, for the Tribeca Festival, when Zegarra won the award for Best New Documentary Director. After attending a screening of "Runa Simi," an audience member was so moved that he gave Valencia tickets to see "The Lion King" on Broadway with his teen-age son, Dylan, who voices Simba in the Quechua version. (There are no lions in the Andes—or kings, for that matter—so the title is one of the relatively few phrases that remain untranslated.) When the curtain went up, Valencia spent the first several minutes overcome by emotion, glassy-eyed and weeping. "Every language has a spiritual meaning," he said. "And the characters had different personalities for me because I'd translated them." Watching the musical, he felt as if he knew the lines by heart. "In my head, I was hearing it in Quechua."

Released in 1994, the original "Lion King" was the highest-grossing film of the year, and the highest-grossing animated film in history until "Finding

Nemo” broke that record, in 2003. But, more than three decades later, “The Lion King” doesn’t take up much real estate in the Disney Store: besides plush toys of Simba and Nala, there’s hardly any trace of it. So, why did Valencia tackle “The Lion King”? He saw it in 1995, when he was six years old, on a small black-and-white television at home in Cuzco. “It was the first movie I saw all the way to the end,” he said.

This was more than Zegarra had managed. He, too, was six years old when he saw the film, at a theatre in Lima; he cried so much that he was dragged out halfway through. “My version of ‘The Lion King’ ends with Mufasa dying,” he said.

Valencia believes that the way to preserve a language is to get kids to speak it. “Entertainment is a right,” he said. “Quechua saved my life. It gave me purpose.” Just then, the strains of a familiar song wafted across the store, and Valencia and Zegarra followed it, past a Lightning McQueen replica, to a tiny area where a half-dozen child-size chairs were arranged before a screen. The song was “Hakuna Matata,” sung by Timon, Pumbaa, and a young Simba. The scene happened to be the first clip that Valencia had translated and dubbed a decade ago, when his quixotic project had begun. “The Lion King” has been dubbed into more than forty languages, most of which keep the song’s Swahili title. For the unauthorized Quechua version, Valencia took the liberty of changing it: “Hakuna Matata” became “Hakuchu Munayta,” which means, roughly, “Let’s walk together in beauty.” As the chorus played, and as the cartoon characters bounced along the screen, he sang along, in Quechua. ♦

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[Make-Believe Dept.](#)

The Anti-A.I.-Ad Ad Campaign

The comedians Harris Alterman and Dave Ross have been putting up posters for fake tech products across the city, including a wearable grandpa, underwear that thinks, and A.I. cutlery.

By [Bruce Handy](#)

September 5, 2026



Illustration by João Fazenda

Ambiguity is generally not welcome on the subway. Are those seats empty for a neutral reason or an unpleasant reason? Is the person sitting across from me dangerous or just eccentric? That stain is . . . what, exactly? But one sweltering noontime at the West Fourth Street station, three flights

down on the Brooklyn-bound B-D-F-M platform, ambiguity was the point. Two comedians, Harris Alterman and Dave Ross, were taking videos of themselves hanging big print advertisements for nonexistent tech companies on the back and sides of an abandoned newsstand. The ads conveyed just enough Silicon Valley messianism to be believable, and just enough absurdity to be funny. Or maybe it was the other way around? One read “UnderwAIr: Panties that think.” Another depicted a gold coffin engraved with a dollar sign. The copy: “Grieving? Trade on it. WakeMarket.”

It was Alterman and Ross’s second time pulling this stunt. A video of an earlier round of fake subway tech ads had gone viral in June, earning more than five million views on Instagram. (The first batch was even more absurd: “What if forks were spoons? Cutlery.ai” and “We put the Q in QR1777. FiveTable.”) Today, the collaborators were dressed identically in black shorts and white T-shirts that read “*AI.CONGLOMERATE*,” the pretend parent company for their pretend roster of startups. The pair had a lot on their plate: not only shooting the video but also prepping for a happening at the newsstand, which Al Mullen, a friend and a fellow-comedian, was transforming into a kind of art installation (with the M.T.A.’s blessing and a grant from an organization funding small projects to improve the city). Alterman and Ross were going to take it over one Saturday for a fake-A.I.-palooza.

The ads were printed on large vinyl sheets, and Alterman and Ross were hanging them with low-tech loops of duct tape. (Each ad is a one-off that Alterman and Ross remove when they’re done; the jokes live online, not on subway walls.) It wasn’t hard work, but the platform’s kiln-like conditions sapped their stamina, as well as the tape’s stickiness. People waiting for trains seemed not quite sure how to take the ads. A man with dreadlocks contemplated the promise of “the world’s first wearable AI grandfather.” (This was a parody of an actual product, a talking A.I. pendant called Friend that retails for two hundred and forty-nine dollars.) Was an A.I. grandfather something the man might want? “Get the fuck out,” he responded when asked.

[Talk of the Town](#)

Fun, fizzy dispatches from the city and beyond



Alterman, thirty-four, and Ross, forty-three, were friends from the comedy circuit before they collaborated. They look a bit alike, both with beards and thoughtful demeanors, but Alterman is marginally more hirsute and possesses an unexpectedly high-pitched laugh, whereas Ross wears glasses and is more voluble. Both have worked techy jobs—Alterman as a social-media manager, and Ross as a website designer. The fake ad campaign germinated about a year ago, when Alterman began noticing subway ads for A.I. companies that annoyed him with their promises to make existence easier, even frictionless. The idea seemed to be that “eventually you do nothing,” he said. “Your life lives itself.” Another quirk he noticed: the ads were often impenetrable to non-techies. “They all use the same words,” he said. “It’s the same voice, which I’ve called slop voice.” He and Ross compiled a long list of terms they’d spotted in the wild—“prompt,” “next gen,” “merging,” “deck,” “one click”—and from there “we basically just do Mad Libs, where we put different words in different orders until it makes us laugh.”

“Blank plus blank equals blank—that’s one of our favorites,” Ross said.

“From blank to blank in just one blank,” Alterman added. He claimed that they’d come up with their first batch of ads in an hour.

Ross, who’d executed the designs, called that an exaggeration, but maybe not by much. “It was fast, for sure,” he said. “We’ve been thinking about it for a long time.”

They didn't have a goal for the project, aside from being funny, but among the millions amused by the initial video were several actual tech companies that approached the comedians about working for them. "One of them floated a very high number, a five-figure number," Ross said. "And it was a moral quandary even thinking about it, because I very much want a job. My financial situation is scarier than it's ever been. And this A.I. company wasn't the worst of them. I don't think their app itself is bad for humanity necessarily, but that entire world disgusts me." He and Alterman talked the deal over and consulted friends. "Literally everyone was, like, 'Dude, take the money,' " Ross continued. "But then it ended up not being an offer, so we didn't have to worry." Exhale. Faustian bargain averted. "But I would have taken the money," Ross added.

"I'm glad we didn't have to decide," Alterman said. ♦

Bruce Handy is the author of "[Hollywood High: A Totally Epic, Way Opinionated History of Teen Movies](#)" and the picture book "[Balloon](#)," illustrated by Julie Kwon.

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[The Boards](#)

“Paranormal Activity” Creeps Onto Broadway

Oren Peli, the creator of the original horror-film series, stops by the new stage production and dishes on the creaky house that spooked—and inspired—him back in 2005.

By [Anna Russell](#)

September 7, 2026



Illustration by João Fazenda

There are many pubs in London that claim to be haunted. Victorian ghosts, lingering by the stairs, have a way of drawing visitors. One recent evening, the horror director Oren Peli stopped by one such boozer, in an alleyway off the Strand, looked around amiably, and ordered a Coke. He wore shorts, a baseball cap, a paisley shirt, and blue Hokus, and was undisturbed by

rumors of a grisly spectral presence. “I’m not a believer in that kind of stuff, but it makes for a cool story,” he said.

In 2005, Peli was working as a video-game programmer in San Diego, a job that he hated. He was living in a creaky wooden house, with his “kind of jumpy” girlfriend at the time. “In San Diego, it gets very hot during the day and very cold at night, so the wood expands and contracts,” he said. “The houses kind of groan.” His girlfriend claimed to hear voices and footsteps. “I didn’t hear any of that,” Peli said. But one night, at 3 *a.m.*, they woke up to a loud bang and a crash, “coming from inside the house, for sure, a hundred per cent.” All the doors and windows were closed. “I was, like, ‘What’s going on here?’ ”

It turned out that a Costco-size container of laundry detergent had fallen onto the washing machine and then rolled behind an open door. Mystery solved. But the episode gave Peli an idea. “I just thought, What if we got a video camera?” he said, and recorded “all night to see if there’s something happening. Will we be able to capture any proof of anything supernatural?” He never did it (“too lazy”), but “I thought, How scary would it be to watch footage of yourself sleeping” and catch “a little evidence, the door opening, just something that lets you know there is some invisible entity in the room?” He imagined that it would make a good movie.

About a year later, Peli used his creaky house as the set for “Paranormal Activity,” a horror film about a couple who record themselves sleeping to try to identify the weird noises they hear at night. The shoot lasted a week and had a crew of three, including Peli and his girlfriend, and a budget of fifteen thousand dollars. After the movie played at Scremfest, in L.A., DreamWorks acquired it, and eventually it got a wide release. It went on to make close to two hundred million dollars and has spawned seven sequels. “Surreal,” Peli said.



Cartoon by Roz Chast

The story of the creepy house, and the creeped-out couple, is now running on both Broadway and the West End. There have been some tweaks. In this version, the couple has moved from Chicago to London for a fresh start—bad things happened in Chicago—and the set features a wide town house with dark corners and William Morris wallpaper. Peli was not involved in the stage adaptation, but he had tickets to see it that night with his wife, Staci. “I hope I’m not going to scream,” he said. “That’ll be really embarrassing.”

At the theatre, he and Staci, who now live in New Zealand, reminisced about the San Diego house. Peli and the girlfriend who lived with him had broken up, and Staci visited the house after the film’s release. It “looked exactly the same” as in the film, she said. The first night she slept over, the doorbell rang in the wee hours. (A prankster.) Later, a friend stayed in the guest room and was surprised when the lights suddenly went on. (Peli had forgotten to turn off a timer.) “She stayed up the whole night, just so freaked out,” Staci said.

When Peli was eleven, his parents let him watch “The Exorcist,” which gave him nightmares. As a young adult, he couldn’t even watch

“Ghostbusters.” But years in the industry have hardened him; now he watches horror with an analytical eye. “Like, I wonder, How did they do that?” he said. “How many takes did *that* take?” The best horror “is something that doesn’t necessarily shock you with a jump scare, or with gore, but kind of gets into your soul, your deepest fears,” he said. Showering. Camping. Sleeping in your bed. It should “make people worry about something that actually relates to their own life.”

When the lights went down, Peli watched stoically. After one deft scare, the person sitting next to him jumped so hard that she pulled a muscle. “That was well done,” Peli said. Afterward, he checked his phone. He had set up cameras at his New Zealand house to monitor it. “We’re getting alerts. Something’s happening in the garage,” he said. “Let’s see if there’s anyone in the house.” He scrolled through footage of the kitchen, the garage, the front door. Eerily empty. He shrugged: “The house still stands.” ♦

[Anna Russell](#), a contributing writer for *The New Yorker*, began writing for the magazine in 2017. She lives in London.

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Have Conservatives Taken Sexy Back?

The culture wars have come for lingerie as the right, once the advocates of promise rings and purity culture, embarks on a crusade to “Make America Hot Again.”

By [Jennifer Wilson](#)

September 7, 2026

While we pretended not to be looking, breasts somehow became Republican-coded. Illustration by Fromm Studio

Martin Luther King, Jr., once observed that one of the “most segregated hours” in American life is Sunday at eleven in the morning, referring to church service. Today, the same might be said about the month of April as it unfolds in Indio, California, where throngs of people descend each year to worship at the altars of live music and brand activations. Two weekends are set aside for Coachella, the music festival known for its eclectic mix of headliners, from Björk to Bad Bunny; for its Summer of Love-inspired dress code (e.g., crocheted booty shorts); and for being the preferred setting for celebrity couples to make it desert official on Instagram. (This year, Katy Perry and her boyfriend, the former Canadian Prime Minister Justin Trudeau, sporting a backward baseball cap, posted from the arid environs.)

But, on the weekend *after* Coachella, the very same grounds are occupied by Stagecoach, a country-music festival that’s often thought of as the conservative Coachella—or “Trumpchella,” as one Reddit user put it. An event where influencers in cowboy boots and Marlboro Man jackets can take selfies with the Budweiser Clydesdales, it has a reputation as a safe space for uncritical displays of red-blooded American patriotism. Since 2020, though, the festival has been trying to promote a different image by banning displays of the Confederate flag, which some vendors used to sell in bikini form. This year, near the main stage, where the rising star Ella

Langley was singing her hit “Choosin’ Texas,” I saw a man wearing—in a show of inclusivity, perhaps—a shirt that read “*Show me your boobs if you hate racism.*”

Funnily enough, I was actually at the festival to investigate the political implications of cleavage. The month before, it had been announced that SYRN, the newly launched underwear line from the actress Sydney Sweeney, would be the “official lingerie partner” of Stagecoach. (The brand would have a pop-up karaoke bar on site—the SYRN Saloon—with daily panties giveaways.) The setting was certainly an interesting choice on the part of the “Euphoria” star, who spent the better part of last year running from the controversy over her ad for American Eagle Outfitters—also a sponsor of this year’s Stagecoach—in which, following a brief explainer on genetic determinism, a voice-over boasted of the blond, blue-eyed actress’s “great *jeans.*” The inspiration had seemingly been “Genes,” a near-identical ad that Brooke Shields did for Calvin Klein in the nineteen-eighties, but, in 2025, jokes about Sweeney’s supposed physical supremacy appeared to be giving free press to a right-wing talking point. By then, conservatives had concocted a theory that the fifties-pinup physique of Sweeney, a registered Republican, was an affront to progressive sensibilities; a year earlier, the *National Post*, a right-leaning news site, had raised the question “Are Sydney Sweeney’s breasts double-D harbingers of the death of woke?” While we were pretending not to be looking, breasts had somehow become Republican-coded.

Sweeney remained mostly silent throughout the fracas; “I’m in the arts. I’m not here to speak on politics,” she told *Cosmopolitan*. But was launching a lingerie brand itself a statement? When Lauren Sanchez showed up alongside her fiancé, Jeff Bezos, to Trump’s second swearing in with a white lace bra peeking out from under her Alexander McQueen pants suit, she inaugurated a surprising new front in America’s culture wars: lingerie. Through the tech venture-capital fund Coatue, Sanchez and Bezos have both provided financial backing for SYRN, as has Michael Dell, the billionaire founder of Dell Technologies and a prolific G.O.P. donor. And Trump himself, according to financial-disclosure documents filed with the U.S. Office of Government Ethics, purchased as much as a million dollars’ worth of Victoria’s Secret corporate bonds in December of 2025. Maybe he

liked what he saw. In 2024, the company, under its new C.E.O., Hillary Super, had announced the return of its signature fashion show, which had been paused indefinitely in 2019. The year before, Ed Razek, the event's producer, told *Vogue* that he had no plans to begin casting plus-size or transgender models (whom he called "transsexuals") because the show was about "fantasy." After public outcry, the company replaced its Angels—supermodel brand ambassadors—with the VS Collective, an advisory panel featuring the soccer star Megan Rapinoe and the transgender model and activist Valentina Sampaio. It also began selling nursing bras. But when Super came aboard, in 2024, she struck a different tone, telling the *Wall Street Journal* that her predecessor had "made decisions out of fear." She also shared with *Fortune* that Victoria's Secret would now be less "performative" when it came to diversity and would no longer necessarily "check every box and make sure every single thing someone could think of is covered." This June, the company's stock ticker was changed from VSCO to VSXY. (In a statement, Super told me that "what became clear" from her takeover "is that sexy still matters.")

Inside the SYRN Saloon, which I had entered through batwing doors labelled "SS," the crowd sang a rowdy rendition of Shania Twain's "Man! I Feel Like a Woman!" I wondered whether anyone there knew that the song had been inspired by drag queens or that, when Twain made her début in Nashville, in 1993, she was shamed for her bare midriff and bed-tousled hair. When I was growing up, in the early two-thousands, "conservative" meant *conservative*. The right was the party of George W. Bush, abstinence-only sex education, and Christian evangelical teens who recited chastity pledges and wore promise rings under the banner of "True Love Waits." Now, at Trumpchella, I was sipping a Made You Look margarita while examining SYRN's Hoedown Throwdown: a three-pack of thongs emblazoned with slogans such as "*tight jeans, loose morals*" and "*cowboys ride harder and stay on longer.*"

Outside, I'd passed a man holding a sign that read "*Hot Girls Eat Arby's.*" Last summer, the sandwich chain, which is owned by Roark Capital Group—named for the protagonist of Ayn Rand's "The Fountainhead"—hired Sophie Cunningham, a W.N.B.A. player for the Indiana Fever, as a brand ambassador. (Cunningham, who follows the conservative provocateur

Candace Owens on TikTok and recently told ESPN that “young girls” in sports “shouldn’t have to go against biological men,” became a right-wing darling for being her fellow white teammate Caitlin Clark’s on-court attack dog.) To announce the partnership, Cunningham posted a picture of herself slyly smiling in an Arby’s tee with the words “*look who has the meats now.*” How did this happen? How did the right get the meats?

“There’s been a mega-shift,” Raquel Debono, the founder of Make America Hot Again, which organizes mixers for young conservatives in New York City, told me. “It’s like the Mar-a-Lago face. Look at Fox News. Everyone’s got Botox, filler, and their tits out. It’s the bimbofication of *MAGA*.” The first election of Donald Trump, weeks after a 2005 “Access Hollywood” tape of him talking about grabbing women “by the pussy” was released, helped inspire the rise of “Barstool conservatism,” a kind of libertine libertarianism named for the comedy website Barstool Sports, whose founder, Dave Portnoy, once blogged that a certain female ESPN journalist’s “#1 requirement” was to “make men hard.” (Portnoy recently authored the memoir “Cancel Me If You Can.”) The “anti-woke” beer brand Ultra Right put out a “*MAGA Babes*” calendar that included women in red-white-and-blue bathing suits and Dana Loesch, the former *Breitbart* editor, hoisting two assault rifles into the air. “The vibe shift is real, and it’s spectacular,” Kat Rosenfield, of *The Free Press*, quipped, in a callback to the “Seinfeld” episode “The Implant,” in which Jerry questions the provenance of his new girlfriend’s breasts. For this faction, #MeToo had been not a reckoning but an opportunity—to cast the left as sex scolds and their own party as the one now singing along to Shania Twain: “I ain’t gonna act politically correct / I only wanna have a good time.”

The SYRN Saloon was filling up. Two young men standing near me began chanting, “We want Sydney! We want Sydney!” I asked why they liked the actress, not wanting to make assumptions. One replied, with a knowing grin, “Because she has great *jeans*.” A figure-skating coach from a nearby town shared that she hadn’t understood the fallout over Sweeney’s American Eagle ad. “Her job was to do a commercial, not to please every single person all across the country,” she said, sounding annoyed. Then she placed her hand on my shoulder and said, “I’m sorry.”

Finally, Sweeney—blindingly blond—arrived, wearing *SYRN*’s Date Night Satin Corset in Dew Me blue and Cowgirl Crush lace-ruffle miniskirt. “I have a special guest, everybody!” she yelled into a microphone, before inviting Chase Rice, who performed at the 2022 Turning Point USA festival, onstage to sing his 2012 bro-country anthem, “Cruise.” Next, she brought up the country star Riley Green, who had *also* performed at that festival. Sweeney’s boyfriend, the music manager Scooter Braun (a villain to Taylor Swift fans everywhere for purchasing her master recordings), watched from the side of the stage as the actress and Green began belting Garth Brooks’s “Friends in Low Places.”

I didn’t know what was real and what was provocation anymore. I just knew that I loved that song, though it seemed to mean something different in this context, as did the lacy bras in desert pastels that were hanging from the ceiling. How had everything been turned so upside down? Had conservatives taken sexy back, or was this all just an optical illusion, not unlike the kind created by a padded bra or a pair of Spanx? Or maybe it was as simple as a friend of mine had said: “Everyone is convinced their enemies are having bad sex.”

In 1965, Helen Gurley Brown, the author of “Sex and the Single Girl”—a self-help book for the career-minded woman in no rush to settle down—took over as the editor-in-chief of *Cosmopolitan*. Her very first issue included an article titled “Oh, What a Lovely Pill!,” about a new medication that could prevent unwanted pregnancies. “Good girls go to heaven—bad girls go everywhere,” Brown famously quipped, as her magazine became a user’s manual for the sexual revolution.

In 2019, a former model named Brittany Hugoboom, née Martinez, co-founded *Evie* magazine, envisioning it as “a conservative *Cosmo*” and “feminine, not feminist.” Scrolling through the site’s soft-pink hues and headlines such as “What the It Girls Are Wearing in Italy This Summer,” you could mistake it for a lot of content aimed at women these days, until you stumble on an article like “Being on Birth Control Made Me Feel Like a Failure, So I Chose Happiness Instead.” Much has been made of the manosphere, but *Evie* has set its sights on the red-pilled woman, who has replaced the supposed Kool-Aid of “having it all” feminism with *MAHA-*

approved raw milk. (Evie even sells a “raw milkmaid dress,” which resembles a saucy peasant costume from Halloween Adventure.) According to internal company analytics, *Evie*, a mostly digital publication, received two hundred million impressions across its social-media channels in a month earlier this year. Its reader spends her pregnancy—one of many, ideally—pondering “The Most Masculine Boy Names of 2025.” If she does want birth control, she can use 28, *Evie*’s “menstrual wellness” app, which tracks users’ cycles and received funding from the Palantir co-founder Peter Thiel. For the woman who “does her own research,” there are pieces such as “Why You Shouldn’t Have Sex with Him If He’s Covid Vaccinated.”



“It started with subway tile in the kitchen and then we got carried away.”
Cartoon by Dan Misdea

Most *Evie* articles, however, encourage the act. This year’s annual print edition is titled “The Sex Issue” and includes a guide to dirty talk and a “blowjob checklist.” On the cover is a photo of a model dressed in lingerie—bridal, of course. At my suggestion, Hugoboom and I met for lunch at Altesi, an old-school Italian restaurant on the Upper East Side beloved by Ivana Trump, who reportedly purchased six dozen bras every six months. Hugoboom, who greeted me wearing a low-cut, form-fitting leopard-print dress and black high heels, had just seen “The Devil Wears Prada 2” and felt a pang of recognition. “When all the drama with that one article came out,” she said—referring to Miranda Priestly’s green-lighting of a fashion spread featuring a brand reliant on sweatshop labor—“I’m just, like, ‘Oh, I feel like I’ve been there.’ ” I asked which *Evie* article had stirred the most controversy. “The most recent one, which shouldn’t have caused drama,

was ‘I’m a Hot Mom, and I’m Tired of Being Mom-shamed for It,’ ” she recalled, before imitating her detractors: “*Moms shouldn’t have to be hot—they have a lot of things going on in their life.*” She rolled her eyes.

Hugoboom, who grew up in California and Texas, told me that she conceived of *Evie* when she was living in Los Angeles and working as a model—what she described as her “Zoolandery” chapter. “A lot of it was sitting in traffic, going to castings in downtown L.A., getting things thrown at you by homeless people,” she explained. She needed a change and realized that, through her personal networks, she had “all of the categories of a magazine lined up.” From modelling, she knew a lot of makeup artists. “O.K., so that’s Beauty,” she recalled thinking. She knew the personal trainers who worked with Victoria’s Secret models—“So that’s, like, Health.” She co-founded *Evie* with her husband, Gabriel Hugoboom; the two met at the University of Dallas when she was eighteen, at a pool party. She remained a virgin until her wedding night, seven years later. “So we know relationships pretty well,” she told me. She also saw an opening in the media landscape. The world of women’s magazines had become “hyperpolarized,” she believed, made up of avowedly feminist outlets like *Jezebel* and *Vice’s Broadly*, but she couldn’t find “the kind of girly-pop type of magazines that I loved when I was younger.” She took a sip of her cappuccino. “I’ve always just loved femininity,” she said. “I think because my mom was a flight attendant.”

In a Substack post announcing “The Sex Issue,” Hugoboom wrote that right-wing critics of “casual sex” had “no clear and exciting vision for an alternative.” The glittering signifiers of the sexually liberated life style—stilettos, mimosas, moaning—had been ascribed by shows like “Sex and the City” to single women in Democratic cities, as conservatives preached restraint. “Who wants that?” she asked. Hugoboom was essentially proposing a takeover: “The best, most fulfilling sex comes when you and your spouse commit to learning the art and science of pleasure.” “The Sex Issue” was in fact quite technical, with a detailed diagram of the clitoris and a comprehensive list of pelvic-floor exercises. Hugoboom explained that *Evie’s* readers needed the basics covered; she had received frantic D.M.s from women who had saved themselves for marriage and were feeling less

than rapturous. “It would be, like, ‘I waited twenty-seven years to have sex, and now I’m psychologically damaged,’ ” she said.

Evie isn’t alone in offering belated sex ed for the religious right. I came across a website called christianfriendlysexpositions.com, which claims to have introduced twenty million couples to “sex poses and sensual tips diagramed and described in a tasteful, God-honoring, marriage-focused manner.” Lingerie is a popular topic in this very specific corner of the internet. The Christian blogger Phyllicia Masonheimer has extolled the virtues of lingerie showers. “We gathered around the bride, laid hands on her shoulders and prayed for the power of God to cover her marriage, to bless her union, to encompass her sexuality,” she reported on her blog, “Every Woman a Theologian,” adding, “I am deeply saddened when women are awkward at parties like this.” And there are new lingerie brands that cater to the God-fearing garter-belt enthusiast, such as Ginger & Peach (“All we do is bathed in prayer,” its owner promises) and Mentionables, a Mormon-owned company whose product photos are model-free so that your husband can peruse them without “feeling guilty for checking out other women,” according to its website. There were limits, though, to the right’s new sex positivity. A podcast for Christian couples called “The Naked Marriage” warned against the spouse-replacing perils of using a sex toy: “Like seasoning on a steak, it should enhance the experience, not become the meal itself.”

But it turns out that the right doesn’t need purity culture to reboot the policies that went along with it. In June, the Department of Health and Human Services began withdrawing federal grants from nonprofits that had received money through the Teenage Pregnancy Prevention Program. Going forward, the agency said, funding would be restricted to organizations that prioritized “abstinence-until-marriage-only ‘sexual risk avoidance’ ” education. But H.H.S. defunded some of those programs as well. Organizations using an abstinence-only curriculum called “Love Notes,” developed by the Dibble Institute, in Berkeley—which teaches “relationship skills” to teens—were defunded because of a module on the harms of pornography; H.H.S. flagged the material for promoting pornography. (Some suspected that the agency had relied on A.I. for the audit.)

Hugoboom insisted that she wasn't a hard-liner. She didn't see, for instance, how her opposition to the *COVID* vaccine was any different from "L.A. liberal girls" avoiding microplastics. "People in the comments called us alt-right," she said. "It was so weird." Inside "The Sex Issue" was a graphic that read "Body Count? One. Orgasms? *Countless*." Was *Evie* against premarital sex? "We're not taking a stance," Hugoboom replied. "We do focus on a healthy sex life when you're married. What's the one thing that you can do that you can't do with your friends?" I laughed, telling her that, in Brooklyn, it wasn't unheard of for a married friend to ask you out for coffee and then let you know, in case you were interested, that they were opening their relationship. She asked whether that had ever happened to me. I confessed that it had. "That would freak me out," she said. "I would die."

After lunch, we visited the Madison Avenue outpost of Agent Provocateur, the British lingerie brand. *Evie* publishes shopping guides for the #MyBodyHisChoice customer, such as "The Valentine's Lingerie He Hopes You'll Wear." We were greeted by the store manager, Samantha, who was wearing the A.P. uniform—a tight pink Vivienne Westwood minidress—as well as stockings with the words "*whip me, bite me, eat me, tease me*" stitched into the back seam. The bridal section had fewer items in white than I was expecting. That made sense to Hugoboom: "I was a virgin on my wedding night, but a lot of brides aren't." Samantha and I went silent. I pointed to a mannequin's torso that was covered in an elaborate network of crystal chains. "This would be more for, like, a play party," Samantha explained. "Here we go again," Hugoboom remarked.

Samantha asked whether we would like a fitting. This was tempting. I had never been professionally measured for a bra, but I was worried about being in my underwear with a source. "You should! It'll be fun," Hugoboom said. I told Samantha that I thought I was a 36B. She eyed my chest and said no, I was most likely a 34D. I explained that this wasn't possible—if I were a D cup, I would have lived an entirely different life.

She brought me one of their latest designs—the Clarette, a navy-blue lace balconette push-up bra—in my new size and had me try it on. It was so ostentatiously sultry that I knew I could never tell anyone who had critiqued "the male gaze" in a college essay what I really thought of it. When I

emerged from the fitting room, Hugoboom squealed. “You look insane!” she said. I agreed, but I used a different term.

We left the store, sans bra. (It cost two hundred and fifty-five dollars.) Hugoboom seemed sad. “You looked really hot in that bra,” she told me as we said our goodbyes. “I don’t mean that in a lesbian way,” she added.

Throughout its history, lingerie has gotten tangled up in politics. If the story of women’s liberation is often told as one long unlacing of the corset, an early salvo came from the French barricades. During the Paris Commune of 1871, a socialist tailor named Herminie Cadolle experimented with corset design in the hope of allowing women to move around more freely and, presumably, evade the gendarmes. The Commune lasted just seventy-two days, but the *corselet-gorge*, a chest covering with straps which Cadolle later developed, has been called one of the first modern bras. Later that century, suffragettes on both sides of the Atlantic took up the cause of dress reform; corsets could be replaced by sleeveless vests sold in specialty catalogues as “emancipation waists.” In 1896, the journalist Nellie Bly reported that one attendee at a suffragette meeting in Washington, D.C., was “corsetless, and, I fear, petticoatless!”

By the nineteen-thirties, corsets had gone out of style among women of all political stripes, but, if whale boning couldn’t contain the fairer sex, advertising would. A company called Maidenform—named to distinguish its cupped bra from the boyish bandeau popularized by flappers—launched its “I Dreamed” campaign in 1949. “I dreamed I was a lady editor in my Maidenform girdle,” read an ad showing a woman in a “Bi-line glamour girdle” juggling telephones. Another, from 1953, featured a woman in a fireman’s helmet, a hoop skirt, and the era’s signature bullet bra, saying, “I’m the chief and the siren.” Working was always presented as a fantasy scenario; men home from the war needed their jobs back, after all. The campaign eventually earned a place in the Smithsonian and an episode on “Mad Men” in which Don Draper is tasked with devising a competing bra ad for Playtex. (“I find they both open easily,” the account man Ken Cosgrove offers.)

In 1968, bras got their biggest political stage yet when a group of women’s liberationists protested the Miss America pageant in Atlantic City by

dumping bras, pots and pans, and copies of *Playboy*—all of which they called “instruments of female torture”—into a trash can marked “Freedom.” Art Buchwald, the *Washington Post* humorist, wrote a mocking column titled “The Bra Burners.” Though the group didn’t actually light any matches, the image stuck. Critics leapt at the chance to cast feminists as prudes and housewives as vixens. In 1973, Marabel Morgan advised readers of her self-help book for Christian housewives, “The Total Woman”—which went on to sell ten million copies—to greet their husbands at the door dressed as “a pixie or a pirate, a cowgirl or a showgirl.” A rumor spread that she had even suggested wives open the door wearing nothing but Saran Wrap. (The idea was spoofed in the 1991 film “Fried Green Tomatoes”: Kathy Bates’s character, a shy housewife, puts on sandwich wrap to surprise her husband, who responds, “Have you gone insane?”)

In the late eighties and early nineties, it was men’s underwear that became politically weighted, as religious leaders blamed the “gay life style” for the spread of H.I.V. Calvin Klein plastered posters of men in tight white boxer briefs, a gay fetish object, on billboards and bus stops. “The best protection against *AIDS* is to keep your Calvins on,” the rapper Marky Mark teased in a 1992 commercial from the era. Sex was dangerous, conservatives said, so Madonna, an L.G.B.T.Q. ally, fired back with a satin bullet bra designed by Jean Paul Gaultier, which she wore during her 1990 *Blond Ambition* tour. In England, women calling themselves “ladettes” were similarly rejecting Thatcherism and adopting bawdy behaviors: heavy drinking, swearing, wearing bras out in public. Then, in February of 1994, a billboard appeared in Piccadilly Circus, showing the model Eva Herzigová in a black Wonderbra, which seemed to rival *NASA* in its gravity-defying technology; the ad was captioned, simply, “Hello Boys.” When the Wonderbra came to New York City that May, demand was so high that the first shipment arrived at Macy’s in an armored vehicle. The *Times* wrote, “The New York woman knows what she wants. She wants rent control, good restaurants, a seat on the subway and—apparently—better cleavage.”

But times have changed, or so I heard on an episode of “Hello Girls,” a 2023 podcast about the history of underwear, co-hosted by the fashion journalists Emily Cronin and Kate Finnegan. The two devoted an episode to reexamining the Wonderbra’s legacy in light of recent events. “Donald

Trump happened. MeToo happened. Jeffrey Epstein happened. . . . So how does an advert that shows a thin white woman offering her boobs up for the boys look to us now?” Cronin asks. Then someone introduced as a “Gen Z fashion consultant” responds, quite forcefully, “It’s so disgusting. It’s almost embarrassing to think at some point a woman looked at that and was, like, ‘Oh, gosh, yeah. I need to get that same bra.’ ”

I’m not a fashion journalist. I wasn’t a journalist at all at the start of #MeToo. In 2016, I had recently finished grad school, and the only question I was asking myself when shopping for underwear was where the clearance bin was. But, while reporting this story, I learned that the estimated hundred-billion-dollar lingerie industry had apparently experienced #MeToo as an existential crisis. A 2018 article in *The Hollywood Reporter* asked “Did #MeToo Kill the Push-Up Bra?” after sales of the style declined by forty-five per cent during the previous year. The article stopped short of a definitive yes, but it suggested that, “with women redefining what’s ‘sexy’ outside the bounds of the male gaze, and feminism driving the fashion conversation,” #MeToo had “likely played a role.”

That a newer item—the bralette—had been flooding the market since 2014 seemed a likelier explanation, but a narrative had formed that women were enlisting their undies in the fight against the patriarchy. Other articles —“Victoria’s Secret? In 2018, Fewer Women Want to Hear It,” “Lingerie looks for a new bottom line after #MeToo”—followed. Sarah Shotton, the creative director of Agent Provocateur, recalled marketing meetings in which people said, “ ‘We can’t talk about sex anymore because of what’s happened.’ I said, ‘If we can’t be sexy, we’re not Agent Provocateur.’ ” (She hired the filmmaker Charlotte Wales to shoot a commercial with female Olympians in A.P. lingerie getting hot and sweaty—from exercise.) “There was just, like, a microscope on everything,” Jennifer Zuccarini, the founder of the lingerie brand Fleur du Mal, said, echoing Shotton’s recollection. Fleur du Mal released a behind-the-scenes photo from 2017 of a male photographer standing over a female model to take a shot. “People were, like, ‘He’s dominating her.’ I’m, like, ‘Oh, my God, he’s just a photographer getting a photo. This is crazy,’ ” Zuccarini said.

There was a feeling among the female founders and executives I spoke to that they were cleaning up a mess made by men. After the Victoria's Secret fashion show came under fire in 2018, reports emerged of a close friendship between the company's owner, Les Wexner, and Jeffrey Epstein. Using that relationship, Epstein had posed as a talent scout for the brand, luring young women to his hotel room under the pretext of auditions. Then, in 2020, the *Times* reported that multiple women had accused Ed Razek, who cast the Angels, of sexual harassment (accusations he deemed "categorically untrue, misconstrued or taken out of context").

Lingerie brands across the industry entered a phase of penitent marketing. Aerie, American Eagle's underwear line, announced a capsule collection with the Olympic gymnast and sexual-assault survivor Aly Raisman, fifteen per cent of whose proceeds would go to a nonprofit combatting child sexual abuse (though only up to seventy-five thousand dollars). Kim Kardashian launched her shapewear company, *SKIMS*, in 2019, and its first model was Alice Marie Johnson, a formerly incarcerated woman whose case Kardashian had publicized. And Parade, one of the many female-led direct-to-consumer brands that entered the underwear market during #MeToo, included a donation button on its website's checkout page; the company later told *The Cut* that those customer donations had covered, among other things, "twelve weeks of therapy for Black women." Even Emily of "Emily in Paris" was stumped, last season, when she had to come up with a campaign for the Italian lingerie brand Intimissimi. "We see a couple kissing passionately. She starts to take off her lingerie, but he stops her," she tells a room of executives. "The lingerie is so beautiful it takes center stage." The Italians look on, confused.



“Think outside the box of ‘everything that’s ever been done before’ and inside the other, bigger box of ‘legal and profitable.’ ”

Cartoon by Maddie Dai

Had the right sensed an opening in all this hesitation? Sarah Leonard, the editor-in-chief of *Lux*, a socialist-feminist magazine that has covered sexual harassment and labor abuses in the fashion industry (and which I’ve contributed to), believes that this era of corporate advertising produced a useful caricature of liberal causes, not unlike the fictitious bra burners of yore. “The right conflated the left with dumb, progressive-lite marketing to sell underwear. It was fuel for them, and it did nothing for us,” she told me. Moira Donegan, a writer who, in 2017, created a crowdsourced spreadsheet naming men who’d been accused of sexual misconduct which became known as the Shitty Media Men list, said she found it frustrating that #MeToo is so often remembered this way. “We were asking that sexual harassment not be a precondition to accessing public life,” she told me. “It was not about wanting to see fewer bikinis on billboards.” But in America it can be hard to know your opponent from the version of them that’s been molded into a consumer base. (Coachella and Stagecoach, for example, are owned by the same Republican billionaire, Philip Anschutz, who has donated to anti-abortion groups.)

Women do consider lingerie political, but their concerns aren’t always the ones that companies want to advertise. The gothic-inflected lingerie brand Thistle and Spire, popular with romantasy readers, received blowback after its latest line was revealed to have used A.I.-generated designs, pushing the company to reverse course. At the Rack Shack, a bra store in Bushwick I

visited, sex workers get a fifteen-per-cent discount for such items as “smart pasties,” which can be tapped with a phone to tip the wearer. A rep from the gender-inclusive brand tomboyx, which sells boxer briefs lined with blood-absorbing material, told me that a customer once e-mailed to say, “Your underwear saved my life.”

Some consumers maintain an old-school view of lingerie’s core objective. At a pop-up in Nolita for Cou Cou, a “clean girl” underwear line whose products are almost entirely compostable, I met a thirty-three-year-old tourist from Houston named Chloe. Her reasons for shopping at Cou Cou weren’t exactly ideological. “I’m not going to buy La Perla just to hang out at home,” she told me, referring to the luxury lingerie label. “I don’t have a man. Cou Cou is a good in-between.” She went on, “You can wear it out to a club, and, on the off chance you go home with someone, you have this on, not your old Hanes period-stained underwear. I’m not saying this is a true story.”

In July, I travelled to Bologna, Italy, to visit what I had started thinking of as the Vatican of lingerie. This was the atelier of La Perla, which was founded in 1954 by the corset-maker Ada Masotti. She sought to apply the most sophisticated methods and fabrics, usually reserved for dresses or veils, to women’s undergarments: *frastaglio* (hand-sewn embroidery on tulle), silk soutache (ornate braided trims), and Leavers lace (woven on a specialized English loom). Masotti called the last of these “the fabric of desire.” She delivered her items to the wives of Bologna’s elite in red-velvet boxes like those used for jewelry.

Over the decades, La Perla became the uniform of screen sirens. It is thought that Sophia Loren wore one of its bustiers for her famous striptease scene in “Yesterday, Today and Tomorrow” (1963), opposite Marcello Mastroianni. Daniel Craig sported a pair of baby-blue La Perla swim trunks on a beach in the Bahamas in “Casino Royale” (2006). I first heard of the brand as a teen while watching the reality show “Newlyweds: Nick and Jessica” (2003), in which Jessica Simpson calls her husband, Nick Lachey, to confess that she “accidentally” ran up a bill of more than seven hundred dollars at La Perla. “You gotta look at price tags before you pay, babe,” he told her. (The pair separated two years later.)

Hoping to retire one day, I wasn't at La Perla to shop. I wanted to meet the company's seamstresses—known as *le perline*, or “the little pearls”—who saved their own jobs after a Bologna court declared the company insolvent in 2024. In 2007, Masotti's son had sold the company to the San Francisco-based private-equity firm JH Partners. After two subsequent sales, Brexit-related tax issues, and a series of risky investments by its latest owner, the company had gone bankrupt.

Bologna is nicknamed La Rossa, or “the Red One,” in reference to both its terra-cotta rooftops and long history of leftist politics; the Italian Communist Party governed the city from 1945 to 1991. In 2025, *le perline* protested in Piazza Maggiore under a red banner shaped like a bra and petitioned the European Parliament. “We denounce the predatory practices of speculative finance, which sacrifice the real economy for immediate profit,” they wrote in a manifesto. “We are fighting for the survival of a company founded by a pioneer of women's entrepreneurship.” In a resolution, the Italian government negotiated a sale to the American billionaire Peter Kern, formerly of Expedia, and required the reinstatement of two hundred employees. (Kern's wife was reportedly a fan of the brand.)

From my hotel, just off Via Antonio Gramsci, I set off for the factory alongside my interpreter, a Welsh woman named Glesni Williams. We arrived at a hunter-green building with huge windows and shaded porticoes. It had been designed by Pier Luigi Cervellati in 1972, to maximize worker comfort. In the lobby was a twenty-foot-wide poster, from 2017, of Kendall Jenner in a fuchsia lace bodysuit. (Earlier that year, she had posed for the company in front of a burning bra and shattered glass.)

We were met by Anne d'Ambrosio, the company's head of communications, who invited me to preview the fall collection, the brand's first since reopening; the inspiration was the legacy of La Perla itself. I was introduced to Stefania Lonati, the house archivist, who had been pulling old samples and advertising materials for the designers. I asked if I could see Sophia Loren's bustier. Lonati looked pained. “We don't know where it is,” she confessed. As it should be, I thought. Upstairs, I browsed the collection, which included a nightgown embellished with the brand's signature La Maison lace embroidery, giving the appearance of flowers winding up the

décolleté. It was being paired with a shimmery chrome silk. “In the blue, it looks like liquid on you,” D’Ambrosio said. “This is innovation.”

D’Ambrosio led me across the factory floor, where *le perline* were back at their stations. We entered an alcove. There were what looked like enormous bullets lined up on a shelf. (They were used, I learned, to create the molds for bra cups.) A worker named Vincenza placed a triangle of fabric on a machine labelled “*Watch Your Hands.*” Next, we walked over to the embroidery department, where a woman in her sixties named Pina was using a magnifying glass as she sewed tiny pearls onto a lace bra. Pina had been a leader in Unicheunite (“Unique United”), the association *le perline* formed to resist the factory’s closure. “We took to the streets,” she told me, “to prove that this is who we are.” Every La Perla piece is “‘unique’ because it’s made by hand,” she explained, “not by machine.”

I had found the impossible—ethical consumption under capitalism. The politics of lingerie must stem from the labor conditions that produced it, right? *SKIMS* may purport to offer “solutions for every body,” but it scored the lowest possible marks in a 2024 accountability report from the watchdog group Remake, for its lack of transparency about its working conditions and environmental impact. As we left, Williams, who also works for Cineteca di Bologna, the film archive and restoration center, mentioned that there was an archiving push across Italy because of an initiative, under Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni, of the right-wing Brothers of Italy party, to protect Italian cultural heritage. This may have also played a part in saving La Perla. The right was trying to co-opt sexy here, too, it seemed. Even at the Vatican of lingerie, nothing was sacred.

Back in New York, I found a package waiting for me: a small pink box from Agent Provocateur. I opened it and was face to face with the Clarette again. “You can’t be a D Cup and not have this bra,” the note said. It was signed “Brittany.” I didn’t know what to make of the fact that the only person who had ever gifted me lingerie was the editor of a magazine that had just published an article titled “Dear Men, Please Stop Drinking Beer. It’s Making You Effeminate and Infertile.” In the end, I guess it didn’t bother her that I was unmarried. As I grudgingly put it back in the box to be

returned (journalistic ethics), I found it a relief to know that everyone was having trouble living their politics. ♦

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Saudi Arabia's Pursuit of Michelin Stardom

The kingdom, seeking to rebrand as a culinary juggernaut, has bankrolled new restaurants and conscripted big-name chefs. Will it succeed?

By [Ruby Tandoh](#)

September 7, 2026



Alain Ducasse has opened a restaurant in AlUla, an area that some Saudi clerics believe to be cursed. Photo illustration by Christoph Niemann

AlUla, an oasis town in northwest Saudi Arabia, sits on a swath of desert creased with red-stone canyons and hard-baked river scars. Thousands of years ago, the region was the southernmost capital of the Nabataeans—the ancient civilization that built Petra—whose ornate tombs are hewn into the rocks. Some religious scholars in Saudi Arabia have preached against developing the area, claiming that its former inhabitants were struck down by the wrath of God. This makes it somewhat surprising to find, amid the wind-sculpted monoliths, the Maraya concert hall—a reflective box the size

of an Amazon warehouse, where you can sit on the rooftop and eat raw-scallop ceviche.

I visited Maraya in January, after I'd heard that Jason Atherton, a British Michelin-starred chef, had opened a restaurant there. It was the night before the full moon, and my taxi cleared a security booth before entering the Ashar Valley, where we weaved through rock formations and saw the pinprick lights of luxury resorts in the distance. I didn't notice the building until it was right in front of us: its reflective surfaces blended into the night. The concert hall holds the Guinness World Record for largest mirrored building, a category in which there is little meaningful competition. I circled the structure looking for a door, all but palming my way around the walls.

Inside, I was shown up to Atherton's restaurant, Maraya Social. Except for two guys taking photos of each other, making sure to get the plush green-velvet upholstery and the marble bar in the frame, the place was empty. The menu ran international and glibly luxurious: Dover-sole meunière, a hundred-and-seventy-five-dollar tomahawk steak, mocktails priced like the real thing. A waiter regretfully informed me, before I ordered, that they were out of the lamb rigatoni and the lamb shank. This was fine. Oh, and the short rib, he added. And the chicken karaage. I had already written off the Dover sole, given the desert setting, which is how I landed on the tagliatelle alla caponata with whipped ricotta. The waiter returned a couple of minutes later to say that they had run out of ricotta, too.

The pasta—a hair clump of noodles in a soupy, sweetish tomato sauce—came in one of those parsimonious bowls with a small hollow in the middle and a rim as broad as Saturn's rings. The centerpiece ingredient was, inexplicably, sautéed carrot. It had the unmistakable whimsy of a fridge-raided meal. When I spoke to the manager and, later, a representative from the restaurant operator, they described the trouble of running a restaurant in a place as remote as AlUla. They talked about how often they have to eighty-six things if the delivery trucks don't arrive in time from Riyadh or Jeddah, and how difficult it is to find staff, especially chefs, this far from the cities.

Albandari bin Ibrahim, a local, remembers when AlUla had a handful of sit-down restaurants, several of which were owned by her cousin. "I used to

hate the food because we ate it daily,” she said, laughing. In the past few years, high-end restaurants have arisen like mirages, and the town has been the setting for dinners by the likes of H  l  ne Darroze, Emmanuel Renault, and Yannick All  no, all Michelin-awarded chefs of the French gastronomic   lite. By my calculation, the cumulative number of Michelin stars that have passed through AlUla—a town where date palms outnumber people by a hundred to one—stands at about sixty-five.

Inside a candlelit boutique hotel in the Old Town is what many consider AlUla's best restaurant: Joontos, a Spanish-Saudi fusion place that in the past year has welcomed Bill Gates and Kimbal Musk (Elon's brother). The head chef, Clint Montano, is an improbably gentle Swedish gym buff, who, when I met him, was wearing a thermal vest despite the heat. At Joontos, the chefs concoct dishes such as the *batata harra*, which recalls patatas bravas with black lime—a pervasive, earthy-bitter top note in Saudi cuisine. “Fusion, not confusion” was the idea, Montano told me.

Like many restaurants in AlUla, Joontos is partly a creation of the Saudi government. “We are working for the R.C.U.,” Montano acknowledged, referring to the Royal Commission for AlUla, which has been given a mandate to develop the area into a world-class heritage destination. “The new Saudi El Dorado” was one epithet coined by L’Agence Française pour le Développement d’AlUla (*AFALULA*), an intergovernmental tourism agency established in 2018 by Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman (M.B.S.) and Emmanuel Macron. It is because of *AFALULA*, which connects Saudi funding with (mostly) French contractors who are willing to take it, that the town has welcomed a roster of blue-chip chefs serving camel and foie gras; the agency also greased the wheels for Arduna, a new art exhibition with a Picasso on loan from the Centre Pompidou.

The exhibition opened while I was visiting, and Montano was catering a stargazing dinner for some V.I.P.s. Security was locked down in the date-palm groves, and traffic was diverted to the back roads; a mobile laboratory was set up in the desert to make sure that the food was safe for such esteemed guests to eat. When I asked Montano what drew the uber-élites of the world to AlUla, he said it was the peace and the privacy, noting that you can't fly drones there without a permit. Around a thousand private jets

landed at the AlUla International Airport in 2025. “Let’s be honest, ” Montano said matter-of-factly. “This is the new Monaco.”

When the chef and writer Anthony Bourdain went to Jeddah for his gallivanting food series “No Reservations,” in 2008, he found a thriving but thoroughly local scene: he had a breakfast of liver and onions at a souk and a supper of stewed camel in the desert. Because Saudi Arabia had not yet been opened to nonreligious tourists—that happened in 2019—many visitors to the country were pilgrims, who didn’t expect flashy meals. In Mina, the encampment outside Mecca where millions of pilgrims stay each year, buffet catering is provided, along with occasional surprises such as popcorn machines and ice cream. There are four KFCs beside the Kaaba, as both fried and broasted (pressure-fried) chicken have become accidental staples of the hajj diet. Saudi Arabia’s greatest restaurant success story is Albaik, a chain of broasted-chicken shops that started in 1974, which opens additional branches in Mina during peak pilgrimage times.

For much of its history, Saudi Arabia—which, like a lot of the Islamic world, has a rich tradition of hosting at home—was not especially suited to restaurant culture. This partly came down to lawmakers’ interpretations of religious principles. Restaurants were required to separate single men from women and families. A few years ago, one cleric questioned the morality of all-you-can-eat buffets, because they require—in the heady optimism needed to hand over money, up front, for unquantified rewards—something of a gambler’s mentality. The sale of alcohol was banned until 2024, and, even now, only high-earning foreigners living in the diplomatic quarter can reportedly shop at Riyadh’s sole liquor store, which has no name and no sign. The hospitality industry “reflected the society at the time,” Stefan Breg, a British food-and-beverage consultant who has worked in Saudi Arabia for more than a decade, told me. There were about a dozen high-end hotel restaurants, in major cities, and that was about it.

Then, in 2016, the kingdom announced a program called Vision 2030— a brain dump of economic initiatives, infrastructure plans, social reforms, and cultural gambits, apparently dreamed up by M.B.S., designed to make the country less economically dependent on oil. The aim was not just to make Saudi Arabia a juggernaut in burgeoning industries such as A.I. and fintech

but also, seemingly, to paint over the country's reputation—cemented by the murder of the journalist Jamal Khashoggi, in 2018—as a repressive autocracy. The most notorious parts of Vision 2030 have been its beleaguered giga-projects, such as the Line, a futuristic megacity that was meant to be housed inside two parallel mirrored buildings, each roughly the height of One World Trade Center and more than a hundred miles long. (The *Financial Times* reported in January that construction had slowed, and that the development would be much smaller than anticipated.) Other initiatives have been comparatively down to earth, such as the kingdom's investments in Formula 1 racing and in soccer, and legal changes that permitted women to drive and travel freely without the permission of a male guardian or a family chaperon.

M.B.S.'s evident hope was for Saudi Arabia to look and feel more like other wealthy, modernized countries, where people drink matcha and go to music festivals, and where foreigners visit not solely for business or pilgrimage but for a good time. The kingdom revoked the enforcement powers of the religious police (also known as the Committee for the Promotion of Virtue and the Prevention of Vice) and committed to attracting a hundred million tourists yearly by 2030. This endeavor forced the obvious question of where all of those people would eat. In 2018, a government task force laid out a few goals: there would be 3.33 restaurants and cafés per thousand people by 2030, and the number of “globally rated fine dining restaurants” would be at least twenty-one. The official program document reported that “3star Michelin chefs are recognized as the utmost level of food quality.” How many restaurants run by such chefs would suffice? The task force established an opening target of three.



“Excuse me. Pardon me. Sorry.”
Cartoon by Liam Francis Walsh

The kingdom was setting out to build an illustrious dining scene, more or less from scratch. At the outskirts of Riyadh, dozens of big, glitzy restaurants manifested seemingly overnight, among them a branch of Wolfgang Puck’s Spago, a Japanese steak house called Wagyumafia, and Madeo, a Tuscan-inspired restaurant whose only other outpost was eight thousand miles away, on Sunset Boulevard. A new government body, the Culinary Arts Commission, was created to codify Saudi recipes and increase the number of chefs at the country’s disposal, brokering the opening of a Cordon Bleu campus in Riyadh and dispatching young Saudis, on full scholarships, to culinary colleges around the world. Big-name restaurateurs had their rent and startup costs subsidized. Much of this has been funded by the Saudi government and the Public Investment Fund (P.I.F.), the country’s nearly trillion-dollar sovereign wealth fund, which has been the engine of M.B.S.’s breakneck reforms. Madawi Al-Rasheed, a British anthropologist of Saudi origin, told me that the P.I.F.’s investments in Western brands and pre-Islamic heritage sites such as AlUla reflect the prince’s intention to forge a “Saudi identity where Islam is just one component of it.” “The contradictions in the national narrative become apparent,” she said. “It’s all about Saudi Arabia, but it’s also all about globalization—foreign tourists, shopping centers, and patterns of consumption that we see across the globe.”

Last June, the kingdom’s efforts were rewarded with the announcement that there would be, for the first time, a Saudi Arabia edition of the Michelin guide. Seba Zarea, a likably frank Saudi bureaucrat who helps run the Culinary Arts Commission, told me that the decision required years of discussion. “People, specifically in the West, have a perception about Saudi that wasn’t easy to change,” she said. Gwendal Poullennec, the international director of the Michelin guide, insisted that the organization was simply waiting for Saudi Arabia’s restaurant scene to reach maturity. “We have partnerships with states at all different levels,” he told me. “Whatever the political—let’s say, the political situation.”

The Michelin announcement didn’t inspire the kind of backlash that engulfed, for example, the American performers at the Riyadh Comedy

Festival, who were excoriated in the U.S. for taking checks from a regime that prolifically executes people and quashes dissent. Still, I detected shyness from some Europeans involved in the Saudi tourism project. I'd written to nearly every French chef whom *AFALULA* had brought to Saudi Arabia and none wished to sit for an interview. On a video call, I proposed to the chairman of the agency, Jean-Yves Le Drian, that some might be anxious about the P.R. ramifications of collaborating with the Saudi government. "I understand the caution," Le Drian said, after going off mike to consult with his press team for longer than I would have expected of someone who previously served as France's defense minister and minister for foreign affairs. "We are in a phase of emergence, a country taking a new form," he added.

Le Drian, who is seventy-nine years old and currently serves as France's special envoy to Lebanon, has worked in the Middle East for nearly two decades. I wondered whether he thought his agency was helping Saudi Arabia accrue a certain kind of soft power. " 'Soft power' is a term that's a bit overused," he said. "Personally, I'm not a big fan."

His Saudi counterparts could be more forthcoming. "Food is a soft power," Zarea told me. "Everyone agrees on that."

Of all the culinary royalty to visit the kingdom, the most senior is Alain Ducasse, a French chef and restaurateur who has received more Michelin stars than any other chef alive today. Under the auspices of his seasonal restaurant Ducasse in AlUla, I found myself at an alfresco dinner in a canyon, in the light of a full desert moon. Waiters circulated with non-alcoholic champagne and canapés; a group of American tourists tried to get the moon in their selfies. There was a d.j. playing spacey house music, just a little too loudly.

Of course, Ducasse himself was not there—he cannot be at the many dozens of places to which he has lent his name, including restaurants in Qatar and Japan and an outpost on *Le Commandant Charcot*, a luxury polar-exploration vessel. But this was, at least nominally, Ducasse food: French classics, spliced with Saudi ingredients. "Oasis-to-table" was the concept, Ducasse explained in an e-mail afterward. To honor the region's

native produce, we ate cured fish and beet with geranium, which happens to thrive in the oasis, as well as lobster and caviar in a sauce of local citrus.

The main course was a beautiful but insipid pâté *en croûte*—a French terrine wrapped in pastry, made here with barely seasoned chicken. I'd been seated, at the singles table, with a dentist who lived nearby. When I told her that I was a food writer, she began to ask, sotto voce, what I would rate each course on a scale of one to ten. "I prefer my food with . . ." She probed for the right word. "Flavor?" At the end, the servers brought out madeleines, as if to conjure more memorable meals from years past.

If the goal was to champion local food, it might have been more apropos to serve a dish such as *shorba al ulawiya* (an aromatic soup thickened with green wheat) or to finish the dinner with cardamom-spiced *qahwa* (Arabic coffee). But the DNA of fine dining is written in French, from the choreographed service to the very idea of doing things *en croûte*. To "elevate" a cuisine, as it often tends to be framed, French chefs must be summoned, French techniques deployed. "The same phenomenon takes place throughout the world," Ducasse wrote to me, when I asked him why he thought the Saudis might want the French *je ne sais quoi*. "Nothing to be surprised of in this: whatever the passing trends and fads, French cuisine remains a reference."

Could Saudi cooking become a reference, too? Another aim of the Saudi gastronomic project—one that seems to compete with the Ducasse of it all—is to make its cuisine more prominent internationally. The trouble is not that Saudi Arabia lacks delicious things to eat but that foreigners have almost no way of knowing about them: usually, cuisines become beloved abroad because of tourism, or because of emigrants who go into the restaurant trade, or with help from a strong culinary literature (such as Julia Child's and Marcella Hazan's cookbooks). Until recently, Saudi Arabia had almost none of these things, which is why few people outside the country can name a single Saudi dish.

In AlUla, I sampled some *kabsa* (a spiced chicken-and-rice dish that originates in the Gulf) and tricorn *sambusas* (fried, meat-filled pockets of pastry) at Tofareya, a home-style restaurant in the Old Town, but whether most visitors are leaving conversant in Saudi cooking remains to be seen.

When I spoke to Le Drian, who has been the chairman of *AFALULA* for three years, I asked if he enjoys Saudi food. “Of course,” he said. “I’m a little hesitant about camel, but the rest is good.” I asked him specifically which Saudi dishes he liked. The diplomatic complexity of the question seemed to weigh on him. But then it came: “Hummus. Yes, it’s hummus.”

A while later, I asked Anissa Helou, a Lebanese food scholar and the author of a cookbook about Saudi food, whether she considers hummus a distinctly Saudi dish. A laugh careened through the phone. “Wherever hummus is from,” she said, “it is not there.”

After my time in AlUla, I flew to Riyadh, where I had plans to meet Naif Alsuwilam, one of the city’s first restaurant influencers. I’d discovered him a couple of months earlier in a video on Instagram: a cheerful guy in his late twenties, bespectacled and immaculate in a smart white thawb, reviewing a new burger place called Junkie. (“*Wallahi al-Azeem*”—I swear to God the Almighty—he said, with evident pleasure, after downing some cheesy fries.) Alsuwilam has been documenting the city’s food scene since he was a teen-ager, posting across YouTube, Instagram, and TikTok, where he has almost four hundred thousand followers. Around half of the Saudi population is under thirty, and, like young tastemakers everywhere, they are chronically online.

Shortly before we were due to meet, Alsuwilam tried to cancel—he said he had a horseback-riding lesson. He eventually agreed to talk for half an hour in the early evening, over mint tea and date-filled *kleija* pastries at Abu Waleed Tea. The original Abu Waleed was a streetside tea vender who became something of a local sage. “It used to be word of mouth, then social media started,” Alsuwilam told me. Waleed died a few years ago, and his store has become an Instagram-friendly chain: the café was slickly designed, with the kind of moody lighting that you might expect at a night club, and guys standing around watching sports.

Alsuwilam and I drove around for a while in his pickup truck—our brief meeting had been upgraded to an hours-long sojourn, though he never said as much. Saudis love pickups, he explained; I spotted a crew of men in thawbs hanging out on the bed of a bright-red vintage Ford. There were other familiar sights: a British-style fish-and-chips van, an In-N-Out dupe

called California Burger. We sampled flavored drinks at a camel-milk store and stopped by Sold Out, a fast-food restaurant where Alsuwilam had to film some sponsored content. The place had inscrutable stoner-eclectic décor, with pictures of Salvador Dalí on serving-tray papers and a Rastafarian lion statuette on the counter. “Best themed restaurant in Saudi Arabia,” the award plaques hanging on the wall read. I asked Alsuwilam what the theme was, and he shrugged.

The clock ticked toward eleven. In Riyadh, where daytime temperatures often break a hundred and ten degrees Fahrenheit, the food scene is liveliest after dark: many restaurants stay open until one or two in the morning, and Saudis drink coffee until well into the night. We headed toward Diriyah, a sixty-two-billion-dollar development outside Riyadh that is home to the At-Turaif historic district, the Saudi dynasty’s first capital, which is being transformed into a tourist hub. (A Trump International Golf Club is slated to open nearby in the coming years.) Much of the area is under construction, and as we left the city proper, we drove in curving paths through what felt like an interminable building site.

Our destination was a newish restaurant complex called Zallal. It is essentially a mall food court, but great care has been taken to make it feel traditionally Saudi, as if in rebuttal to comparisons with ultra-modern Dubai: the design replicates mud-brick textures, decorative battlements, and triangular peepholes. Alsuwilam wanted to take me to Aseeb, one of the city’s higher-end Saudi restaurants. After we were seated, and after I’d told Alsuwilam that I really ought to get back to my hotel soon, he ordered half a dozen dishes and then said that he wasn’t hungry.

So I tucked into a spread that included *sambusas* and *warak enab*—vine leaves stuffed with rice. There was *shorbat al-shoufan*—a gently spiced oat soup with pieces of tender camel meat—and *marquq*, a meat stew with zucchini and ribbons of dough, which were cooked in the broth until they became soft and slick like pappardelle. When I got to the *jareesh*, a comforting and savory broken-wheat porridge, Alsuwilam gave me an expert recommendation: press the black lime under the spoon until it bursts, and work the salt-sour juice through the contents of the bowl.

Aseeb serves hearty Najdi cuisine from the central highland region around Riyadh, food that felt familiar to me as a Brit: heavy on meat, unafraid of compound carbs, and, arguably, overly conservative with spice. The restaurant is the kind of reverent cultural flagship that a tourism board dreams of—the superego to Sold Out’s id. On social media and on its menus, Aseeb describes itself as having been opened by Abu and Umm Saud. This is a bit like opening a midtown steak house and saying that it was founded by a nice old couple called Mr. and Mrs. Rockefeller.

“Luxury restaurants” received their own legal designation in Saudi Arabia last year, with enforceable requirements for valet service and a clause forbidding drive-throughs. One of the most successful restaurant groups in this realm is Modern Food Company (M.F.C.), which operates ten brands across Riyadh. The most esteemed of these is Myazu, a plush, moody Japanese-ish place that follows the interior-design principles of a haberdashery box (velvet, ribbons, a basket-weave ceiling), and that has become a template for trendy Riyadh finger food, with its Wagyu sliders and prawn-tempura hand rolls. Roberto Carta, an ebullient Sardinian expat who runs operations for M.F.C., said that it was always an ordeal when Saudi royals ordered takeout. “You have army guys watching the chef cooking—it’s a pain in the ass,” he said, while giving me a tour.

The biggest headache is staffing the kitchen, as there are few Saudi chefs. “My friend’s brother was the first one I ever heard of,” Nawal Alkhalawi, a chef who was raised in Jeddah and lives between there and London, told me. “But there was so much stigma around it, even for a man—like, that’s not a job for *us*.” By “us,” she means Saudi nationals, who often have domestic help (mostly Filipino migrants), and for whom entering a restaurant kitchen as an underling, chopping onions, might come as a shock. There is only one Saudi head chef in the entire M.F.C. brigade, a forty-year-old named Rayan Alayesh who studied at Le Cordon Bleu. He told me that he’d hoped to get a head-chef role at M.F.C. a few years out of culinary school. As a reality check, his bosses made him work for two years in a café.

Instead, top kitchen jobs go to Europeans, almost all of them men: Myazu’s Riyadh branch employs no women back of house. When I visited the

restaurant, I met M.F.C.'s chef-director, Ian Pengelley, and the executive chef Barry Andrews, a Scottish double act who have ended up custodians, somehow, of Riyadh's pan-Asian dining scene. A few days earlier, they had been at the awards ceremony for the Middle East and North Africa edition of the World's 50 Best Restaurants, and Myazu came in forty-fifth. "We pissed off the Saudi ladies who do the voting, because we're two Scottish lads," Pengelley quipped. "I think we may have cracked some jokes. I might have touched one on the arm." European chefs are everywhere in Saudi Arabia, though it does not exactly provide the "Kitchen Confidential" life style that they'd prepared for. "I think you need to be at a very specific point in your career," Andrews told me. "You can't be so young that you want to party and stuff."



"Can you recommend a specialist who has veto power over all the other specialists?"

Cartoon by Barbara Smaller

The lower ranks of the kitchen—the commis and the line cooks, the kitchen porters and the cleaners—are made up primarily of migrant men, usually from the Philippines, India, Bangladesh, Nepal, and Indonesia. As of 2022, migrants accounted for forty-one per cent of the Saudi population, and they hold a huge majority of kitchen roles. Many of M.F.C.'s two thousand employees are recruited through agencies abroad and subsequently housed in segregated compounds, divided into women's and men's blocks, then subdivided along roughly ethnic lines. They are transported to work on charter coaches: if you go to Myazu's neighborhood in the late afternoon, just before the evening shift, you will see buses arrive in waves.

Most M.F.C. line staff and waiters come to Saudi Arabia without family, and, barring emergencies, they must stay in the country for two years before

the company allows them a visit home—a common arrangement for migrant workers in the Gulf. “For European people, it’s one year,” Carta said, while we walked around Coya, an upscale Peruvian restaurant that’s decked out like an Andean Planet Hollywood. “Obviously, it’s different.”

As we left, the front-desk staff stopped Carta, a snappy dresser who can be counted on to wear slimline Italian tailoring no matter the temperature. They asked him about his nose ring—it was new. “They were laughing at me,” he said, when we stepped out into the heat. “They said that in Nepal only ladies get these.”

One tour guide in AlUla told me that Westerners were coming around to the idea of Saudi Arabia as a place to go on vacation. Like Dubai or Abu Dhabi, he said, it was a Middle Eastern destination that was “away from all the war and stuff.” This proved untrue less than a month later, when the U.S. and Israel attacked Iran, setting off a months-long conflict that has included retaliatory strikes on Gulf states, including Saudi Arabia. The U.S. Embassy in Riyadh was struck by two Iranian drones during the early days of the conflict, with no reported injuries; the people I’d met in the city said they experienced few disruptions to their daily lives, though air travel in the Gulf had come to a standstill. “We actually got a lot busier at the beginning of the situation,” Andrews told me by text, because fewer wealthy Saudis were going out of town.

Even before the war, there were signs that the Saudi tourism project wasn’t going as planned. Take, for instance, the Red Sea island of Sindalah, a speck of land two kilometres long and half a kilometre wide, which was conceived as a luxury yachting resort connected to the now diminished giga-project of Neom. Sindalah was meant to have thirty-eight food vendors, seven of them inanely titled concepts—Les Bubbles, Le Deli, La Crème des Desserts, and so on—from the Joël Robuchon restaurant group. Thousands of workers moved to a compound on the mainland, commuting by boat to Sindalah to prepare for the arrival of the promised tourist élite. The island soft-opened in October, 2024, and Alicia Keys—whose husband, Swizz Beatz, owns a Saudi camel-racing team—performed at the party. But, in the months that followed, the project seemed to stall; the island is still not open to the public.

No one I spoke to could pinpoint what went wrong. Carta told me that only three of the restaurants had functioning toilets. “Whoever did the feasibility plan is an idiot,” an industry source told me. “It was a massive humiliation for the king.” The British consultant Stefan Breg, whose company worked on food and beverage for Sindalah, and who is quick to praise Saudi Arabia as a nation of dreamers, declined to elaborate on the resort’s unravelling, though he indicated that there had been logistical slipups. The kingdom, Breg acknowledged, can’t achieve its aspirations “without those boring old fundamentals of boxes and people.”

The boring old fundamentals, it seems, are asserting themselves across the country. The Public Investment Fund has tightened its belt, according to its governor, Yasir al-Rumayyan, who said earlier this year that the fund would be focussing on “improving the efficiency of its spending and disbursements”—hence the reported abandonment of schemes such as the Line. The Royal Commission for AlUla is hoping to have a million visitors to the area by 2030, but the count last year stood at around three hundred and eighteen thousand—fewer than the number of people who annually visit the seaside pier in my home town, a place with slot machines and a doughnut stall.

And many of the restaurants that materialized during the gold rush have struggled. In 2023, Cool Inc., a Saudi company, opened twenty-one high-end restaurants within four months, including Spago, the widely hyped London restaurant Gymkhana, and the New York bistro Raoul’s, turning VIA Riyadh, a shopping-and-leisure precinct, into something like a Saudi Vegas Strip. Each place cost between five and ten million dollars to fit out; most of them have since shuttered. “We expected the tourism to come in much bigger numbers,” Sinan Al-Saady, the company’s former C.E.O., told me, the day before Spago closed, too.

Perhaps a restaurant group’s best bet would be to open businesses that Saudis actually like. A server at a Ducasse bistro in Riyadh told me that the place was averaging forty covers a day: “French cuisine doesn’t work well here—without wine, the cuisine itself is nothing.” Breg said that some consultants’ fixation on awards could be out of touch. At a meeting about one of the giga-projects, he recalled, “Someone said, ‘We should do a

Michelin restaurant.’ Why? The concept of the Michelin guide isn’t relevant to Saudis at all.”

As it happens, Michelin held its first-ever Saudi awards on the final night of my trip, at the Four Seasons Hotel in Riyadh. I followed a stream of people in suits and abayas and thawbs into the Kingdom Ballroom—a vast space, big enough to hold a track meet, and almost completely characterless save for dozens of remarkably vulvic chandeliers. The prizes would be divided into three categories: Michelin stars, for the best in fine dining; the more inclusive Bib Gourmand, for excellent food at a moderate price point; and commendations for all the other restaurants that had merited a writeup in the guide.

There was traditional string music playing and hosts bearing cups of fresh *qahwa*. Seemingly everyone I’d met in the kingdom, from the Myazu Scots to Seba Zarea, of the Culinary Arts Commission, was there, hobnobbing. I spotted Tom Aikens, an English chef, tweezering microgreens onto canapés. When I asked if he, too, was being courted for a Saudi opening, he said, “I’ve been talking to a few people,” and raised a cryptic eyebrow.

We all took our seats for the ceremony, and an attendant led the Michelin Man—whose given name is Bibendum—to the stage, where he stood for much of the night, waving to the crowd. The event was somewhat shambolic, with confused chefs stopping for selfies with Bibendum as the host tried to move things along. Everyone applauded politely when Joontos collected its Bib Gourmand, and when Aseeb and Myazu received commendations. The Exceptional Mocktail award went to Santiago Latorre, a bartender at Riyadh’s Il Baretto. The host asked him to name his favorite mocktail. “It’s a Negroni,” he said. “The real one, or the mocktail one.” The audience laughed nervously. “We weren’t expecting that answer,” the host said, “but thank you.”

No Michelin stars were awarded in Riyadh that night. Instead, people talked generously, in bland motivational patter, about the potential of the scene. If people were disappointed—after all the time it had taken to get Michelin into the kingdom, after all the chefs trained and restaurants subsidized—they did not let on. At one point, a man placed a hand on Bibendum’s shoulder and led him offstage, as if to be put out of his misery.

After the ceremony, I made my way toward Tahlia Street, a bustling thoroughfare near my hotel, in search of a late-night pick-me-up. I clocked lounges and chicken shops, a billiard hall with a buzzing Egyptian restaurant underneath, a popular seafood spot serving something called Viagra casserole. Tables and chairs spilled out onto the sidewalk, where diners made the most of the cooler evening air.

On a side street, I came across Kunafa Abu Al Hous, a Riyadh institution that specializes in *kunafa*, a Levantine dessert of molten cheese, syrup, and crunchy, shredded *kadaif* pastry. Close to midnight, it was busy with cliques of men—Saudi and non-Saudi alike—hanging out over coffee and sweets, and parents in the family section wiping their kids’ syrup-sticky fingers. In the universal sign language of the hapless tourist, I ordered a slab of each of the *kunafas*: the famous version with *kadaif*, another with a buttery semolina crust, and *osmaliyeh*, which is sandwiched with thick cream. It took all of thirty seconds for the man behind the counter to pack my order, but, while I waited, he insisted that I take two fat pieces of pistachio baklava. ♦

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[Letter from Washington](#)

Donald Trump's Capital Makeover

A coterie of advisers, planners, and architects is enabling the President's passion project—renovating D.C. in his own image.

By [Antonia Hitchens](#)

September 4, 2026



“President Trump loves the city,” a top ally in the construction endeavors said. “Washington is such a beautiful experiment, but it’s really incomplete.” Illustration by Max Guther

On January 2nd, just hours before ordering U.S. forces to execute a nighttime raid on the compound of President Nicolás Maduro, of Venezuela, Donald Trump left his Mar-a-Lago estate and headed south. His motorcade pulled into an industrial area that contained a shooting range, a concrete seller, and a self-storage facility, where it parked alongside stacks of stone slabs. The President was marble shopping. Surrounded by Secret Service, he perused the showroom of Arc Stone & Tile, inspecting potential shades and styles to be trucked up to Washington, D.C., for a new ballroom that he is building at the White House. He considered white and pink samples for the interior and black onyx for the bathrooms. “He has certain marbles,” Michael Coiro, the store’s owner, recalled, “that he’s always interested in.”

Coiro's shop had worked with Trump before, supplying peach stone from Brescia, Italy, for a ballroom floor at Mar-a-Lago. "In the midst of all these geopolitical situations," Coiro said, "he's fully engaged."

Trump often engages in this manner. Last October, during what became the longest government shutdown in American history, the President posted a series of photographs of his renovation of the White House's Lincoln Bathroom. "I did it in black and white polished Statuary marble," he explained. At an agriculture roundtable in Chippewa Falls, Wisconsin, he held up a picture of a fountain in Washington that he had refurbished. "We had twenty-two fountains that didn't work," he said. In March, during a Medal of Honor ceremony, he paused to extoll the quality of the gold drapes that he had selected for the East Room. "These are the 'fun' projects I do while thinking about the World Economy, the United States, China, Russia, and lots of other Countries, places, and events," Trump has said.

The President maintains that he's fixing up the country just like he's fixing up the White House: applying gold accents to the ceilings, installing bronze plaques that celebrate his achievements and denigrate his rivals, constructing a new ballroom that he asserts is a matter of both pride and national security. He has walked on the roof to look at prospective job sites. During meetings, he opens his desk drawer and toys with models of structures that he wants to build. In the evenings, he supervises from the windows of the Executive Mansion as crews work around the clock on the grounds. "He really cares about the renovations much more than anything in Presidential day-to-day life," a person close to the Administration told me.

Back when Trump was a developer in New York, he would turn up alone on city blocks where he hoped to build, peering around in what one civic advocate termed his " 'Fountainhead' pose"—feet apart, hands on hips, jaw locked. These days, when he surveys possible building sites around Washington, which he does with increasing frequency, he travels with an entourage. One April morning, after an American fighter jet was shot down in Iran and a missing U.S. airman was rescued from behind enemy lines in an overnight extraction, Trump went on a slow tour around a traffic circle outside Arlington National Cemetery. He was contemplating an empty

green space in the center of the roundabout, where he hopes to build a large arch, like the Arc de Triomphe, in Paris. (When asked whom this addition to the capital's monumental core was for, Trump said, "Me.") The next month, his motorcade nipped over to the Reflecting Pool, which he had drained to repaint what he called "American-flag blue."

A fair amount can be done without leaving the house. "It's been an amazing place to work with," Trump said of the Oval Office. He flew his "gold guy," a cabinetmaker named John Icart, up from Florida to help adorn the wall trimmings and the fireplace, but he occasionally tries out additions himself, using Krazy Glue. A senior Administration official recently spread a towel on the Resolute Desk and placed tile samples before the President. "He'll look at those, make a call to a quarry master, talk to them for fifteen minutes, asking about various attributes," the official told me. "He's asking you questions, and you're, like, 'Sir, I missed stone class in my third year of law school.' " The Rose Garden was torn up and paved over to make room for striped umbrellas and lawn chairs; it now resembles the patio at Mar-a-Lago.

The Administration is spending more than nine hundred million dollars on White House renovations alone, most of which will come from taxpayers. Public tours of the property were halted, owing to all the construction, but, before that, docents had noticed the President walking the grounds and slipping notes to gardeners and landscapers. Steve Witkoff, an old friend from Trump's New York real-estate days who is currently engaged in diplomatic efforts to end the wars in Ukraine and the Middle East, told me, "Every time I'm in the Oval Office, he walks me outside and he says, 'What do you think of what I did with the tile? Let's go look at the foundation of the new event space.' "

The building projects are the No. 1 subject that Trump brings up in his unprompted remarks. In interviews, his aides are quick to defend the virtue in his obsession. "The President is going to leave a significant architectural legacy when he finishes his term," Will Scharf, the White House counsel, told me. Trump has not been self-conscious about narrating this desired legacy in real time. "Such attention to detail is rarely seen in the modern era!" he wrote on a plaque that describes new marble floors in the Palm

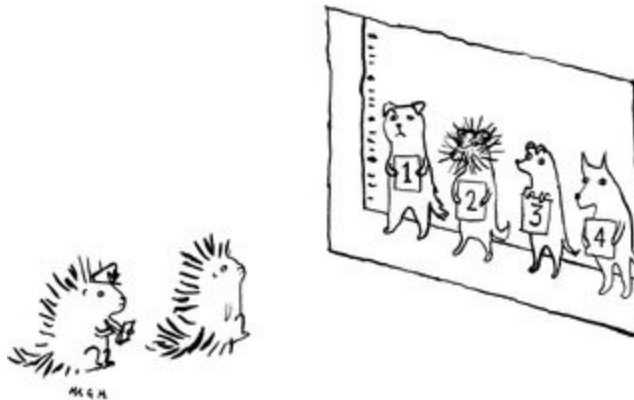
Room. “He’s Robert Moses, for God’s sake,” Witkoff told me. “I mean, he’s insatiable. ”

The President’s primary preoccupation engenders a certain amount of armchair psychology among those who know and work with the “builder-in-chief.” One Cabinet secretary told me, “It’s a diversion for him. If he’s doing stuff with gravity, like Iran, he loves to be able to turn to this.” (“Oil?” the secretary added. “Enough already!”) Or, as a person who knew Trump in New York put it, “There’s a little bit of Nero fiddling while Rome burns.” One former Administration official told me that the President is “trying to project an image of American greatness,” then suggested that I consult a relevant book, “Hitler and the Power of Aesthetics.” Its author, Frederic Spotts, argues that Hitler, a painter in his youth, saw himself as an artist reshaping the cultural essence of Germany. The former official said, “It opens with this very memorable scene of Hitler in the bunker toward the end of everything, and he’s obsessing over these architectural models of Linz, Austria, which is where he was from, and how he was going to make it this European cultural city.” The senior Administration official told me that the projects represented Trump’s attempt to overcome D.C.’s “sclerotic mind-set—all these Lilliputians tying Gulliver down.” He went on, “Break free, and build.”

To realize these visions, Trump has bent the systems of American government to his will: expanding executive authority, barrelling past Congress, stacking planning commissions and civic institutions with loyalists, and taking a legal fight that began with the demolition of the East Wing—which he ordered to clear space for the ballroom—all the way to the Supreme Court. “Some of us are getting four to five hours of sleep a night, trying to keep up with the President,” a person who works closely with Trump on the projects told me. Another adviser said, “Everything is riding on this. It’s nice to have a President who cares, but where does it stop?” He reminded me that they were now reviewing plans to paint the historic granite of the Eisenhower Executive Office Building bright white. Trump often tells aides a story about the original architect. So many people thought his building was ugly, the President says, that he killed himself.

A common question in Washington this summer: How much time is the Administration spending on these projects? One afternoon, I stopped by the White House to ask. “We all have our issue buckets,” a West Wing staffer told me—national security, immigration, foreign policy, and so on—“and the project portfolio, the construction, is a key policy focus itself now.” The President has, for instance, directed Vince Haley, the head of the White House’s Domestic Policy Council, to make getting the arch built his “primary thing.”

Trump had just flown back from a *NATO* summit in Ankara; he’d been smuggled out of Turkey via a catering truck and a decoy plane after Iranian threats on his life. He marked his return by posting a photograph of new gold lettering reading “The West Wing” that had been installed during his trip: “Newly revamped . . . including signage and renovated walls, maple trees, and plantings!” This was a relatively small flourish on a property undergoing so much renovation that it looks more or less like a demolition site. Next to the Executive Mansion was a gaping hole where the East Wing used to be. The South Lawn was being replaced by a new helipad for Marine One. To the north, Lafayette Park was barely visible behind security fencing. Trump had refurbished two ornamental fountains, for seventeen million dollars, and wants the park to have forty-seven maple trees, in homage to himself.



Cartoon by Roland High

During visits to the White House, I’d grown accustomed to passing by work crews, cranes swinging above the rubble, and dump trucks queuing at the security perimeter. That afternoon, I watched as workers on the North Portico draped scaffolding with a tarp depicting the Portico’s famous

columns. Later, on Truth Social, Trump posted photos of the plaster at the bottom of the (real) columns. “It hasn’t been fixed in decades,” he wrote. In a recent podcast interview, Doug Burgum, the Secretary of the Interior, explained, “President Trump comes out to greet a world leader, he sees door dings in the pillars, and says, ‘Look at all this stuff that needs to be repaired.’ ”

To the President’s detractors, the wreckage of the East Wing is an easy metaphor, a physical embodiment of the turmoil of his second term. Trump, for his part, insists that these critics are “very, very disloyal” and that preservationists are “TREASONISTS” with bad taste. In mid-August, while his Treasury Secretary was trying to calm a tumbling bond market and the war with Iran entered its sixth month, Trump summoned reporters for a surprise tour of the new White House driveway. He had replaced the asphalt —“very basic, not appropriate”—with radial-cut granite.

“This is the highest-quality stone you can get,” the President said, standing in front of construction fencing and raising his voice to be heard over the banging in the background. “It’s rated a million-year plus. That means it has a million-year life. Can you imagine that?” The stone could withstand thirty-five thousand pounds of pressure per square inch, he said. He motioned for the group to follow him to the helipad: “We’ll walk together, if you’d like.” Trump softens when taking on the role of tour guide for his projects. When he invited reporters to inspect the ballroom building site, he had his chef put out a spread of breakfast sandwiches.

Trump gestured to new sod that had been laid around the helipad. “You know, grass has a life like humans have a life,” he said. “This grass is the highest quality. It was given free of charge by ScottsMiracle-Gro.” Construction workers in reflective vests and hardhats formed a semicircle for the cameras. Trump had insisted on cutting more than a month off of the original timeline for the helipad so that it would be ready for an impending visit from President Xi Jinping, of China. There had been a setback: Trump realized that he didn’t like how the downward slope of the helipad, a design feature to facilitate drainage during rainstorms, made it look uneven with the horizon. Trump had the contractors redo the helipad to make it flatter, so that guests can “go there for cocktails and then walk to the ballroom.”

“Nice job, fellas,” he said, waving at the crew. “Sorry to take an extra week and a half, but lifting it up was one of the best things we’ve ever done.”

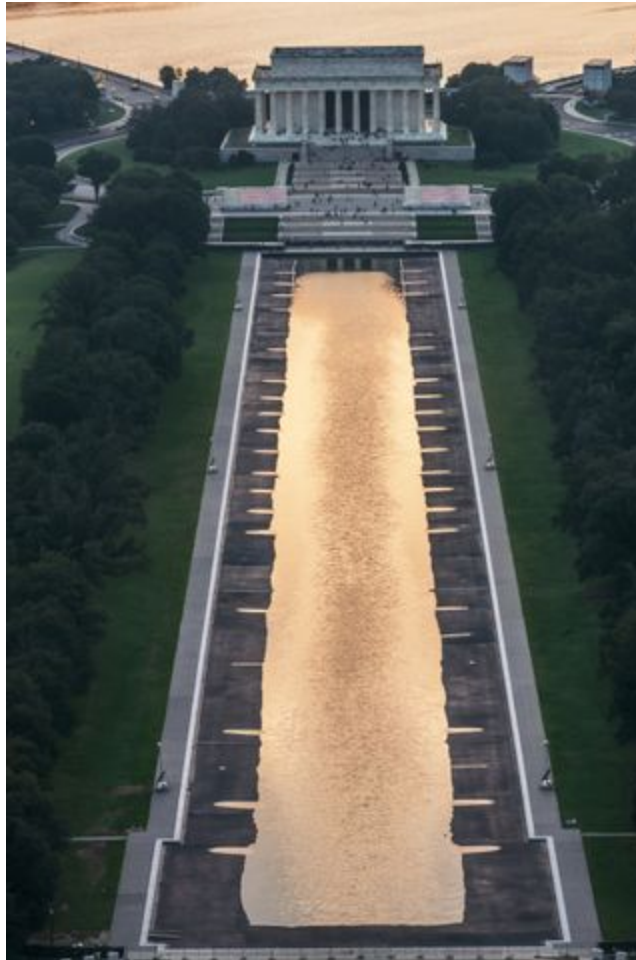
Two hundred and fifty workers are constructing the ballroom, twenty hours a day, seven days a week. They have been ordered to pour three thousand cubic yards of concrete and install a million pounds of rebar. Trump pressured his lead architect to make the building bigger and bigger, and they eventually parted ways over how big was big enough. It is now slated to be ninety thousand square feet, which will double the area of the existing White House. Pile drivers work, noisily, late into the night. (“Sorry, darling, that’s progress,” Trump has said he told Melania.)

Lately, the President has taken to referring to the ballroom as a “military complex-slash-ballroom,” sometimes suggesting that the whole thing had basically been the Pentagon’s idea. But the original impetus concerned women not having to get their Manolo Blahniks stuck in the mud. In 2010, during the Obama Administration, Trump called David Axelrod, one of Obama’s top advisers. “You have these state dinners on the lawn there in these shitty little tents,” Trump said, according to Axelrod’s memoir. “I build ballrooms.” Could he interest them in one at the White House, free of charge? “The ballroom is something that’s always kind of been on his mind,” Scharf told me.

One morning last October, construction teams arrived with a backhoe. “It won’t interfere with the current building,” Trump had said, “which I’m the biggest fan of.” Within three days, the East Wing had been destroyed. Trump had some of the debris deposited on a historic golf course in East Potomac Park that he’d been flirting with developing. A few remnants of the East Colonnade, the walkway connecting the East Wing to the Executive Residence, remained, in the form of dangling wires and crumbling bricks.

Late last year, the National Trust for Historic Preservation filed suit, arguing that “only Congress may authorize the demolition or construction of federal buildings.” A district court ruled this spring that construction had to stop. (“WRONG!” Trump wrote online.) The Administration appealed, and in August the Supreme Court, in a 5–4 decision, allowed the project to continue, for now, on the basis that the National Trust likely lacks standing

to sue. (Alison Hoagland, a member of the Trust, had declared that the new ballroom would harm her “aesthetic, cultural, and historical interests.”)



The Reflecting Pool was drained and repainted in a shade that Trump calls “American-flag blue.” When the paint job started to peel, he ordered Jeanine Pirro, the U.S. Attorney in D.C., to prosecute visitors for vandalism.

As part of the appeals process, a member of a three-judge panel had cast the ballroom as illustrative of the Administration’s “move fast and break things” approach. “If the government decides, very quickly, to bulldoze the Statue of Liberty,” the judge asked, “nothing can be done?”

“I think that’s right, yes,” a lawyer for the Administration responded.

With the East Wing gone, Trump saw the ballroom as a fait accompli. Joshua Fisher, the director of White House management and administration, said, “The superstructure is beyond the point of return.” The Administration argues that the ballroom is “65% finished.” (According to records obtained

by the *Washington Post*, it's nowhere close to that.) Trump wrote months ago that he had already ordered many of the construction materials: "All of the Structural Steel, Windows, Doors, A.C./Heating Equipment, Marble, Stone, Precast Concrete, Bulletproof Windows and Glass, Anti-Drone Roofing, and much more." If the President gets his way, gold seals will be affixed to the outside of the finished building before the legal disputes are resolved. "IT'S TOO LATE!" he wrote.

Trump is working from an old playbook. When, during his years as a developer, he thought he might face resistance to a project, his solution was to knock down an existing structure as swiftly as possible, to avoid any intervention from architectural-preservationist types. In 1979, he bought the Art Deco Bonwit Teller building to clear space for Trump Tower. "They were trying to landmark the building when I bought it, and they never saw a building get ripped apart so fast," he has said. The exterior had been decorated with fifteen-foot-tall friezes, which Trump promised to donate to the Metropolitan Museum of Art. His contractors smashed them to pieces. Trump had estimated that saving the friezes would have cost around thirty thousand dollars. "I believed [they] were worth considerably less," he said. In the early eighties, Trump pushed his contractors to start demolition on several adjacent brownstones on the Upper East Side before they had a permit; it turned out that gas lines in the buildings were still active and could've caused an explosion. When he wanted to gut-renovate 100 Central Park South, it was eighty per cent occupied. With no legal standing to force tenants to leave, he turned off the heat and left their garbage out to rot. He suggested putting raw chickens in elevator shafts and moving homeless people into empty apartments.

Trump started construction on Trump Tower before the architectural plans were even complete. At community-board hearings, neighbors complained that the tower would be too tall and block too much light. The *Times* wrote that Trump had used "every trick in the book to maximize its size." He wanted to have the building finished in time to hold a grand-opening party in the tower's multistory atrium, which featured a sixty-foot waterfall, on Valentine's Day, 1983. "That atrium had to be put together with spit and glue," Barbara Res, Trump's longtime construction manager, wrote in

“Tower of Lies,” her memoir. “We didn’t know how long the waterfall could run without a stone or two falling down.”

Growing up in Queens, Trump would accompany his father, Fred, as he collected rent payments from tenants. But the son had grander ambitions. “I used to stand on the other side of the East River and look at Manhattan,” Trump has recalled. Fred introduced him to city leaders and lenders, and he began to learn how much he could get away with. Once, Trump offered to forfeit a \$4.4-million commission he was owed on a property if the city agreed to name it after his father. As officials prepared their response, they realized that the commission was worth nine times less. “I guess he just thought we would never read the fine print,” one said. Trump didn’t like to be told no. He was committed to having marble sinks in the bathrooms on Trump Shuttle, the airline that he bought in 1989—until others insisted it would make the planes too heavy. In his buildings, he didn’t want to have accessible bathrooms or Braille on the elevators. (“No blind people are going to live in this building,” he said of Trump Tower, according to Res.)

The city’s élites were appalled by Trump’s destruction of the Bonwit Teller. “I’ll never have the goodwill of the Establishment, the tastemakers of New York,” he later said. “They have never tried anything on the scale that I am trying things in this city.” He occasionally tells a story about attending the dedication ceremony for the Verrazzano-Narrows Bridge, in 1964, with his father. Robert Moses had spent decades working to build the bridge, which connected Brooklyn and Staten Island. During the ribbon-cutting ceremony, politicians arrived in their limos and, in Trump’s version of the event, were received with pomp and circumstance while the bridge’s designer stood alone and ignored. “All these politicians who opposed the bridge are being applauded,” Trump said, and the man “who poured his heart into it” is “just standing there in the rain.” It was something of a false memory: Moses had actually called the architect up to be recognized during the ceremony, which took place on a sunny day. “I realized then and there that if you let people treat you how they want, you’ll be made a fool,” Trump said. He was always on the lookout for slights, and defiant in the face of anyone who criticized him. “You can go ahead and speak to guys who have four-hundred-pound wives at home who are jealous of me,” he said in 2005. “But the guys who really know me know I’m a great builder.”

Last fall, Trump stood behind a lectern shaped like a golden eagle and told a crowd of dinner guests how much he liked building at the White House: “They said, ‘Sir, you can start tonight. . . . You have zero zoning conditions. You’re the President!’ I said, ‘You gotta be kidding me!’ ” He was addressing several dozen donors who had funded the ballroom. “So many of you have been really, really generous,” Trump said. The project had been budgeted at two hundred million dollars. (The expected cost has since tripled.) Instead of relying on Congress for the money, he solicited private contributions from companies including Nvidia and Lockheed Martin, many of which went on to win large government contracts for unrelated projects. According to court filings, Trump was “personally selecting the project’s contractors and handling details of their contracts, including amounts of payment; and telling people working on the project that they did not need to follow permitting, zoning, or code requirements because the structure was on White House grounds.” Witkoff told me, “He’s talking to the contractor and saying, ‘You got to deliver me a better number.’ He’s saying, ‘You can afford to give me a discount, because it’s for the American people.’ ”

Although Trump delighted in supervising the project directly, the judge in the National Trust case had ordered the Administration to submit plans to the federal bodies that would normally review them: the National Capital Planning Commission and the Commission of Fine Arts.

The N.C.P.C. is a twelve-person panel tasked by Congress with overseeing federal construction and development in D.C. It is the capital’s equivalent of a local planning board. Last summer, when Trump was looking for ways to fire Jerome Powell, the chair of the Federal Reserve, for not cutting interest rates, he started attacking Powell for supposedly mismanaging a renovation of the central bank’s historic headquarters. As President, Trump could appoint three of the N.C.P.C.’s members, so he fired Joe Biden’s appointees and installed replacements, including James Blair, then his deputy chief of staff, and Will Scharf, then his staff secretary, who became the head of the commission. At the new panel’s first meeting, the men tore into Powell’s renovation; one of them referred to it as an attempt to build “the Taj Mahal near the National Mall.”



“But, had there not been an apocalyptic flood and two of every species tasked with repopulating the earth, do you think we still end up together?”

Cartoon by Jason Adam Katzenstein

Before joining the Administration, Scharf was Trump’s personal lawyer. He was part of a team that successfully argued the January 6th case before the Supreme Court, which resulted in a ruling that Trump had broad immunity from prosecution for actions taken while in office. “The President doesn’t watch the whole commission meeting and critique me on the back end, the way he used to do with my TV hits,” Scharf told me. “But he stays involved.”

I met Scharf recently in his West Wing office. He joked that his appointment as N.C.P.C. chairman “in the technical Presidential scholarship would be called ‘ad-hoc-crazy.’ ” He told me, “There was a realization that a lot of what the Administration wanted to do was going to flow through N.C.P.C.” Staff secretaries manage and edit all the written material that ends up on the President’s desk, but Scharf had taken an unusually visible approach to the job. He frequently stood next to Trump in the Oval Office to present and explain executive orders to the press, looking over Trump’s shoulder as he signed them in Sharpie. Now, in addition to reviewing diplomatic documents or directives to shrink the federal government, Scharf would be considering garage-door design concepts and pulling all-nighters on Air Force One while studying façade improvements for Capital One Arena.

The N.C.P.C. sometimes conducts multiple reviews of a plan, and even modest projects that make it through can turn into drawn-out affairs. In Trump’s first term, a new White House tennis pavilion took nearly three years from start to finish. Scharf understood that that couldn’t be the case

here. “When President Trump decides to do something, he moves fast,” he told me. “With respect to the ballroom, this is something that the federal government could have been arguing about and attempting to plan and attempting to build for decades.”

Scharf insisted to me that, given his role at the N.C.P.C., he stays out of conversations about ballroom construction at the White House. But he and Trump find opportunities to discuss architecture in more general terms. “During our Middle East swing, we’re in this massive palace, and there are chandeliers everywhere,” Scharf told me. “Typically, at the base of the chandelier, where it connects to the ceiling, you have what he calls a medallion. He pointed out that the palace didn’t have medallions around its chandeliers. And, I hate to say it, but it looked cheaply built. The President’s, like, ‘They really messed this up.’ ”

On the day Scharf and I met, scaffolding was coming down around a pair of refurbished equestrian statues, newly coated in gold leaf, near the Lincoln Memorial. (“Wear sunglasses if you’re passing by them,” a D.C. theatre director told me.) In the afternoon, Trump gave a presentation in the Oval Office about his vision for a twenty-two-billion-dollar gilded redesign of Dulles Airport. “It’s incredible watching him think through construction problems,” Scharf said. “He is very good at building for a setting, and he has a keen sense of design. If you talk about aircraft carriers, he has a very firm view of what’s good and what’s bad—steam versus electromagnetic catapults, for instance. It’s the same with columns.” He went on, “Every President is going to come into this job with something they’ve done throughout their entire life.”

Representatives from the White House didn’t outline their plan for the ballroom to the N.C.P.C. until two and a half months after the East Wing was destroyed. On the day the plan was presented, the commission first had to review schematics for a new mesh enclosure for an Arabian-leopard habitat at the National Zoo. “Arabian leopards are excellent climbers and use trees to escape predators and scan their hunting territory,” a planner explained.

Experts and former commissioners had noted with alarm that the N.C.P.C. should have looked at plans for any exterior construction project at the

White House long before Trump tore down the existing structure. Scharf brushed off such concerns, insisting that the commission didn't have authority over demolition, only its opposite: "What we deal with is essentially construction, vertical build."

Part of the commission's responsibility is to preserve the historic sight lines of national landmarks. Shalom Baranes, a Washington architect who worked on renovations at the Treasury Building and the Pentagon, presented preliminary mockups of the ballroom—what one public letter, signed by dozens of architects urging Baranes to quit, had said would make the new structure "the tail wagging the dog" of the comparatively diminutive White House.

But without the ballroom, Scharf said, Trump would be forced to host King Charles "in a tent on the South Lawn with porta-potties." Blair, the deputy chief of staff, invoked history: "Winston Churchill said to the House of Commons, when they were going to rebuild it, that we shape our buildings and they shape us thereafter." Phil Mendelson, one of only a handful of commissioners who aren't Trump loyalists—he chairs the local D.C. Council—was disturbed by the extent to which the ballroom overwhelmed the original White House. "Maybe it can be and needs to be shrunk a little bit more," he said. "It's just so—it's just so imbalanced."

Later, members of the public were invited to weigh in, turning what was essentially a zoning meeting into a forum for irate D.C. residents and other critics to confront top Administration officials and express their discontent with the President. "The fix is in for this project," Jon Golinger, speaking on behalf of Public Citizen, a good-government advocacy group, said. He called for Trump's N.C.P.C. appointees "to answer today to the rest of the commission what they knew and when they knew it" and demanded that they resign. Two architects from Venezuela proposed that the project be modified to include an extrasensory "freedom dome" that would support "global and cosmic alignment and orientation with a universal energy network."

"It's the beauty of the public deliberative process," Scharf told me. "And, in the end, I think history's going to prove the President right."

As the commission moved toward a vote on the plan, there was a certain resignation among the ballroom skeptics, who knew that they were outnumbered. (Representatives from three executive agencies and the chairs of two congressional committees—all currently Republicans—serve alongside the Presidential appointees.) Paul Ingrassia, who was a lawyer for the accused sex traffickers Andrew and Tristan Tate before he was tapped to join the Trump Administration, said, “The White House shouldn’t be a static building. It should develop with the times, and I think this is a tribute to where the United States currently is positioned in terms of global leadership.”

Days before the vote, the judge in the National Trust suit had ordered Trump to stop construction on the ballroom to “avoid irreparable harm.” The President, he wrote, “is the steward of the White House for future generations of First Families. He is not, however, the owner!” Scharf reminded the N.C.P.C. members that the court’s opinion was irrelevant to their work. “We are not some sort of free-ranging ballroom-justice commission,” he said. They approved the design; Mendelson was the lone dissenter. Trump took to Truth Social to thank the commission. “He’s excited when we clear a hurdle, like any builder would be,” Scharf told me. Trump posted a photo of himself smiling outside the White House, where the “magnificent” ballroom was “now rising on this Hallowed Ground.”

Trump is hardly the first President to modify the White House. Franklin D. Roosevelt built an underground bunker, nearly tripled the size of the West Wing, and added a swimming pool. Harry S. Truman redid the whole interior and proposed a balcony for the South Portico, hoping that it might improve the “livability of the family quarters.” The Commission of Fine Arts, a seven-member council established by Congress that reviews all new public buildings in Washington, acting as a sort of aesthetic guardian, advised against the addition. Truman built it anyway.

Presidents have seldom interfered with the C.F.A., until recently. Biden fired most of Trump’s appointees when he took office, and last fall Trump fired Biden’s. Rodney Mims Cook, Jr., the new chair, is a longtime booster of classical architecture who shares Trump’s affinity for Corinthian columns. (Cook has mused about replacing the Ionic columns that currently

frame the White House with Corinthian ones, which are more decorative and ornate.) During Cook's first meeting as chair, he made clear how he would approach the ballroom. "This is an important thing to the President," he said. "The President is very focussed on world peace, and we need to let him go do that." Other commissioners include Chamberlain Harris, a twenty-six-year-old executive assistant to the President, and Roger Kimball, a conservative art critic, who has described Trump as a "Carlylean figure, an historic man of action."

In February, after just thirteen minutes of deliberation and despite not having a final design, the C.F.A. voted unanimously to approve the ballroom. Cook pointed out how much he liked the Corinthian columns on the exterior. "The committee has just become a rubber stamp for Trump," a former commissioner told me. "It's really sad."

But both the N.C.P.C. and the C.F.A. have insisted that a devotion to aesthetics and to history, not fealty to Trump, was their reason for moving the project forward. Scharf had often presented the ballroom as merely the latest chapter in a series of White House renovations that were met with overblown responses. "At every stage of its development, every new addition, including the initial construction of the White House, has been roundly criticized," he said. After George Washington and Thomas Jefferson announced a design competition for the mansion, in 1792, one observer complained that the winner, James Hoban, had submitted plans for a building that was "big enough for two emperors, one Pope and the grand Lama in the bargain." A decade later, when Jefferson took office, he added colonnades to expand it further. After the Eisenhower (or Old) Executive Office Building was built, in the late eighteen-hundreds, Mark Twain was said to have called it "the ugliest building in America."

Still, these undertakings, even if maligned for their hideousness, were "consistent and compatible with the fabric of what Washington and our central government is all about," Alan Hantman, a former head of the agency that maintains and operates the Capitol, told me. The ballroom designs now differ dramatically from what both commissions approved—recently submitted updates show the building with decorative lion heads, more gold, and an ornamental staircase. "Where the heck are these lions

coming from?” the former commissioner told me. “You could imagine a symbol of American democracy, like a bald eagle or a bison or something. The lion is associated with the British monarchy. I don’t usually curse, but this is a clusterfuck.”

The Trump Administration has argued that demolition is merely an act of upkeep. In a court hearing, Yaakov Roth, a Principal Deputy Assistant Attorney General, referred to a code authorizing Congress’s annual White House maintenance allowance, which covers things like repairs, alterations, refurnishing, and air-conditioning expenses. In recent years, that allowance has averaged around \$2.5 million. Since Trump returned, according to the *Washington Post*, eight hundred and seventy-five million dollars has been routed to the allowance account, which has funded the ballroom project. (Private donations make up three hundred million. The rest has come from various executive agencies.) At the hearing, Roth said, “We think ‘alteration and improvement’ are capacious enough terms to include improving, you know, replacing—”

“That’s a pretty expansive interpretation of the language,” the judge interjected. Later, he wrote, “Some might even view tearing down the White House and building a modern skyscraper in its place as an ‘improvement.’ ”

At the end of April, Trump attended the White House Correspondents’ Association dinner, which was held in a ballroom at the Washington Hilton. As the President sat down to eat with the press corps, a would-be assassin stormed through a security checkpoint before being subdued by the Secret Service. (He has pleaded not guilty.) “This is why we have to have all of the attributes of what we’re planning at the White House,” Trump said at a press conference immediately after the incident. His ballroom, he went on, is “actually a larger room, and it’s much more secure. It’s drone-proof, it’s bulletproof glass. We need the ballroom. That’s why Secret Service, that’s why the military are demanding it.”

The Administration’s legal filings had already pivoted from quoting historical accounts of White House modernization to arguing that the President’s life was at stake. Some of the language in the filings matched verbatim Trump’s Truth Social posts. A motion from April 27th, which

challenged the order to stop construction, contended that the National Trust is “very bad for our Country” and that “even their name is FAKE.” The Trust, it went on, suffers from “Trump Derangement Syndrome, commonly referred to as TDS,” and is represented “by the lawyer for Barack Hussein Obama.”

A senior official told me that the President was personally editing ballroom legal filings. Roth, the Deputy Assistant A.G., was asked about the motion at a dinner party attended by other Justice Department lawyers. “You mean the brief that Trump wrote?” he quipped. Roth’s name had disappeared from the case, typically a sign of disagreement or discomfort with the arguments being made. (Roth, who recently left the government, declined to comment.) “If any other President had the ability, foresight, or talents necessary, to build this ballroom, which will be one of the greatest, safest, and most secure structures of its kind anywhere in the World, there would never have been a lawsuit,” the motion read. It was only “because it is DONALD J. TRUMP, a highly successful real estate developer, who has abilities that others don’t.” The ballroom was a “gift to our Country from President Trump,” according to the brief. “Who,” its writer asked, “could ever object to that?”

Trump’s architectural ambitions extend beyond the White House. Last year, during an event in the Oval Office with the President of Finland, members of the press pool noticed a map of the National Mall on the Resolute Desk, showing plans for an arch opposite the Lincoln Memorial. Days later, at the dinner Trump hosted in the East Room for allies who had donated to the ballroom, the President told his guests that any leftover money from their generous donations might end up funding another project. Poster boards with renderings of an “Independence Arch” ringed the room, and he held up three scale models. “Small, medium, and large,” he said. “I happen to think the large looks by far the best. Why are you shocked to hear that?”

In April, 2025, in an article in the Claremont Institute’s online publication *The American Mind*, the architecture critic Catesby Leigh proposed constructing a monumental arch to commemorate the nation’s two-hundred-and-fiftieth birthday, noting that Washington is the “only major Western capital” without one. “There were more than 50 in ancient Rome,” he

wrote. Leigh recommended a temporary arch that would be sixty feet tall. (In 1789, Americans built temporary arches in their towns to greet George Washington as he travelled to New York for his Inauguration.)

Several Trump allies saw the article and thought that an arch might appeal to him. “The President loved the idea and ran with it,” Vince Haley, the head of the Domestic Policy Council, told me. As with the ballroom, the arch grew bigger and bigger. Trump more than quadrupled the height of Leigh’s proposal, and suggested that it become a permanent structure, of concrete wrapped in granite. It would be topped with a sixty-foot gold statue of Lady Liberty, wearing wings and flanked by gold eagles. “He understands that arches themselves are canvases for beautiful art and sculpture,” Haley said. “He sees this opportunity to have a grand narrative about the history of our country.” (According to the book “Regime Change,” by Maggie Haberman and Jonathan Swan, Trump considered topping the arch with a large statue of a fist, in homage to his “fight! fight! fight!” moment after the assassination attempt in Butler, Pennsylvania.)



“If you haven’t dined with us before, we do things a little differently.”
Cartoon by Riley Fanning

An aide researched arches around the world and prepared a flip book of fifty or so examples for Trump to look through. Trump selected an architect, Nicolas Charbonneau, whose design, in his own words, would frame the view of Arlington National Cemetery as the Renaissance painter “Master Raphael framed the heavens.” In fact, after Trump’s input, the arch would obscure the view of the cemetery, and of the Lincoln Memorial.

Trump tasked Haley with supervising the project. “There is nothing that competes with that,” Trump told him. Challenges quickly arose. The President has some leeway in renovating the White House, but the proposed arch is situated on a parcel of federal land in D.C.’s historic monumental core. “There’s a different set of hoops to jump through,” Haley told me. The construction site is directly beneath a flight path to Reagan National Airport, and large cranes might be less than two hundred feet from descending planes. Owing to constant construction noise, daily burials at the cemetery would no longer take place in silence.

In July, I walked into an N.C.P.C. meeting about the arch as protesters outside were singing and holding up posters: “You’re so vain, you probably think this arch is about you”; “Stop Arch Insanity.” Inside, Scharf argued that the Height of Buildings Act, a law that requires most buildings in the capital to stay under a hundred and thirty feet, shouldn’t apply to federal projects. (Two other laws governing the construction of new monuments were similarly inapplicable, the Administration has claimed.) Not letting Trump build as tall as he wants raises “sovereign-immunity issues,” Scharf said.

“Our skyline didn’t happen by accident,” one commissioner said.

When the arch came before the C.F.A., Burgum, the Interior Secretary, presented it as the culmination of a plan that had actually been in the works for a century. He referred to a 1924 proposal approved by Congress—but never carried out—to erect a pair of hundred-and-sixty-six-foot columns at the end of Arlington Memorial Bridge. Trump’s arch, he said, is simply “building on” that plan. It was approved. Cook, the chairman, had been yearning for an arch in Washington for decades. Around 1999, he proposed putting one along the west bank of the Anacostia River. He was fairly successful in getting funders and lawmakers on board, but enthusiasm for the project waned. He instead built one in his home town, Atlanta—a structure of around a hundred feet with a bronze temple on top. Cook actually thinks that Washington should have three arches. “President Trump loves the city,” he told me. “He has the same affliction, I guess you would call it, that I have. Washington is such a beautiful experiment, but it’s really incomplete.” This month, without N.C.P.C. approval, the Administration

announced that excavation for Trump's arch would begin. As Haley said to me, "Inertia and the collective maw of regulations can grind you to a halt."

As a child, Trump would go into Manhattan from Queens to see the Empire State Building, which at the time was the world's tallest. The Sears Tower, in Chicago, later took the record, which Trump decided he wanted to bring back to New York. "I loved the challenge," he wrote. In 1974, when the city's real-estate market was in a slump, Trump bought an undeveloped parcel of rail yard on the West Side in a bankruptcy sale. It was his first major deal in Manhattan. "I saw the city's trouble as a great opportunity for me," he wrote. Eventually, he announced that he would construct a hundred-and-fifty-story building, the world's tallest, on the parcel, part of a "city-within-a-city." He would move a portion of the West Side Highway for the project, which he called Trump City.

For a while, it looked like the flagship building might actually get built. "Donald Trump, at thirty nine, was literally about to reach the sky," Wayne Barrett, a longtime Trump chronicler at the *Village Voice*, wrote. Trump would later say, of his proposed skyscraper, that it "made no sense to try to create something that blended into the surrounding community." Instead, it should overpower it. The building would have cast shadows over New Jersey and all the way up to Ninety-sixth Street. As the *Times* editorial board put it at the time, the development was his "bid for immortality."

But Mayor Ed Koch wouldn't give him the special tax and zoning concessions he'd hoped for, and West Siders hated the plan. No matter how much maneuvering Trump did, the site sat vacant. He always hoped to one day avenge that failure. "My time," he insisted at the end of his book "The Art of the Deal," "will come." He kept looking for ways to cast himself as a hero of the built environment. In the eighties, he renovated Wollman Rink, in Central Park, stepping in after years of stalled efforts by the city. He started pitching himself for other large-scale civic projects far beyond his abilities, like redoing the Williamsburg Bridge.

Now it is Washington's turn. "The great civilizations of history did not wallow in aging ruins of the past," Trump said this summer, during a rally on the National Mall. He proposed creating a ten-billion-dollar fund for "beautification projects" around the city, which he had always complained

was a “cesspool.” He had the National Park Service flush sediment out of dormant waterlines in Meridian Hill Park so that a fountain there could be turned on for the first time in years. He plans to construct a pedestrian bridge from the Lincoln Memorial to the Potomac River. (“They want to call it the Trump Promenade,” he has said.) He wants to build a Garden of American Heroes, which will include sculptures of two hundred and fifty important Americans—Henry David Thoreau, Alex Trebek—on waterfront parkland, and he insured that the Big Beautiful Bill allocated forty million dollars for the project.

Trump is no longer stymied by the forces that held him back in his early days. “In New York, he was only the developer, pushing up as hard and as cleverly and deviously as he could against the various obstacles and making his way around them,” the person who knew him in New York told me. In D.C., “he’s the mayor, the planning commission, and the lending institution all together. He’s basically on every side of the table.” He often awards no-bid contracts, and handpicks the inspectors general tasked with overseeing them. If a project falters, he finds ways to shift the blame: when the paint job on the Reflecting Pool started to peel, he ordered Jeanine Pirro, the U.S. Attorney in D.C., to prosecute visitors for vandalism.

Paolo Zampolli, a former modelling scout who is now Trump’s special envoy for global partnerships, told me that the President is just trying to give D.C. “a facelift.” We were sitting near a large fan in his Dupont Circle row house. The air-conditioning was broken, and the Tate brothers were mingling upstairs with a handful of diplomats and Administration officials. “The city has so much potential, but the marble is crumbling,” Zampolli said, dabbing sweat from his face with a handkerchief. Last year, Trump purged the board of the John F. Kennedy Center for the Performing Arts and named himself chairman, embarking on a series of renovations that included putting his name, in bronze letters, on the front of the building. Zampolli is one of the new board members. He imagined an Italian Riviera on the banks of the Potomac, with a Cipriani restaurant atop the redone Kennedy Center.

Meanwhile, the General Services Administration had listed a number of historic federal buildings for sale, part of an effort to “revitalize” D.C.’s

downtown. “We know we have prime real estate,” Zampolli told me. Some of the buildings that the G.S.A. has tried to off-load are historically significant: the Wilbur J. Cohen Federal Building, for example, is referred to as the “Sistine Chapel of the New Deal” because of its mid-century murals. Zampolli wanted it and other buildings like it condemned or vacated, and replaced. He didn’t see why D.C. had to be so dowdy—or even look like D.C. at all. “I wouldn’t mind seeing some beautiful skyscrapers next to Capitol Hill,” he said. “I wouldn’t block the view of the Capitol, but some skyscrapers, the higher you go, the more beautiful it is.” Zampolli pulled out his phone to show me a slide show with designs for a proposed overhaul of the city’s southwest quadrant. The working title was Trump City.

A few weeks later, Trump ordered dozens of trees, including a historic cherry-blossom tree, to be removed from East Potomac Park, so that construction could begin on the golf course he plans to overhaul there. Trump and Burgum had already been out to scout it. For years, the nonprofit National Links Trust has run the course, charging forty-two dollars for eighteen holes; Trump, per a spokeswoman, wants to bring “glamour and prestige” to the place. “This is what he does,” Witkoff told me. “The President is intent on making Washington, the capital of the country, a better city.” Trump, he posited, could govern via real estate all over the world, from Ukraine to the Middle East. When it was time to come up with a rehabilitation plan for Gaza, Witkoff said, Trump “really wanted to be intimately involved in it. He had done many master plans in his life. He wanted to understand, with all the bombs that were dropped there, how we were going to demolish. He wanted to bring his insight, his creative sensibility, and say, ‘How are we going to do this to make it really special, so that when people come back they’re living in a special place?’ ”

Late in August, Trump left the White House in Marine One, and the helicopter circled twice before departing, allowing him to take in the construction sites from above. Nearby, his Commerce Secretary, Howard Lutnick, was giving a press conference outside a D.C. courthouse, where a judge was weighing a challenge to Trump’s effort to put his name on the Kennedy Center. The Administration’s lawyers argued that if Trump’s renovation plans kept getting blocked they might have no choice but to

demolish it. “What do you want the guy to do?” Lutnick said. “He’s only the President for two and a half years.”

Trump isn’t the only one who can knock things down. “Life is a series of battles ending in victory or defeat,” he told *Forbes* in 1982. At the time, he was building an Atlantic City casino that he went on to name the Trump Plaza. It debuted to great fanfare; at the opening, he walked through the lobby with Michael Jackson, who sang next to him. By 2021, his casino had languished for years, empty and in disrepair. It was dynamited to clear the boardwalk for a new venture. “Have you ever heard a President talk about beauty so much?” the senior official said. He compared Trump to Ozymandias and Louis XIV. “Beauty is so bound up with power. But remember what Napoleon’s mother said at his coronation: ‘Let’s hope it lasts.’ ” ♦

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How Hermès Unharnessed Fashion

Under the stewardship of Nadège Vanhée, the artistic director of women's wear, a house known for craftsmanship is exploring the risqué.

By [Lauren Collins](#) Photography by [Jet Swan](#)

September 7, 2026



A patinated leather miniskirt from the Fall/Winter 2026 collection. Styling by Claudia Sinclair; Set Design by Rachel Thomas; Hair by Claire Grech; Makeup by Anne Sophie Costa; Makeup for Vanhée by Lynsey Alexander; Manicure by Ami Rai; Production by Mini Title

The light, the light. It was all anybody could talk about—the soft, weightless Los Angeles light, melting between the columns of an open-air pavilion, which was perched on a hilltop above Bel Air, and painted a highly specific shade of pale yellow that made several hundred assembled guests appear as though they were standing in the middle of a banana cream pie. The structure resembled a Greek temple and was as big as a mansion. It had been purpose-built by Hermès, the French luxury-goods company, at unimaginable cost. Tomorrow it would all come down. But, for one June evening, the sun was streaking the horizon, and a fashion show was about to start.

The sound of drumbeats filled the pavilion. The first model emerged onto a sinuous runway in a nubuck coat paired with chiffon pants that fluttered in the breeze, revealing knee-high calfskin boots. The outfit matched the pale

yellow of the venue but upheld the Hermès aesthetic of discreet, horsey timelessness. So when the next model came out, also wearing shades of margarine and lemon, it took a moment to register that her look—a skintight, bell-bottomed catsuit covered in blinking sequins—represented a deviation from, if not a challenge to, the Hermès ideal. Hermès does not employ celebrity ambassadors, as most other major luxury brands do, but, perhaps in a nod to the setting, the evening’s front row was a touch starrier than usual. Miley Cyrus, open-mouthed, nudged Kerry Washington as the woman in spangles swept by—this was red-carpet clothing, flashbulb clothing, clothing to be seen in once rather than excavated annually from a closet of perennials. Nadège Vanhée, the artistic director of Hermès women’s wear since 2014, described the event’s conceit to me as “How do I create a conversation between the mystique of a French fashion house talking about horse carriages and the spirit of Los Angeles, which is rewind, erase, restart?”

Thierry Hermès, an Alsatian-born harness-maker, founded Hermès in 1837. (Pronunciation hint: “air mess.”) Over nearly two centuries in trade, the company has dealt in germinal francs, Poincaré francs, de Gaulle francs, and euros, always remaining family-owned. The current C.E.O., Thierry’s great-great-great-grandson Axel Dumas, presides over an empire of sixteen *métiers*, as the divisions are known in the house lexicon, including everything from saddlery, gloves, and belts to timepieces and tableware. Many people know Hermès for its intricately printed silk scarves (Grace Kelly once used one as a sling) and for its savagely coveted Birkin bags (whose rate of appreciation is said to outperform the S. & P. 500). The latter have inspired so many knockoffs that Judge Judy once devoted an episode of her show to a Birkin-counterfeiting scam, marvelling, “*Twenny-nine hundrud dollas for a pockabook!*”



Vanhée is interested in “clothes that could be associated with shame, like the bra or the harness.”

These days, that would be a bargain, as even the most modest models cost five times as much. Hermès is worth an estimated hundred and ninety billion dollars, making it the second most valuable luxury-goods firm in the world. Last year, it briefly overtook the front-runner, L.V.M.H.—the slick conglomerate behind the likes of Louis Vuitton and Dior—its eternal nemesis and spiritual foil.

In the capricious luxury sector, Hermès has a reputation for steady thinking. Protestants in a traditionally Catholic country, the family—now a tripartite mishmash of Dumases, Guerrands, and Pueches, owing to a surfeit of daughters at the end of the nineteenth century—is known for avoiding debt and investing for the long term. Its bags inspire a fevered economy of influencers, resalers, and aspiring buyers, thanks, in large part, to the company’s choice to keep supply diabolically low. Hermès positions itself above the melee, as a guardian of tasteful continuity. According to one former executive, the family sees money “merely as a means, especially for

buying time,” and, according to one relative, “moral elegance” is considered a job requirement at Hermès. In 2016, at a benefit auction, Jeffrey Epstein placed the winning bid on an internship at Hermès; the company withdrew the lot and reimbursed the charity. Dumas later explained that the last thing Hermès needed was to get involved with a “louche financier.”

Hermès is a sporty house, but it is also the wonkiest house. The company employs a paleographer, for deciphering handwriting in old company correspondence, and maintains a collection of leather-bound ledgers containing the specs of every saddle made from 1900 to today. The first sixteen pages of last year’s annual report consisted of a cartoon about a globe-trotting Pegasus. It would be difficult to find another luxury brand that promoted an employee from sewing bags to designing them after he submitted a plea written entirely in Alexandrines. But Hermès did, and it is still producing that designer’s first creation, from 2002: the Picotin, inspired by feedbags. Suckers for a touch of whimsy, the company’s window dressers once garnished a display inspired by the Garde Républicaine, a famous French cavalry division, with a pile of horse manure. Such is the Hermès commitment to authenticity that the poop was sourced directly from the unit.

The company’s twin values of work and quirk can sit uneasily in the distractible, self-serious fashion world, to the point that fashion at Hermès has historically been regarded as something of an oxymoron. Unlike its competitors, Hermès is a pre-haute-couture enterprise, founded before the rigid bureaucracy of French fashion was put into place, in the eighties, with the establishment of a governing syndicate. Emilie Hammen, the director of the Palais Galliera fashion museum, explained that, as a result, the company “has never felt a need to prove itself within this framework.” Hermès tends to express itself through craft rather than through novelty. “I’m not doing fashion,” Véronique Nichanian, who designed menswear at Hermès for more than three decades, told *GQ*, in 2021, preferring to call her creations “clothes-objects.” The house is, in many respects, the antithesis of the kind of fashion described in Miranda Priestly’s famous cerulean speech, from “The Devil Wears Prada”: unlike its bags, whose imitators include Walmart’s seventy-eight-dollar Wirkin,

Hermès's clothes have traditionally trickled down nowhere, influencing no one. You will certainly not find an “equestrian gilet dress in satin-gray plongé ostrich” hanging on the racks at Target next year just because Hermès sent one down the runway.

Yet, under the stewardship of Vanhée, fashion is an increasingly important venture for Hermès. Internally, the division has grown by forty-four per cent since 2022, accounting for more than a quarter of the sixteen billion dollars in revenue that the company reported last year, and Hermès's cultural influence is likewise on the rise. Lauren Sherman, the fashion reporter for *Puck*, wrote admiringly of the L.A. show, “This was the most Vanhée has ever inserted herself into the broader fashion conversation, which you don't really have to do at Hermès.” A friend of mine who works in the industry was recently raving about a pair of stretchy, high-waisted black pants designed by Vanhée that she said insouciantly bundled together several desirable codes: equestrian, prep, surf, S & M. She continued, “You can wear them with literally anything and look like a sexy luxury bitch.” The writer and filmmaker Miranda July, who attended the show in L.A. wearing a blue turtleneck under a black leather Hermès overalls minidress, told me, “It's kind of crazy that she's making clothes for such wealthy people that are so sensuous and kinky. It's for flesh—for beating skin with blood under it.”



"I'm glad we've seen it, but it's hard to get excited about something I can't eat."

Cartoon by Tom Chitty

Vanhée doesn't fit the obvious profile of a provocatrice. The first time I met her, this past spring, she was reading an essay by the French sociologist Nathalie Heinich about "visibility capital" and the economics of being seen. She likes Austrian spas and Jon Fosse novels. The tech executive Charles Porch, a close friend of Vanhée's, told me, "She's really nerdy, in the best way possible." She dislikes digital mood boards, so much that she forbids her designers to use them, and she has zero presence on social media, which she dismissed as "kind of a sad-girl thing." Her inspirations for another recent show included the fashion photographer Deborah Turbeville and the Greek goddess Hecate.

In Los Angeles, the sexy luxury bitches continued down the runway. The most persuasive dialogue between French pedigree and Californian freedom came in the form of a pair of short jackets, one in calfskin and one in goatskin, featuring motifs, realized in complicated leather marquetry, that equally recalled the Longchamp racecourse and the Wild West. After a series of slouchy suits and bustier dresses in turquoise and scarlet silks, the show exploded to black, culminating in a series of bravado gowns. A two-piece set featured palazzo trousers trailing a nimbus of silk and a stomach-baring bandeau top cinched with a leather belt at the bust. Vanhée has said that she thinks of leather as the conscious and silk as the subconscious, the former structuring and the latter flowing—this look, then, was integration, fusing the banker's accessory with the sexpot's attitude.

Vanhée emerged from backstage at the end of the show in red trousers, a red top, a caramel-colored leather bomber, and a pair of yellow-and-black La Sportiva trail-running sneakers that she wears everywhere, maybe to offset all those hides and tulles. Because she is indifferent to self-mythologizing and thinks intently about what she says—and perhaps also because, physically, she corresponds to some people's idea of a melancholic Pre-Raphaelite maiden—she has often been characterized as "an enigma" or "mysterious," or even "cold-blooded." The more straightforward reality is that she is someone with a healthy sense of priorities, who considers it more radical to act as a steward than to play the renegade, even if she prefers to do a little bit of both. "My work isn't my personal diary," she told me

matter-of-factly. “As a creative, I want to give a certain orientation, but to work at Hermès is also to be of service.” She is, in other words, the anti-auteur—a mature, cerebral mortal to fashion’s babbling gods and kings. Free of undue pressure from her bosses or the public, from above or from below, she may be the last fashion designer un beholden to the comments section.

The company’s historic seat in Paris’s Eighth Arrondissement, 24 Rue Faubourg Saint-Honoré, is central to the mythology of Hermès. In 2019, the company released the first versions of a bag it calls the Faubourg Birkin, which depicts the building’s arch-windowed façade in different conditions—day, night, rain, midnight. (A rare snow edition, made of alligator skin, recently sold for some four hundred thousand dollars at a private sale.) A few years later, Hermès commissioned the journalist and filmmaker Frédéric Laffont to write a book about the headquarters. After months of hanging around the labyrinthine premises—going up and down “the red staircase,” which is red, and “the green staircase,” which is also red—Laffont came away thinking that Hermès resembled a cult, or a tribe, with its own grammar, rites, and totems. Pascale Mussard, a sixth-generation family member, recalling the all-night Christmas celebrations she attended at the headquarters as a girl, during which each worker’s child would receive gingerbread and an orange, reached for another metaphor: “It was like the village of the Smurfs.”

Charles-Émile Hermès, the founder’s son, moved the company to 24 Faubourg in 1880. Baron Haussmann, making way for the boulevards, had demolished the original headquarters, near La Madeleine, and Charles-Émile wanted the company, which specialized in saddlery at the time, to be closer to the Élysée Palace, with its great stables and tony crowd. By the turn of the twentieth century, the area counted some forty *maisons du cheval*, including riding schools and makers of saddles, harnesses, and carriages. With Charles-Émile’s sons, Émile and Adolphe, at the helm, the company became the area’s star tenant, furnishing saddles to a Continental élite, including Nicholas II, the Tsar of Russia. Émile’s leatherworkers often married Jeanne Lanvin’s seamstresses, who were confecting gowns for society women just across the way.

A photograph from the era shows Émile's four daughters, in braided buns and white drop-waist dresses, posing with an iron rocking horse that still sits in his former office at 24 Faubourg. In July, Menehould de Bazelaire du Chatelle, who was Hermès's artistic director of cultural patrimony until her recent retirement, welcomed me into Émile's lair, which has been lovingly preserved as a private museum. The place teemed with treasure: a samurai's coral-studded stirrup, a miniature game of dominoes that could be worn as a pendant, a cane whose head popped open to reveal a mustache brush and a pick for gathering wild mushrooms. Bits and bridles filled every corner, giving the place the feel of the world's poshest Cracker Barrel. A shelf held dozens of obscure cookbooks, which Hermès scarf designers can consult for gastronomy-themed prints. There was a nineteenth-century praxinoscope that recalled the magic lantern from Marcel Proust's "In Search of Lost Time."

"Émile and Proust were born in the same year," de Bazelaire du Chatelle told me. "Proust said he built his book the way a couturier constructs a dress."

It was touching to hear her speak about the long-dead men as though they were her intimate friends, two neighborhood guys frequenting the same haunts in an eternal Belle Époque. Hermès is a luxury-goods company, but it operates a bit like a farm or a vineyard, rooting itself in a sense of place. "We are peasants of the city, and twice a year we have our own crop," a family elder once told Axel Dumas. Part of the brand's appeal is that even its placemats and wristwatches seem imbued with terroir.

The First World War changed everything for everyone, but Hermès faced a double problem: in addition to decimating its workforce and its clientele, the conflict clarified the need to transform the business. In 1914, the French government had sent Émile to the Americas to requisition horses and cavalry equipment. He came back talking about cars, having witnessed Henry Ford's assembly lines in Detroit. Émile chose not to modernize his company's way of working—one man, one saddle—but it was clear to him that the automobile owned the future. Soon, some eighty thousand horses had disappeared from a capital newly thrumming with Citroën Type As. Company legend holds that a pair of veterans appeared at 24 Faubourg: one

had lost his left hand and the other his right, so they went Dutch on a single pair of gloves.

Émile could have folded the company, but he had an idea. On his requisitioning tour, he'd observed another newfangled creation fastening the cloth top of a Cadillac convertible—the zipper, which he introduced to France in 1922, having obtained the patent to the invention in the country. The next year, Hermès launched the Bolide, thought to be the first handbag to use a zip closure. Émile continued to diversify. In 1937, Hermès debuted a silk scarf, depicting horse-drawn omnibuses inspired by a popular board game. When the Second World War broke out, Hermès was not existentially threatened. With less money to spend on clothes, clients gravitated toward more affordable accessories; silk became difficult to obtain, so the company released rayon scarves. Perhaps the most lasting consequence of the war years occurred when the manufacturer that supplied Hermès with mustard-colored bags and boxes ran out of paper, forcing the company to switch to a bright-orange hue. Hermès embraced the shade as its signature, to the point that, years later, when Eric Clapton custom-ordered a crocodile-skin guitar case, it arrived in an enormous orange box in the shape of a Martin 000-28EC.

The business podcast “Acquired” has described Hermès’s strategy as “the opposite of everything you learned in Econ 101.” The company maintains a scarce supply of its handbags on the ground that it’s impossible to expand production without decreasing quality. Competing luxury brands have wildly increased the prices of their bags in recent years—a Chanel classic flap bag that cost fifty-eight hundred dollars in 2019 cost ten thousand eight hundred dollars by 2024—but Hermès has taken a relatively restrained approach, with hikes at several percentage points less than the rate of inflation. Even when outsourcing could provide opportunities or economies, the company is maniacally focussed on controlling all aspects of the process. It doesn’t sell sunglasses, for example, because it would have to subcontract the manufacturing of the lenses. Parts of the belts and ties are sewn by machine, but artisans, many of them trained in schools established by Hermès, still saddle stitch leather goods by hand and screen-print scarves using up to forty-nine separate screens per scarf from an archive of more than seventy-five thousand proprietary colors. (By superstitious

tradition, an Hermès scarf never features a knife or a sword—anything that is not “nice” to the neck.) Vanhée’s pride in her team’s impractical craftsmanship was evident during a rehearsal for the L.A. show, at a studio in Culver City, as we walked by a leatherworker molding the shoulders of a dress with a hammer and a marble plate he’d brought all the way from Paris. Vanhée said, “You only see that chez Hermès, eh?”

Eccentricities aside, Hermès is capable of acting with steely discipline when necessary. In 2010, Bernard Arnault, the chairman of L.V.M.H., called Bertrand Puech, then the chairman of Hermès’s supervisory board. Arnault told Puech that he had managed to accumulate a 14.2-per-cent stake in Hermès and would be announcing this to the media in two hours. Hermès executives and family members hadn’t had a clue. (Arnault, who eventually acquired a twenty-three-per-cent stake, was later fined for failing to make mandatory disclosures.) The C.E.O. at the time, Patrick Thomas—not a family member, it should be noted—indelicate­ly conveyed his sense of shock, telling reporters, “If you want to seduce a beautiful woman, you don’t start by raping her from behind.” Business bros still recount what happened next with the kind of awe usually reserved for events like the siege of Stalingrad: in a remarkable show of unity, more than fifty family members banded together to form a holding company, fighting off the possibility of a takeover by pledging not to sell some 50.2 per cent of the company’s stock for twenty years.

Hermès’s symbolic capital was on display at this summer’s World Cup. The tournament basically doubled as an Hermès fanboy convention, with players such as Ousmane Dembélé, Lamine Yamal, and Erling Haaland showing off their bag collections as they shuttled between matches. According to one estimate, Haaland, Norway’s star striker, helped generate nine million dollars in brand value by carrying rare specimens such as an Haut à Courroies (*HAC*) Endless Road, featuring palladium hardware and a patchwork vista inspired by David Hockney landscapes. The Birkin, above all other models, has become a vessel for popular culture, name-checked by *Real Housewives* and *A\$AP Rocky* alike. The singer Drake is not married, but, a few years ago, he admitted that he’d started collecting Birkins for his future wife.

The Birkin dates to 1984, when Jean-Louis Dumas, the executive chairman of Hermès at the time, boarded a flight and encountered the famously basket-carrying actress Jane Birkin, who complained that she could really use a bag big enough to hold both scripts and diapers. Dumas mocked up a sketch on the spot, and the Birkin was born—a squarish satchel with top handles and a trim leather belt to hold down the flap, although, according to *Connecticut Luxury* magazine, many owners prefer to leave their bags open, in imitation of Jane herself. Her original Birkin (which sold last year at Sotheby’s for some ten million dollars) was black, but diehards today compete for models like the Himalaya, made in white-and-gray crocodile skin that supposedly mimics snowcapped mountains, and any bag in such colors as Rose Confetti or 5P Bubblegum Pink; the latter is said to have a “near-mythical” status among connoisseurs.



“Milo is quite advanced—he’s already procrastinating at a fifth-grade level.”
Cartoon by Sophia Glock

The *Financial Times* has compared the hype that surrounds the bags to the tulipomania that seized seventeenth-century Holland. Both the Birkin and the smaller but nearly as coveted Kelly—created in the nineteen-thirties but popularized by Grace Kelly, who used it to camouflage her pregnancy in the fifties—are known in fan circles as “quota bags.” Hermès decides who gets them and who doesn’t, refusing to sell them online and tightly controlling their availability in boutiques. Because of the bags’ popularity, Hermès has developed an unusual relationship with some of its clients, who ask not only what Hermès can do for them but what they can do for Hermès. At the L.A.

show, I met a pair of young women named Brittany Kane and Andrea Henderson, D.M.D. and D.D.S., respectively. (“We love dentistry and we love fashion,” Kane told me.) Henderson explained later that “you don’t go into the Hermès store and ask for a Birkin” off the bat, adding that she’d broached the topic only after paying her respects by buying jewelry and shoes. This works for some people but apparently not for others. In 2024, three customers filed a class-action lawsuit alleging that Hermès uses the promise of handbags to induce people to buy teacups and trinkets and seven-thousand-dollar wastepaper baskets, all the while knowing that many of them “will not in fact get a Birkin bag.” The suit was dismissed. Hermès told me, “Under no circumstances is the sale of a product conditional upon the purchase of another.”

The “Hermès game,” as it’s known, has spawned an entire repellent vocabulary. The ancillary purchases, for example, are euphemized among shoppers as “pre-spend” or “Birkin bait,” and tales circulate of aspirants attempting to curry favor with sales associates, or “S.A.s,” by offering cash and trips on private jets. In order to justify the expenditure, or perhaps the humiliation of having to beg for the privilege of parting with their money in a public store, some participants tend to treat what is realistically a one-way capitalistic transaction as some sort of bilateral spiritual quest. Reddit abounds with threads such as “What was your journey to a Special Order?” (A “special order” allows a client to customize her bag.) One lucky buyer replied, “In my case, I think my SA felt that I had enough neutral bags (two Birkins, an Evelyne, a KTG) that it was time for me to go through a special order to get a bag unique enough for me.” Drafting on Hermès’s cachet, a New York City plastic surgeon recently began providing a package of procedures for new moms known as the Birkin Body—lipo, a tummy tuck, breast surgery, and a butt lift.

All this rapacious consumerism sits somewhat awkwardly alongside Hermès’s image of Old World gentility. You can see why the company would want to move further into fashion and other retail categories, hedging its bets as leather goods, traditionally its most profitable division, risks overexposure. Hermès deals nonchalantly with the discordance. When I asked Vanhée about the bag-unboxing videos that proliferate on Instagram, she quickly dismissed the topic, saying, “Isn’t that old?” The company

does, though, sell a scarf called Tulipomanie, covered in frilly blooms of an exquisiteness that seems to rebut the charge of excess hype with a wink.



Hermès artisans still saddle stitch leather goods by hand and screen-print scarves using an archive of more than seventy-five thousand proprietary colors.

Hermès has long employed superior designers, including, in recent decades, Martin Margiela, Jean Paul Gaultier, and Christophe Lemaire. Vanhée fits easily into a lineage of potent minimalism (Margiela and Lemaire) and sly subversion (Gaultier), but, unlike her predecessors, who continued to work on their own lines, she has devoted herself entirely to Hermès. Also, it must be said, she is not a man. “What really sets her apart is that there’s a sense of interiority and psychology and even autobiography to many of her collections,” CNN’s senior style reporter, Rachel Tashjian, said. “You can see what she’s thinking about and feeling, or you *wonder* what she’s thinking about and feeling.” The artist and director Alex Prager told me, “When you look at her characters, you can imagine a whole life for them.”

By the time Hermès recruited Vanhée, she had an impeccable résumé: the Royal Academy of Fine Arts Antwerp, the Institut Français de la Mode, Margiela, Phoebe Philo's Celine. She had just finished a three-year stint as the design director at the Row, Mary-Kate and Ashley Olsen's brand, known for making unsurpassable basics at outrageous prices. Vanhée recalled, of her time there, "They had confidence, but what I think I gave them was a strong spine, and I encouraged them to be even more who they are, to push the American elegance of the brand further."

The aura of regimented cool that Vanhée created at the Row caught the attention of Hermès executives. When the call came from Axel Dumas's office, she was in the middle of a hiking trip in Okinawa. "I was wearing this beautiful brand from the West Coast of America which is called Patagonia," she joked. "Total look Patagonia. All I had was a little duffelbag." Dumas summoned her to Paris, but she had nothing appropriate to wear. "Of course, big drama," Vanhée recalled. "What do I do? I'm a pretty tall girl. It's Japan." She ended up with a navy-blue suit from the men's department at Comme des Garçons. "And then I went with some classic loafers, because I was a wild animal!" she said. When she finally made it to 24 Faubourg, she sat down and started talking about Plato's cave. Dumas, who has a degree in philosophy, was impressed. Upon hiring her, the only brief he gave was that he be "pleasantly surprised."

Vanhée was born in 1978 in Seclin, a small town near Lille. Her father was a doctor, a French Catholic who had lived in Morocco before moving to Algeria, where he met her mother, a Muslim nurse from Constantine. As Vanhée's birth approached, the expecting couple decided that the baby should be born in France, so they went to Seclin, where she had relatives living—"Voilà," Vanhée told me. Soon, the family was back in Algeria, living in Algiers. "I spent my first two years there," Vanhée recalled. "And after that we moved back, and there was a certain melancholy, because, *bon*, when you go from those beautiful white views, it takes time to love the North of France."

Vanhée was a studious child. She thought that she might like to be an archeologist, until, as a teen-ager, she started contributing music reviews of indie bands such as Placebo and Moloko to a zine. Fandom led to flea

markets, which led to a curiosity about fashion. She began taking apart the garments she bought and sewing her own. Sure, she dyed her hair black and wore it half-punk, half-goth style, but the classic fashion narrative of the yearning provincial outsider, slaving over *Vogue* spreads and dreaming of urban glamour, holds little resonance for her. Fashion was “a hyper-repressed desire”—something to admire, maybe, but not to join or conquer. “I had as much cultural stimulation there as I do in a big city like Paris,” Vanhée said of Seclin one day at the Hermès atelier, proffering a dark-chocolate-covered speculoos cookie, a favorite northern delicacy.

Designing clothes at Hermès isn’t the easiest job. In addition to fashion’s historically muted role at the brand, there is the simple fact that an Hermès designer must use a lot of leather, to honor the house’s equestrian heritage, but that, if the looks get too leathery, they can easily veer toward barnyard or bordello. The Birkin and the Kelly have been around for decades and look much the same as they ever did, but a fashion designer at Hermès has to think about freshness as much as function and form. “Don’t be too much of a creator, and don’t be too much of a traditionalist,” one house motto goes. Vanhée handled that dilemma confidently in her first collection, for the Fall 2015 season. Even if the looks could be uneven, ranging from a sublime pair of blue-black lambskin dungarees to a frumpy quilted parka with saddlebag-like pockets, the collection was received warmly, with *Vogue* calling it “a respectful journey around the house.” Vanhée told the *Telegraph* that year, “I don’t think a garment needs three sleeves to be experimental.”

In the seasons that followed, Vanhée mostly stuck to making incomparably crafted, gimmick-free, calmly intelligent clothes. They performed well with customers, but detractors suggested that she was uninspired, dismissing her as “Nabeige.” The idea that Vanhée’s work was dull or overly conservative sprang, in part, from her tenure at the Row, which is often credited with launching the “quiet luxury” trend of monochrome wearable pabulum for a public obsessed with projecting good taste. Still, in her early years at Hermès, she was crucified on the rare occasions when she attempted something different. In 2017, she showed boho vests and plaid trousers to criticism that, as the Business of Fashion put it, her “remarkable clarity and sense of intent had gone completely AWOL this season.”

Vanhée loathes the phrase “quiet luxury” and seems exasperated by the association. She emphatically rejects the idea that she was ever “playing it safe.” What some people see as “boring as hell,” she said, is “delicacy and structure” done to an extremely high standard. One season, she sent models down the runway in rigorously cut leathers and then made it rain, dumping droplets from the ceiling. Tashjian, the style reporter, told me, of Vanhée’s designs, “I have moments where I feel like I’m eating at one of those fussy restaurants where everything is square, but there’s something punk in that she just does whatever she wants.” She added, of the rain stunt, “It was so aggressive and sensual and then just completely arrogant, these extravagantly expensive clothes in a downpour.”



A dress from Fall/Winter 2023 of plissé hammered metallic silk.

Sometime around the pandemic, Vanhée’s clothes got perceptibly more outspoken. “Hedonism just upended the classy, even classic, austerity that seemed to be Vanhée-Cybulski’s signature,” the French newspaper *Libération* wrote delightedly, in 2021, reviewing a show that featured crop tops, peekaboo bralettes, and snatches of strategically exposed skin.

Vanhée-Cybulski was Vanhée's married name. Gossips contend that the transformation in her designs coincided with her divorce from Peter Cybulski, an English art gallerist with whom she has a young daughter. "That's sexist, and it's not true," Vanhée told me. In fact, she insists, she's been exploring notions of feminine desire for years. ("I still believe the Hermès woman is seen as a vestal," she told *W*, in 2019, vowing to spice up that image.) Max Pearmain, a stylist who often works with Vanhée, told me that, almost every season, she "homes in on an erogenous zone and tries to push that within the silhouette." In Los Angeles, the focus was the hip, which she accentuated with a series of leather peplums, creative belting, and nipped-waist overcoats. One of her best collections, for Spring 2026, was devoted to the bust, with almost every model donning a sort of "neo-harness" that the fashion magazine *Numéro* deemed "the must-have accessory of the season." Vanhée showed the harness with vibrant *indiennes* prints inspired by Provençal folk costumes, suggesting a rooted, anti-porn idea of eroticism. Sex appeal, too, can have terroir.

There may be some practical considerations at play in the bombshellification of the Hermès woman. Peter Malachi, a communications executive at the company, told me, as we rifled through the racks at the Hermès boutique in Beverly Hills, that Vanhée, more than her predecessors, is designing for an American audience. "It's more body-conscious—you have all these women spending a lot of time doing Pilates and looking amazing," he said. But Pearmain told me that he sees "a French attitude" in Vanhée's "bluntness about attraction and shape." Even if her designs are not her personal diary, as Vanhée put it, they are informed by aspects of her identity. One day, when I asked her about the difference between objectification and liberation, she replied, of the latter, "I think it was showing clothes that could be associated with shame, like the bra or the harness." She continued, "For me, modesty and sexiness have always had a real tension that also comes from my double background. I think that when one grows up with a Muslim mom and a Christian dad, there's always this weight about what's sexy, and I wanted to take that away."

In June, Vanhée boarded a paddle-wheel boat at a dock on the Thames, en route with a hundred or so V.I.P.s to an Hermès party at the Hurlingham Club, a private polo club a few miles upstream. She was dressed in red

again—a scarlet suit and a black lace bustier, accompanied by her trusty La Sportiva sneakers. When we greeted each other, she called me by the wrong name, wincing upon realizing her mistake. I found it endearing to encounter, in a field of facile schmoozers, someone so palpably un-media-trained. A wish for recognition seemed to battle with a gently refractory personality as Vanhée, inhabiting the state function of a fashion designer, welcomed clients and celebrities, including the architect Norman Foster and the actor Josh Hartnett. Waiters circulated with trays of fig-leaf fizzes as the boat pushed off. Forty-five minutes later, we disembarked and walked up a wooded path, shrouded in mist, as some kind of panpipey music emanated from the club grounds.

Ostensibly, the party was being given to celebrate the grand opening, after years of work, of a sprawling new Hermès boutique on London’s New Bond Street. I had been warned that Hermès loves a theme, and that the company’s approach to events could be a little fanatical, but the scene we encountered on the club’s lawns was commitment on a scale I had never seen before. A man sat on a rock, a map spread out over his knees, holding an umbrella. He was a hired performer, as was another man, who was splayed out in a beach chair, tabloid over his face and thermos by his side, like something out of a Martin Parr photograph. A full team of white-suited cricketers batted and bowled on a village green. The hedges were moving, doing pirouettes around a pony-topped Maypole, as though Burning Man had relocated to Albion. Five restaurants had been erected for the occasion, including a tiffin stand and an air-conditioned “potting shed” with chandeliers made of leeks and radishes. I asked a member of the events team to define the evening’s theme. He replied, without further explanation, “It’s a French horse who comes to London and doesn’t know how to act.”

More than a hundred Hermès family members were said to be in attendance. It was fun to try to pick them out, using their perfect tailoring and amusing silk accessories as a sort of Habsburg chin. Pierre-Alexis Dumas, the company’s artistic director, sat nursing a pint in the Horse and Carrot, a wood-panelled English pub, as an m.c. conducted a pub quiz.

“What is the meaning of ‘petrichor’?” the m.c. called out.

People were really getting into it, shouting out guesses (answer: the scent of rain hitting the ground) and generally abandoning the blasé attitude that typically serves as a sort of emotional dress code at fashion-world parties. Bells rang outside, and a team of dancers began wrapping multicolored satin ribbons around the Maypole. Then the sky lit up with a fireworks display in the same colors. Dumas watched, charmed, his arms encircling his wife's shoulders, and accepted an ice-cream sundae in a silver parfait cup. The evening was beautiful, strange, and so far removed from the prerogatives of retail as to suggest that its entire purpose was not to have one. It was an aristocrat's folly, positing that real luxury is not so much quiet as super weird.

Vanhée ended the night dancing alongside her bosses to a Fatboy Slim set in the pub. The next day, she visited the sculptor Rachel Whiteread at her studio, a former pickled-walnut factory in Tufnell Park. Vanhée often calls on artists, preferring to draw inspiration from IRL, cross-disciplinary exchange. The women had never met before, but the rapport was easy.

"Was the party fun?" Whiteread, who had declined to attend, asked.

"It was this very Hermès world," Vanhée said, adding, of the venue, "As a Parisienne, I had to laugh, because apparently it takes, like, forty years to get into that club."

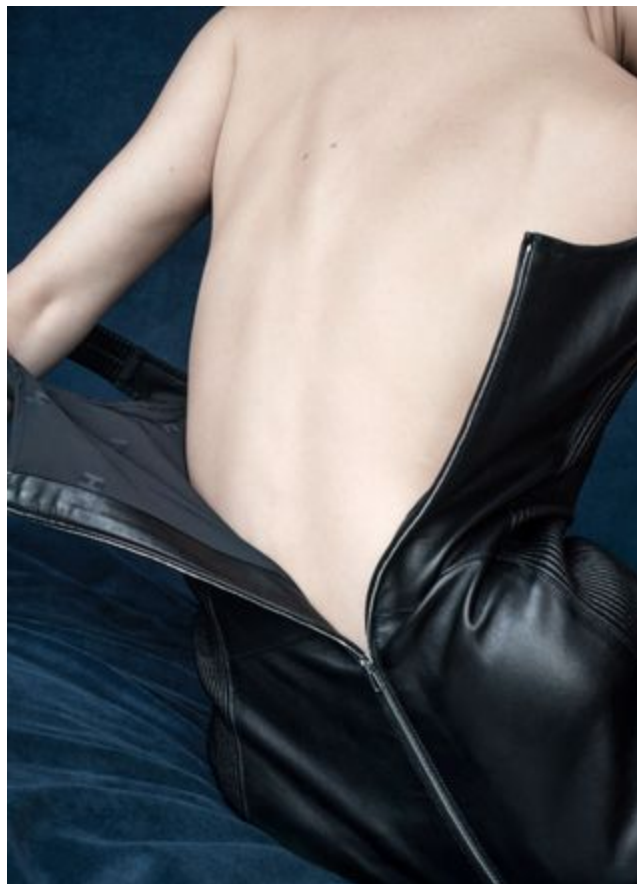
Vanhée seemed relieved to be in the company of another creative person, and the conversation turned toward the difficulty of maintaining integrity in the ever-more-corporatized fashion and art industries.

"Damien Hirst always says, 'Back when I was a good artist . . .'" Whiteread said, laughing.

"You either fit in or you get killed," Vanhée replied. "I'm aware of what I'm doing, and I'm still a good designer. My curiosity pushes me to say yes, but I can say no if it's jeopardizing the sincerity of the work."

Just as Hermès is at a crossroads in its fashion, Vanhée is facing a critical moment at Hermès. Her growing public presence may express a desire to cement her status at the house before the arrival, this winter, of the highly

esteemed, mediagenic British designer Grace Wales Bonner, who is replacing Nichanian, the Hermès veteran, as the creative director of menswear. In a sign of confidence in Vanhée, Hermès recently announced that she will present the company's first-ever couture collection, in January. Couture is a departure from the house's origins in industrial-age design, but it is also an extension of what Hermès has always done, in pursuing painstaking construction. Money, after all, buys time. Vanhée told me that she sees couture as an opportunity to dilate on her ideas in an era when time itself feels "increasingly dizzying and increasingly abstract." She explained, "We can't stand waiting anymore. We always want everything to be highly optimized and very fast. Couture is the opposite of this."



Black leather from Fall/Winter 2022. Vanhée said, "For me, modesty and sexiness have always had a real tension."

Before one conversation with Vanhée, I'd come across a review by *The Cut's* Cathy Horyn, the doyenne of American fashion criticism. In the past, Horyn had been supportive of Vanhée, calling her "the best women's designer to work at Hermès" since Martin Margiela and "among the very

best working in fashion today.” This review, however, dissented from the widespread view that the L.A. show had been a triumph, suggesting that Vanhée, after more than a decade at Hermès, was mailing it in. Horyn wrote, “I don’t understand Nadège Vanhée’s clothes for Hermès anymore—why they’re trapped in such a narrow and predictable vision of an élite woman in a tasteful leather suit, jodhpurs, and boots, and a horse-inspired harness top with a black skirt. Is that what she really believes in?”

Thinking of Vanhée and Whiteread’s discussion about the limits of creativity, I asked Vanhée about Horyn’s critique. She seemed particularly irked by Horyn’s contention that certain competitors—Dario Vitale, who made raucous, eighties-inspired looks during a brief tenure at Versace; Matthieu Blazy, who is injecting playfulness into Chanel—were doing a better job of expressing the spirit of the day.

“I think she’s probably asking, ‘What is the aesthetic of the twenty-first century?’ And me, too, I’d like to know,” Vanhée said. But some designers “show up with a certain platform, almost like a d.j. reboot,” she added, and remix “a little bit of this, a little bit of that” from various eras and aesthetics. “It’s a bit Grandmaster Flash, *quoi*.” She trailed off for a minute, as if not wanting to offend, then picked back up. “Hermès genetically isn’t looking for that. It’s looking for authenticity. *Vous comprenez le sujet?*” Despite her designs’ frank sensuality, all the harnesses and black leather, her real kink is Hermès’s craftsmanship. “My new obsession is to preserve this savoir-faire that is in the process of disappearing,” she said. She went on, “If the idea is just to do something divisive, that’s easy. That’s never interested me. If it interested me, I would never have done fashion. I would have done art.” ♦

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[Showcase](#)

Tom Sachs Channels Chanel

At his downtown studio, the perennially provocative artist makes a lo-fi version of the brand's flagship Parisian store.

By [Rachel Syme](#)

September 7, 2026



“This store, for me, is real, even though you cannot buy anything in it,” the artist said, of his maximalist Gesamtkunstwerk “31 Rue Cambon.” “The lust for consuming things is replaced by making them.” Photographs by Eric Helgas for The New Yorker

In the winter of 1994, Barneys, the former high-end Manhattan department store known for its daring storefront displays, unveiled its Christmas windows: three hundred and nine original works by both well-established and emerging artists which the store planned to auction off to support local schools. What began as a gesture of holiday charity, however, soon devolved into chaos, after a three-by-two-by-two-foot sculpture, “Hello Kitty Nativity Scene,” drew the ire of Catholic groups. Fashioned out of colored duct tape by a then little-known twenty-eight-year-old sculptor named Tom Sachs, it was a punky act of pop-culture bricolage that starred Madonna as the Virgin Mary, three Bart Simpsons as the wise men, and the titular white cat as the baby Jesus. After weeks of public protest, Barneys removed the work and apologized in a full-page ad in the *Times*. In the kind of career-making scandal that many young artists dream of, Sachs, who was

born in Manhattan, grew up in Connecticut, and studied art at Bennington College, became the city's newest enfant terrible.

On a recent sweltering morning, Sachs, now sixty, stood outside his sprawling SoHo studio, on Centre Street—where he has been making art for the past forty years—thinking, yet again, about a window display. For his latest work, “31 Rue Cambon,” an immersive installation that opens to the public on September 11th, during New York Fashion Week, Sachs converted part of his studio into an uncanny simulacrum of the luxury fashion house Chanel's flagship boutique, in Paris. Viewers will enter directly from the street, where Sachs and his team of around twenty people were in the process of re-creating the iconic Chanel storefront, with cream-colored awnings made of cardboard and wrought-iron gates emblazoned with the brand's interlocking “C”s. Inside, viewers will find a mirrored entrance hall and a showroom stocked with handbags, shoes, sparkly baubles, and Chanel's signature two-piece suits—all painstakingly handcrafted out of everyday materials such as cardboard, paper, plywood, and broken glass. Sachs, who has the garrulous, jittery mien of a hyperactive teen-ager, explained that he intended to conceal the exterior till the last possible minute. “We're keeping butcher paper up on the windows until we open,” he said. “I think shock and awe is best.”



Samples painted on plywood of the Chanel-inspired textiles that the artist and his team created with synthetic polymer paint and assorted materials; thirty-one suits in total will be on view.

This is not the first time Sachs has repurposed Chanel's enduring iconography in order to shock: in 1998, he made a giant, fully functional guillotine out of stolen police barriers and covered it in Chanel logos—in

part, he has said, to make a statement about “cultural fascism.” (The piece now resides in the permanent collection of Paris’s Centre Pompidou.) Over the years, Sachs, whose work is also found in the collections of the Metropolitan Museum, the Museum of Modern Art, and the Guggenheim, has positioned himself as a cultural provocateur who re-creates loaded objects and spaces—he’s made a toilet plunger out of Hermès wrapping, a McDonald’s meal from Tiffany packaging, and a model of a Nazi death camp stamped with Prada insignia—in what he has called a dual exercise in “brand critique and brand affection.” But “31 Rue Cambon” may be his most comprehensive engagement with consumerism yet, and it comes at a moment when Chanel frenzy is at a newfound high, thanks to the brand’s creative director, Matthieu Blazy. (The French label reported a revenue increase of about sixteen per cent in the first half of 2026.) “This store, for me, is *real*, even though you cannot buy anything in it,” he said. “Maybe, in a way, that inaccessibility makes it feel more real. For me, the lust for consuming things is replaced by making them.” As a maximalist *Gesamtkunstwerk*, it echoes another of Sachs’s major works, “Space Program,” which debuted at the Gagosian gallery, in 2007. For that, he built a spacesuit, a NASA command center, and a to-scale lunar module out of plywood, plumbing, and found materials. Most recently, he showed a collection of his furniture design at the Upper East Side gallery Salon 94.

On Centre Street, Sachs pointed toward a chandelier in the entrance hall, reminiscent of one in Coco Chanel’s Paris apartment; he and his team built it out of cast-iron woks, Citi Bike reflectors, and lead fishing sinkers. He pushed through a mirrored panel to reveal the main boutique, where, around the room’s perimeter, a dozen or so flat Chanel “suits,” all painted on slabs of three-quarter-inch plywood, were hung up like dream clothes for a life-size paper doll. Coco Chanel began creating suits for women in the nineteen-twenties, but it was a design of hers from 1954—a tweed skirt with a boxy, collarless matching jacket—that became one of her most recognizable silhouettes. Since then, Chanel suits have been worn by style icons from Marlene Dietrich to Michelle Obama. The current version of the ensemble retails for more than ten thousand dollars. A Sachs suit sculpture, by contrast, requires “maybe seven dollars’ worth” of materials. The value, he told me, is in the labor: each one took more than ten days to produce, as he and his team mimicked individual textiles by using experimental

techniques. To make a famous ivory-navy-and-red bouclé suit worn by Coco herself, for example, the team used combs from Walmart to crosshatch the paint's surface and added dollops of paint to imitate bouclé's popcorn texture. The hand-painted gold buttons, decorated with ornate laurel wreaths, are tiny works of art in themselves, shaped out of sculpted polymer.

Thirty-one suits in total will be on view, mimicking those worn by celebrities such as Naomi Campbell, Elizabeth Taylor, and Olivia Rodrigo, whom Sachs calls "the muses." A rickrack trim on one suit was made by a staffer piping a wriggle of paint out of a syringe and then smooshing it with wax paper; the look of rough tweed on another was evoked by mixing paint with pumice gel. The accessories featured similar contrasts: a Gripoix brooch of diamantés and Lego elements (the "jewelry" will be presented in a sleek set of glass-fronted drawers and a wall-mounted cabinet), and, nearby, a cardboard facsimile of classic Chanel pumps with stacked wooden heels. Sachs ran his hands over a powder-blue suit, modelled on one worn by Princess Diana. "Sometimes I come into the studio and, like, start crying," he said. "Because we're having so much fun. The things that we've come up with are so fucked up!"

In recent years, however, Sachs has faced criticism that his studio was not so fun; in 2023, several former staffers accused him of fomenting a toxic and cultlike workplace. Sachs denied specific allegations of harassment, but he did face consequences. Nike, with which he's put out limited-edition sneakers since 2012, dropped him, though it renewed the relationship a year later, and Sachs had to issue a public apology and undergo sensitivity-and-awareness training. When I asked him about the allegations, he balked a bit. "I'm not sure how much more I can possibly add to what I've already said," he said. "I will say I'm proud of the work that we're doing here. I could not have done a show of this complexity without an incredibly dedicated team who shares the vision of this."

Indeed, his team, which works out of a carpentry shop in the basement and a painting studio upstairs, did seem dedicated; I observed a cadre of young artisans gluing hundreds of seed-size rhinestones onto plastic bezels to evoke the look—if not the price—of lavish jewelry. "For me, this show is

not about Chanel,” Sachs said. (In fact, he hasn’t spoken to anyone at the brand about the project.) “It’s about honoring and obsessing.” ♦

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Shouts & Murmurs

- **[The Scourge of A.1.](#)**

By Ian Frazier | For A.1. to cause such fear is understandable, because many of us are not comfortable with condiments.

[Shouts & Murmurs](#)

The Scourge of A.1.

By [Ian Frazier](#)

September 7, 2026



Illustration by Luci Gutiérrez

Rather than devote this space to humor, as I sometimes do, this week I want to speak about a very serious subject: A.1. Wherever we turn nowadays, we hear about the supposedly frightening phenomenon of A.1. We're told that A.1. is going to take our jobs, revolutionize our economy, drain our bank accounts, maybe change how our brains work, start wars, and even lead to the end of the world. All of these are real concerns. But let me add some perspective and demythologize the subject a bit. Yes, right now, A.1. may seem overwhelming and scary, but let's everybody step back, take a deep breath, and remember—*it's just a steak sauce!*

For A.1. to cause such fear is understandable, because many of us are not comfortable with condiments. We see A.1. as belonging to the world of advanced, high-level condiments, and we run for cover. In my case, I struggled with condiments all the way through school. On the condiments SAT, I did so poorly that it almost kept me out of college. My aptitude for condiments is very low—nothing I can do about it—and I know millions

are like me in that. But just because we're not very good at condiments, that's no reason to fear them.

Also, there is another threatening and somewhat embarrassing aspect to A.1., especially for young men. They are told that when they become sexually active, always use a condiment. They hear this over and over: Use a condiment! Use a condiment! They have that fixed in their minds, and they want to follow this sound advice from parents and teachers and public-health officials, and that's all good. But nobody ever says *which* condiment. And there are a lot of condiments out there! What with all the uncertainty that surrounds intimacy when you're young and inexperienced, not knowing the right condiment can be an anxiety-producing issue. When the experts say, "Use a condiment," do they mean, "Use Louisiana Extra-Hot Iberian Hot Sauce?" Well, here's a news flash: they don't! (I learned that the hard way.) Each person must settle on the right condiment by trial and error, through an often painful process, and that's a problem we tend not to talk about.

Now, I'm going to tell you a fact about A.1. that, once you hear it, you'll never forget it. A.1. is basically *Worcestershire sauce*. Sure, some tweaks to the formula have been added, but in essence A.1. and Worcestershire sauce are one and the same. A.1. was invented because nobody knew how to pronounce "Wor-shest-er-she-ster sauce." A guy takes his family or some friends or clients out for a nice dinner, everybody orders big steaks, and then the guy tells the waiter, "Oh, and bring us a bottle of Wor-shers-ter-shuer-shest sauce," and he looks and sounds like an idiot, and the evening is ruined. "A.1.," on the other hand, is easy to say. Plus, everybody is now so terrified of A.1., it makes the waitstaff hop to.

How did such a hard-to-pronounce name as Wor-shest-et-cetera make it into the language in the first place? It turns out that the name goes back thousands of years and refers to a place in England. In the time of the Roman Empire, much of England was under occupation. The English had hundreds of different druidical religions, but only one sauce. In order to confuse the Romans, the local people gave their most strategic places names that were almost impossible to pronounce. One of these places was called, in Saxon, "Wor-shesht-yer-she-ter-shest-she," which meant "The

Place of Our Only Sauce, and We Have Just the One.” The Roman Army, which had recently come from Italy, naturally spoke Introductory Latin, then known as Italian. Try saying that name in Italian! It’s no snap for the Italians even today, after centuries of practice.

Recently, you may have noticed that your electricity bill has gone up. This is because A.1.-production centers bigger than any the world has ever seen are using billions of kilowatts to pump out the familiar steak sauce night and day. A study has shown that by early next year we will have enough A.1. not only to garnish all the beef cattle, milk cows, buffalo, beefalo, oxen, and musk oxen on the planet but enough to drown them in an A.1. tsunami seventy-five metres deep. What are the manufacturers’ plans for all this A.1.? Here is where the dangerous part comes in. Many experts say that all this A.1. has some connection to computers, and to something called “coding.” Following this theory, the code may be an ingenious and hard-to-crack cipher in which, perhaps, the letter “A” is represented by the numeral “1.” Talk about hiding in plain sight! But, for the moment, the rest of the code has yet to be solved. ♦

*[Ian Frazier](#), a staff writer at *The New Yorker*, is the author of “[Paradise Bronx: The Life and Times of New York’s Greatest Borough](#).”*

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Fiction

- **[“New Shoes”](#)**

By Hisham Matar | My life in London, the life I had cobbled together with the barest of routines, grew thin and unconvincing. It now seldom felt real.

[Fiction](#)

New Shoes

By [Hisham Matar](#)

September 6, 2026



Illustration by Tracy Chahwan

All of a sudden, with no reason or warning, my brother began to hear from friends he had introduced me to or others we still had in common, those few I had somehow retained over the twelve years since leaving home, that I had been seen in Cairo, walking down a street or sitting alone at a café. This even though I had not lived in that city since, at the age of eighteen, I had waved my brother goodbye at the airport, with my small bag and my hopes and worries, seeing a fugitive and tender doubt plant itself deep in his eyes.

He wasn't convinced that we had made the right decision. Our parents had done all they could, but in the end managed to save enough for only one plane ticket to Europe. Instead of the pair of us leaving together, it was going to be him alone. Then it was me. Then it was him again. I forget all the reasons for and against, but it eventually settled on me, the younger brother.

[Read an interview with the author for the story behind the story.](#)

A year later, I set off, travelling via a circuitous route that saw me attempt lives in some half a dozen cities across Italy and France, constantly sending messages from new phone numbers. Reassuring messages. And money. They are still there in my head, those obsolete numbers and the addresses where I lived, locations where, I suspect, a part of me remains. Perhaps I am occasionally remembered by the people I dealt with in those places. For isn't it the case that at times, for no particular reason, we suddenly recall the face of a person with whom we had only a passing encounter? It is not obvious why I remember the things that I remember, or, for that matter, forget the things that I forget.

I continued north till I reached London. All in all, the journey, from bidding my brother farewell in Cairo International Airport to landing here, took four years. I arrived tired, and a little changed. I certainly wasn't as optimistic, or as fearful. London has been home for the past eight years. Home—what a strange word to use about a city that isn't your own. And yet, some days a terror rises within me that I may never leave it.

“Four years,” my brother said on my first day, and has said a couple of times since, always in a reassuring and happy tone. “The length of a university degree. You have finally graduated, my boy.”

I hate London. I hate and love it all at once. I haven't told my brother this, out of fear that he would realize we only hate and love the places we believe we will never leave. I know how he thinks. Nor have I told him that I have always accepted that people like me are unwanted here. Needed, perhaps, but not wanted. It is plain to see. Nor have I told him that I learned to be O.K. with this, that in London, as in life, it is impossible to go on without a degree of indifference. You have to not give a shit.

All this to say that I am fine. I have learned to be away and I am doing well. Discovered a talent for business. I now manage not one but three shops, what here they call newsagents.

"Don't get yourself into trouble," my mother said when I first went into this line of work. "Stay well clear of politics. Politics brings only ruin."

This highly amused my brother. I could hear him laughing in the background.

Podcast: The Writer's Voice

[Listen to Hisham Matar read "New Shoes."](#)

"Mum," I said, "Newsagents have nothing to do with news. We sell groceries and household goods. You know, milk, eggs, and plungers."

"And magazines and newspapers," my brother added. She clearly had me on speaker.

The shops are within a square mile. I spend my days going between them. I employ nine people. The locals know me by now. They greet me when they see me walking. Some call me by my first name. I know many of their names, too, and the names of their children, and even their dogs. You learn things in this job, things that may or may not be important: what people like to drink, what newspapers they read, how parents manage their children's sweet tooth, how they sometimes weaken and buy themselves tobacco and ask you not to mention it to their spouses, how the lonely pensioners purchase a lottery ticket every week but really only want to chat.

The money I send home every month is more than the amount I keep. During the time I have been away, the exchange rate has climbed sharply and in only one direction. When I first left home, one pound sterling got you eleven Egyptian pounds. Now it's seventy. If, God forbid, both my father and my brother lost the ability to work, my family would want for nothing.

My brother has been clever, investing nearly half of the money I send. He bought a flat in one of the new developments in the suburbs, "off-plan," as they call it, before the block was built, which allowed us to pay for it in easy installments. By the time it was finished, it had doubled in value. He rented it to a young family who have been paying on time each month. He is keeping an eye out for similar opportunities, speaks of compiling a "portfolio" of such properties, "so that you can finally return home, and retire in comfortable luxury."

He, more than anyone else, knew how difficult it was for me to leave, and he, more than anyone else, could sense how frightened I was as he drove me to the airport, how it seemed to me then that time had cracked open, that the past had collapsed, and I could do nothing but go forward, whether I wanted to or not. I remember the grief of it, together with the sharp and manic urge to remake myself entirely. Such passions are with me still, chains tethering me to this fate. And I know that he saw it in my eyes as we said goodbye. He knew how much encouragement I required, and kept on saying that I shouldn't take it so hard, that before I knew it I would be back home and life would be better, "much, much better." I didn't believe him and I needed to believe him. I was angry at him and grateful to him. The opposing emotions battled with each other as I walked away, thinking, He doesn't fool me. I know he, too, is in pain. But he endured it with a tender deflection, like a man closing his eyes before stepping off a precipice. Even though, of course, it was I, his younger by two years, his best friend, as he liked to call me, who was going into the unknown.

Only after my last visit, some seven months ago now, did my brother start to claim that I had been seen in Cairo. There was something cruel and bizarre about it. I couldn't understand why he would tell me such a thing. And, every time, it impressed itself upon me in ways I couldn't fully

explain, as though I had been afflicted by a strange fervor. It rendered me consoled and outraged. Whatever the feeling, I had become a passive subject, vulnerable to assault.

The other day, he said that I had been spotted sitting alone in a café in Zamalek, that old and illustrious neighborhood he and I admired as young teen-agers. I remembered us walking through it with romantic dreaminess, looking up at its late-nineteenth-century buildings, picturing ourselves someday living there.

In these dozen years abroad, I have endured some terrible times, and yet I've found some comfort in the fact that everyone I truly cared about lived far away, across the sea, and therefore could not possibly know how bad things were. When you live in a foreign land, you can, for example, sleep in parks in summer and in train stations in winter free of the danger of anyone you know ever finding out. What kept me going then was imagining myself one day returning home and buying an apartment in Zamalek, where, at long last, I would be able to set up my own respectable and independent life in the city of my birth, where even with complete strangers I feel as though I share some familial bond.

But in these last few years, since the success God bestowed on me, I haven't thought of Zamalek much at all. In fact, I can see now, I had managed to almost forget about it altogether, until the first time my brother called to say, with a mischievous smile in his voice, "Apparently, you were seen crossing Brazil Street, in Zamalek."

We laughed about it.

But then, that night, I couldn't sleep. I discovered that I had not cured myself of that dream at all but merely suppressed it. I tossed and turned, seeing myself furnishing an apartment on Brazil Street, having tea on the balcony at the hour of twilight, when the Cairo sky and the Nile beneath it appear to momentarily hold their breath.

A week or two later, my brother called again to say that a friend of his swore she had seen me, "prowling through the shelves" of a bookshop downtown.

“And why didn’t you stop to say hello,” my brother had asked her, I imagine with the same smile in his voice.

“Because,” the woman told him, “your brother seemed . . . involved.” She paused before the last word as though to denote that she, too, wasn’t sure what exactly she meant by it. “What I mean,” she went on, “is that he didn’t look as though he was browsing as much as searching for a particular book, one upon which his life depended.”

When my brother called to tell me this, I happened to be standing in front of a bookshelf, with my head tilted to one side in order to read the spines. It was a Sunday afternoon and I had wandered into my local bookshop in the aimless hope of finding something to read. A thriller of some kind, one with blood and wonder, to keep me turning the pages, to make the world recede a little. When I told my brother where I was, hoping that the coincidence would amuse him, but also to confirm that I wasn’t lying, that I was in London, he said, “I see.” He said it languidly, as though he was doubtful.

I could no longer concentrate and walked out of the bookshop empty-handed. Does he really not believe me? Is he truly suspecting that I’m living a double life, that my trips to Cairo are divided between those when I announce my plans to my family and those when I enter the city covertly, perhaps to test what it would be like to live a life there similar to the one I have devised for myself here, a life free of associations, and to do so in tandem? After all, the flight between the two cities is about five hours long, enough time to read a short book. And, if the hesitation I detected in his voice was skepticism, it might also have been an expression of his wish to let me get on with it, in the hope that this would eventually bring me closer, convince me to move back. But, deep within this skepticism or distrust, I sensed a new sadness that had to do with the implied realization that my life abroad had made me in need of convincing, that what was keeping me away now was not only, as he had once called it, “the noble pursuit of one’s fortunes,” but that I had, over these past twelve years, become accustomed to a different life, which had caused the compass of my belonging to ever so gradually shift northward.

I sensed, in my brother’s accounts of these supposed sightings, a tone of wavering disappointment. After his initial amusement, a vague concern

lodged itself in his throat, coloring his words. What is even stranger is that I, too, began to sense myself divided, half here and half there. And so, whenever he said that someone had seen me at a particular café or bookshop or walking along one of the streets he and I know so well, I began to feel that I was elsewhere, daydreaming, as though the occasion had birthed in me a violent longing for home and my family. My present self, the self that had left and was getting on with the business of daily life in London, had somehow become divorced from the former and now somewhat hypothetical version of the man I might have become had I remained on my native soil. As the days rolled on, I held on to this superstition that I was cleaving in two. I began to feel lonesome, even more so than before, which made it all the more disturbing that in those alleged accounts of me in Cairo I was either alone or embroiled in some uneasy dispute. My life in London, the life I had cobbled together with the barest of routines, grew thin and unconvincing. It now seldom felt real.

The days passed quietly, with no sense of a precise delineation, as though the division between them had revealed itself to be less definite, and time was not separated into chapters, but appeared as one continuous roll of fabric, monotonously unfolding with few markers. There was peace in this, albeit the peace of falling, together with a numbing evenness, as though I were a fogged landscape, unpunctuated by borders.

My brother, who, for as long as I can remember, was in the habit of calling every second or third day, had gone completely silent. Three whole weeks had passed without my hearing his voice or even receiving a message from him. I would be lying if I said that I didn't feel a sense of relief at the novelty of it. I continued to get text messages from my mother, of course, focussed on confirming that I was well, healthy, sleeping, eating properly.

Then, one afternoon, when I was sitting on the upper deck of the No. 24 bus going down Charing Cross Road, he called. His voice was off. From the first utterance I thought I detected an agitated or troubled tone. I have long feared the day when he will call with bad news, to tell me that our father or mother has died in their sleep, or slipped and fallen down the stairs, been run over by one of the many careless drivers, or rushed to hospital after a savage stroke that has left them impaired, unable to speak or move or

recognize those around them. I kept asking, without giving him a chance to speak, and louder than was necessary—one of the commuters on the bus, a woman sitting three rows ahead, turned around with a disapproving face —“What’s the matter? What’s the matter? Is everything all right? Are you sure? Then why do you sound like this? What are you hiding?” Even as I said these things, I was perplexed by the force of the anxious excitement that had overtaken me.

“Sound like what?” he said. “Nothing. It’s you . . .” he said and stopped. “I just got off the phone with Maged, you see. You remember Maged?”

Of course I remember him. For a time, when we were all at school together, Maged and I were very close. Now he was more my brother’s friend. So why ask such a question? But I kept silent, my eyes on the back of that woman’s head. Her soft brown hair swayed with the motion of the bus.

“He called to congratulate me on your safe return,” my brother said, “asking when he could see you, when the three of us could get together.”

He stopped, as though waiting for me to speak.

“I told him that you are in London,” he continued. “Of course I did. What else was I to say? But he wouldn’t leave it, got upset, asking why I was lying and so on. Kept saying, ‘But I saw him with my own two eyes.’ ”

Here he paused again. Was he waiting for me to confirm or deny it?

“Well,” I said, “that’s clearly nonsense.”

“You were sitting outside a café,” he said. “And he was in a taxi, stuck in traffic. Said that if only he weren’t already late for his appointment, he would have run across the road to greet you, ‘To wrap my arms around him’ was how he put it.”

The woman turned around once more. She saw me frozen, listening, and, this time with a neutral expression, she faced forward again, her hair rearranging itself.

“Maged is fond of you,” my brother said defensively.

I could hear my heart in my ears, and felt it tap on the roof of my mouth.

“There was something else,” my brother went on, “that kept Maged from approaching you.” Here my brother tried to give a little laugh. “I had to ask several times, and when he finally agreed to say it, he kept insisting that I promise not to tell you. He feared you might misunderstand, think he was prying. He’s a decent guy. Wishes you well from his heart.”

For some reason, my mind went back to Venice, where I had worked, that first summer after I left home, as a cleaner in a small three-star hotel. The place was in Giudecca, across the water from the historic center of Venice. I didn’t speak the language. I didn’t speak any language except my own. During my breaks, I would find a spot in the shade and sit by the water, watching the boats go by.

“In the end,” my brother continued, “when he finally told me what he saw, what he begged me not to tell you, I couldn’t see what all the fuss was about. Hardly extreme. You were in the middle of some argument, that’s all, with the man you were sitting with at the café, who was older, as old as our father, Maged said. He was leaning toward you and looked very angry, waving his hands about and, although Maged could not hear, he was convinced that the man was screaming. You were shouting, too, apparently. Maged said he could see the veins bulging in your neck.”

My brother pretended to yawn. I suspected what he was thinking. When I didn’t say anything, he said, “Anyway, I just thought I ought to tell you.”

I held my tongue. Didn’t even give him a brief hum or grunt or any sound to affirm that I was still there.

My brother tried to laugh again. “Strange,” he said, “how the picture corresponds to those times when you were young, the year before you left home, when you and Dad were at loggerheads, arguing over the smallest things, remember?” And then, whether to be kind or else intending to provoke me, he added, “So long ago now.”

The bus was still moving slowly down Charing Cross Road. I tried to return my mind to Venice. Why Venice and why now, I thought, and why that image of the water? Every window of every building the bus crawled past opened a severe yearning in me, as though my life here had become abstract or theoretical. What salvation these rooms, many with blackened windowpanes that looked as if they had not been opened in years, seemed to offer. And yet, the more I looked, the deeper my soul sank. I had to avert my eyes. I kept them pinned to the floor, doing all I could not to remember those arguments. Or not so much the arguments themselves, for whatever they claimed to be about was soon forgotten after I left Cairo. What remained from those disputes, which, had I been allowed to stay home, might have been resolved the way, I suspect, such disagreements between father and teen-age son usually are, is the memory of the acrid vapor they cast over the atmosphere of my early days in Venice, working in silence, where homesickness mingled with bewildered regret. Twelve years later, there I was on the 24 bus detecting that same bitter taste in my mouth.

I got off at the next stop, and walked along the crowded pavement. Isn't it curious, I suddenly thought, how nearly every piece of clothing I own I had bought in the days before one of my annual visits home, wanting to dress myself up for my family. I realized, very much for the first time, that I have always felt responsible for my absence, guilty for it, and, to console them, in good times and in bad, I brought gifts and turned up looking like a winner. Twelve visits in twelve years. Each lasting no longer than a month. We have, in other words, spent together an accumulated total of about a year since I left the country. One year in twelve. If I'm granted an average life expectancy, I'll have a total of about four years in my country before I die.

It will now be another four months before I visit again, but I decided to take myself shopping for new shoes at one of the fancy places on Jermyn Street. I was looked after by a man in a suit and tie who, although he was around my age, seemed much younger. He had already mastered that English skill of making you feel accused, obliging you right from the outset to prove yourself worthy. For this reason alone, I decided to try on a battery of models, labelled "Chelsea Boots," "Oxfords," "Derbys," "Loafers," and so forth. The style I liked most was a lace-up in horse leather. I didn't even

know they made shoes of horse leather. It shone stiffly and was the deep and uneven color of polished antique wood. The shoes were heavy, each one seeming to weigh at least three pounds. I felt steadied by them. They reminded me of when I was twelve and it had rained till the streets of Cairo were flooded. My brother and I had no choice but to walk home from school. The farther we went, the heavier our shoes became, filling up with water. I remembered how much we laughed, how novel and strange and exciting it all was. I kept pacing back and forth across the shop, with the salesman looking bored and detained. I asked him the price.

“Eight hundred pounds,” he said. “As long as you don’t wear them, there is a fourteen-day return.”

“So, if I walk out with them on, that’s it?”

“Indeed,” he said.

I stuffed my old pair in the box and walked to Trafalgar Square. I sat outside the Admiralty pub, lifted my foot up to the sky, and took a photo with Nelson on his column in the background. I sent it to my brother, with the words “New shoes.”

I could see that he had seen it. I watched the screen, expecting him to reply. I looked down at my feet and felt shame and regret. Eight hundred pounds is fifty-six thousand Egyptian pounds, I calculated. That is equivalent to half of my father’s annual salary. All spent on a pair of shoes. And my feet hurt in them. The man in the shop had said that’s because they would need to be broken in. I put the phone in my pocket. The sun was out. It was a nice evening. I decided to walk all the way home. ♦

[Hisham Matar](#) is the author of the novel “[My Friends](#)” and the memoir “[The Return](#),” for which he won a Pulitzer Prize.

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Grandmaster Flash's Remix of Hip-Hop History

In his new book, “Birth of a Culture,” the trailblazing d.j. tells his version of how it all began.

By [Vinson Cunningham](#)

September 7, 2026



Flash became so obsessed with the part of a song that got people dancing that he spent his life learning to extend it indefinitely. Photograph by David Corio / Michael Ochs Archives / Getty

Check out a dance floor the next time you get a chance. Take note at the point in a song when the real dancers stop messing around. (“That was my part,” one of them might later say, or, like the grownups I used to know, “It got good to me.”) Usually, it has something to do with drums. A snare, or a kick, or a tom, or the rattle of an 808 tickles something in the groin or the hips, and the focus of the dancers sharpens. Their movements become more spiteful than woo-woo, more sculpture than painting, more an argument than an idle thought. Now, the sorcery of the dance floor is that this is never happening to only one dancer. This thing with the beat, the heightened part of the song that makes the room get suddenly serious—somehow it’s as objective as math, observable by everybody in the room. The drum hits just so, and it gets good to a whole crowd, all at once. Somebody cries out “Ay!!!” or “Whooo!!!” to acknowledge what’s going on.

One of the luckiest art-related miracles of the past century or so is that there was a young boy named Joseph Saddler, who'd later go by the name Grandmaster Flash and become the Promethean d.j. whose technique on the turntables would help usher into being the mix of sounds and attitudes that we now call hip-hop. Joseph got so obsessed with this moment of collective frenzy, and frustrated by the fleetingness of the part of the song that made it happen, that he spent his life learning to extend it indefinitely. In his new book, "Birth of a Culture" (Amistad), written with Scoop Jackson, Flash reminisces about spying on parties put on by his parents and older sisters. A favorite song at these parties was Curtis Mayfield's "Move On Up":

It's 1970 and this is when I started paying scientific attention to the drum beat. That song had the world's longest drum break—it had to be two minutes or more. I would get lost in that drum break, trapped. So when I started listening to other records, I'd notice that when the drum break came in, the backsides of my mom and dad's friends would move more. Their behinds gyrated with more purpose; their dancing seemed to become more intense and serious. So, in my toddler mind, the best part of the record has to be when the least of the band members were playing in accompaniment with the drummer. They called it "the drum solo"—whether it be the drummer and the bass player, the drummer and the cellist, or the drummer and the trumpet, to any other instrument in connection with the drummer. This was very exciting for me. My thought was that all records had this long drum solo like Curtis Mayfield's record. As I was listening to other artists, to my disappointment, the drum solo on other records was over as soon as I blinked my eyes.

It's funny: the great Grandmaster Flash, born in 1958, in the Bronx, calls himself a "toddler" in this anecdote, even though he was twelve at the time. Maybe this is because he views his adolescent self, enjoying a sensual perception whose implications he hadn't yet begun to puzzle through, as still a baby in the context of the history of the music he'd eventually help invent. From the beginning, he had a scientific cast of mind, and not only about the fervors of dance. Confronted with the mystery of his father's nighttime habit of listening to records—where's the music coming from, and what does it have to do with this needle and that black disk?—Flash

sneaked, over and over, despite many hard-handed spankings from his dad, into the closet that housed the vinyl.

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Joseph, Sr., was physically abusive to his wife, as well as his son, and before long the family split up. Flash and his siblings moved with their mom from Throggs Neck to Fox Street, in the South Bronx. Amid so much chaos, and perhaps—although Flash never makes this connection—because of it, Joseph, Jr., hyper-fixated on electronics. He ripped apart record players and other gadgets, terrorizing the rest of his family with his curiosity and his surgeon’s willingness to attempt to operate on the bodies of household appliances. The tunnel vision that would make him a genius to the wider world first marked him as bad at home.

His mother had the wisdom to send him to a vocational-and-technical school where Flash learned the rudiments of amplified sound. Soon, he could put the gadgets back together, and even produce versions of them. Pining after the power of the disco d.j.s on the radio, he made his own d.j. set. But he still wanted to know: How could he keep the best parts of his favorite songs playing over and over? “The root of everything I was trying to discover was based on science and math,” he wrote.

Flash tricked out his homemade d.j. set, adding a felt bed for his records instead of the standard metal platter. He marked up the surface of his vinyls with crayons so that he could know when exactly the “break” of a song—the drum break that dependably made the partyers go wild—began and ended. He then figured out a blasphemous move: touching the surface of the records with his fingers to drag them in the opposite direction of the turntable’s motion, thus starting the break over. He used two copies of every

record—toggling back and forth, catching the beat each go-round with impeccable timing, giving the illusion that the drum break never stopped, that it had always, at least implicitly, been a slice of something infinite, and that now, under his trance, it would never stop, until he gave it a chance to mercifully die. Then he mixed one break with another, sometimes letting them bleed together, sometimes making an abrupt switch that felt like a natural fact. True to his lifelong experimental bent, he called his invention the Quik Mix Theory.

Flash knew of the two other d.j.s who were working in the Bronx at the time, with whom he'd later share credit for the genesis of hip-hop. There was Kool Herc, who was one of the pioneers of the "needle drop" technique for extending breaks, and who had the best speaker setup in town. And there was Afrika Bambaataa, who had the widest and most cosmopolitan collection of records of the three, the most sophisticated sense of the history of Black sound, and a reputation for uniting rival gangs and reorienting them toward peaceful community aims. Neither, though, had the technical mastery of Flash, nor did they have his knack for the mathematics of the dance floor. Flash would glide from break to break, taking parts of the Incredible Bongo Band's rendition of "Apache"—whose great effect, according to his "science," "was the way they put the reverb on the snare," their kick like "thunder and lightning"—and fitting them together with, say, "Heaven and Hell Is on Earth," by 20th Century Steel Band, knitting a quilt of sometimes quite disparate older music and making of it something thrillingly new. He couldn't stand to let the tension drop for even a second. If hip-hop seems excessive, this is why: its sound was invented, at least in part, to deliver too much of a good thing.

The early chapters of "Birth of a Culture" are devoted to telling Grandmaster Flash's origin story, but the rest of the book is an episodic telling of hip-hop's later history; Flash talks about or interviews rappers such as LL Cool J and Q-Tip in order to establish bonds of continuity between his achievement and theirs. (His first book, "The Adventures of Grandmaster Flash: My Life, My Beats," from 2008, was a more straightforward memoir.) He is careful not to make his accomplishments, or hip-hop itself, sound like the product of a solitary genius. He always gives credit to Herc and Bambaataa, despite his personal (and, often, sonic)

conflicts with the former. And he points out the aspects of life in the tough South Bronx—“no crystal stair,” to borrow a phrase from Langston Hughes—which enabled the rise of hip-hop. A party at 1520 Sedgwick Avenue, on August 11, 1973, thrown by Herc and his sister, has been mythologized as the unofficial beginning of the genre, but the truth is that throughout the seventies there were dozens of events like this, many of them held outdoors, in parks. Flash would rewire a street light to provide power for his turntables and speakers, and local kids—usually girls—passed out fliers and served as impromptu publicity teams. Shared space and equipment were put to rogue purposes, funkily repurposing municipal goods for the people. The d.j.s practiced in community centers and Police Athletic League locations, or, say, in the basement of a building where somebody’s dad was the superintendent or had otherwise come into possession of a spare key. Parents of friends would give Flash records from their collections, scarcely aware of what transformations their dusty music would undergo. A neighborhood girl named Anna, according to Flash, improvised the word “hip-hop” while drilling her brother who had signed up for the military:

Cookie started teasing their brother in cadence, “Your left, your left, your left, right, left!” And as she was doing that the other girls, including Anna, were saying, “Hip-hop-hip-hop, it don’t stop,” in the same military-type cadence, but with a rhythm like we were at a jam. She said they were doing that because that’s the way the soldiers walked. “One-two-one-two, pivot, turn, one-two-one-two.”

Anna, in Flash’s telling, was a kind of verbal virtuoso, a proto-rapper who rallied her similarly talented girlfriends to provide lines for the largely male m.c.s who rhymed over Flash’s soundscapes. The point of these anecdotes isn’t to direct sole credit to Anna—there are many rival accounts of the origin of the name “hip-hop”—but to illustrate the communal nature of the beginnings of the music and the culture.

This teeming togetherness becomes evident even in Flash’s music. Listen, for instance, to “The Adventures of Grandmaster Flash on the Wheels of Steel,” from 1981, the first record to showcase the Quik Mix Theory. During the recording session, Flash used three turntables instead of the customary two, so urgently did he feel the need to crowd the song with

intriguing earfuls. The cut luxuriates in the pure sound of the songs that make up its collage. The cool, feline bass lines from Queen's "Another One Bites the Dust" and Blondie's "Rapture" are enlisted to form a spine, jangling against each other with a dissonant elegance. A snippet of the falsetto vocal from "Good Times," by Chic, materializes and dissolves like a sun shower. "Apache," that favorite track of the nascent hip-hop cognoscenti, appears with a knowing wink. Each of these references is made to dance via hypnotic repetition, each graffitied by the sleek scratches that Flash made with his fingers on the vinyl.



"In a way, I suppose everything is autobiographical."
Cartoon by Mike Twohy

Flash is always, in different ways, calling himself a cloistered geek in his book. But "The Adventures of Grandmaster Flash" is the work of a confident cosmopolitan, someone who achieves his most important education outside on the streets, after dark. The scenario that comes to mind is of standing on a city corner at the promising beginning of a hot Saturday night, under a blue-black sky, perhaps waiting for a group of friends to show up, listening with a passive intensity to the music pouring out of car windows as they speed by. The rock kids, the funk kids, the disco-ers, the club rats are all fleetingly conjoined by one pair of highly attuned ears loitering on the streets. It's the ultimate dance music, the flowering of Flash's initial desire: to keep the liveliest part of the party going forever.

New York City in the seventies and early eighties, the crucial backdrop for hip-hop's rise, was a Technicolor place of exaggerated ironies. In 1975, banks stopped underwriting the city's daunting debt, which caused a fiscal crisis. The answer was austerity. Layoffs swept New York, and youth services suffered cutbacks. People left in droves. Landlords in search of insurance payouts set fire—often fatally—to abandoned buildings in the Bronx, dozens at a time at the height of the phenomenon; the now famous conflagrations glowed like bright symbols of urban decay. Drugs ravaged the streets, leaving needles and even more emptiness in their wake.

But the hollowed-out city became an impromptu stage, especially for the Black teen-agers who, in ad-hoc and decentralized fits and starts, bred the culture with which Flash is so clearly still besotted. Privation couldn't stop the creative urge. Kids were spray-painting impressive murals on the sides of buildings and the bodies of subway cars. Others practiced a new form of highly kinetic, implicitly aggressive dance which would later be called b-boying, or break dancing. One of these early hip-hoppers was Flash's eventual friend Fred Brathwaite, known on the streets as Fab 5 Freddy. Earlier this year, Freddy released his own memoir, "Everybody's Fly." He was a natural sophisticate whose father was close friends with the jazz drummer Max Roach, and he was a lifelong museumgoer who didn't understand why he and his fellow-graffitiers couldn't be considered fine artists. He came into the company of Jean-Michel Basquiat and Keith Haring, plus Debbie Harry from Blondie.

Hip-hop wasn't the only growing vogue—punk was coming of age, and New Wave was becoming more popular. Black or white, uptown or downtown, it was art-obsessed kids who gave New York its brilliant spark back. Freddy straddled all these worlds, observing their points of intersection and grooves of adjacency. In his book, he muses, for instance, about how "dancehall reggae's toasting, New York City's mobile d.j. scene, and rap developed almost simultaneously . . . largely inspired by slick, jive-talking Black disc jockeys on the radio." And he was dazzled by Flash, too, whose heretically physical way with records—touching and scratching the vinyl like a vandal—reminded him of the heedless white kids he'd come to know downtown. "He was breaking all the rules, which was the most punk

thing you could do,” Freddy writes of Flash. “Rap and punk: They were both so wrong they were right.”

Lots of people were running around the Bronx with the name Grandmaster back in the day—a d.j. named Grandmaster Flowers was first, according to Flash. Grandmaster Caz, of the Cold Crush Brothers, was another. Nothing too new there. As a kid, I always wondered if that title, this in-group’s slightly humorous mark of high-ranking nobility, was a fly retort to the dorky Grand Wizards of the Ku Klux Klan, the dangerous losers in the pointy hats with so much terror on their minds. The realm of racism and hatred and death, that kingdom whose violence had spurred the Great Migration, which had in turn created the sometimes harrowing urban conditions that gave hip-hop its environment and *raison d’être*—they had their weird nomenclature, so why not us?

“Birth of a Culture” might have a similar joke embedded in its title, sharing, as it does, a phrasal structure with “The Birth of a Nation,” D. W. Griffith’s racist apologia for the K.K.K., which also happened to be the first-ever multi-reel blockbuster. Like all of hip-hop’s early heroes, Flash is fixated on the genre’s history—righting its wrongs, fighting a headwind of faulty tellings over the years. He knows that the practice of d.j.’ing—the real origin of hip-hop—has long since been overshadowed by the art of rapping. (He helped this along, too, by recruiting talented rappers—guys nicknamed Kidd Creole, Melle Mel, Scorpio, Cowboy, and Rahiem—to form his backing group, the Furious Five.) But, still, he feels he has to get things straight, perhaps because he knows that the power of a people, and of a culture, comes in part from the practice of fruitfully and generously interpreting the facts that gave them their rise.

In one omission, however, Flash praises Bambaataa’s message of love and peace, but conspicuously fails to mention the many credible allegations of child sexual assault that marred Bambaataa’s later life and career. And Flash has gripes with how things went down. One of the most famous songs in the history of hip-hop, “The Message,” was released as a Grandmaster Flash and the Furious Five record, even though Flash and his Quik Mix Theory appear nowhere in its music. (“I think it would have been a bigger record had our formula as a group been on that record telling that story,” he wrote.)

He doesn't like that Herc claims to have invented the "merry-go-round" technique of multiple d.j.s taking turns on the table, balancing the beat together, without citing Flash. When everyone goes gaga for the practice of sampling, he feels left out in the cold: "It becomes weird and very alarming when you watch something—a concept, an idea, a practice, a love, a theory—that you created evolve in front of your eyes, and you do not get any credit for what that idea has been turned into."

In 2007, Grandmaster Flash and the Furious Five became the first hip-hop act to enter the Rock & Roll Hall of Fame. In 2023, Flash was the subject of a soft-focus interview on the "Today" show, to celebrate the fiftieth anniversary of hip-hop's invention. He emphasized his happiness at the genre's development. "Something that is loved by so many people has to change and has to go through its changes and do different things," he said. "It has to."

Here's all the credit he needs: get some friends together, ones who really know how to catch a beat and feel it in their bodies, put on a Grandmaster Flash record, and watch the world spin. ♦

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[Books](#)

The Art of American Sophistication

How striving, self-invention, and charm became a national style.

By [Adam Gopnik](#)

September 7, 2026



America's signature sense of taste, cool, and sophistication is something we acquire by seeming always to have possessed it. Illustration by John Broadley

The prompt, let's say, is "American sophistication." What does it make the L.L.M. in our heads, trawling the riverbed of our old reading and viewing, produce? Whom do we think of first? Fred Astaire, I suspect, still comes to mind as the exemplar, even among many of those who know him only from stills or streaming. And, if we have a rudimentary knowledge of who he was and where he came from, we can begin to discern a larger pattern: he was not a New Yorker but a Midwesterner, a boy from Omaha, Nebraska, pushed along by a strenuous stage mother, the son of an Austrian Jewish father. His distinctive manner was eerily captured by Scott Fitzgerald, himself a refugee from the Middle West, in his description of Gatsby, *another* escaped Midwesterner, as someone possessing "that resourcefulness of movement that is so peculiarly American . . . He was

never quite still; there was always a tapping foot somewhere or the impatient opening and closing of a hand.” Astaire to the life. He could have played the part perfectly.

For that matter, Cole Porter, Astaire’s greatest word-giver and another model of sophistication, as we commonly use the word, arrived at Yale from Peru, Indiana. So perhaps American sophistication is something that begins, like a Broadway show, out of town. But is this more a general rule than an American peculiarity? Maurice Chevalier and Cary Grant are the first two names that the prompt might supply for France and England. Chevalier was the working-class son of an alcoholic housepainter; Cary, born Archibald Leach, was neglected by his father, a tailor’s presser, and became a travelling acrobat before immigrating to New York. His debonair manner—which came to embody an American ideal of sophistication even more than an English one—was as hard-won as Edmund Hillary’s summit. Much the same can be said of Noël Coward, who learned his crisp enunciation through sheer aspirational effort. The one poshly reared product of high-period Hollywood was Humphrey Bogart, who grew up in a wealthy Manhattan household among private schools and tennis courts, and whose authentic upper-class sneer first found its natural American use as the expression of a desperate, cornered criminal.

Sophistication, one begins to think, is a thing won against the grain of privilege—a substitute for it, a social sleight of hand. A “classy” entertainer is almost never someone from the upper classes; sophisticated people are mostly smart people passing as rich people. At its sharpest, this inversion conferred titles of nobility on those denied social ease: the only Americans ever credibly, rather than jeeringly, called Duke and Count were Black musicians who spent their exhausted lives on buses and trains, and in segregated diners. At the same time, the Wasp élite regarded the top-hat-and-tails sophistication of the Astaire sort as amusingly forced and fraudulent, their own sophistication being evidenced by slightly frayed trousers, white-bread sandwiches, and suits worn for half a century. (There’s a whole world of Wasp resorts whose positive value is their sheer shabbiness.) Only truly sophisticated taste, in this code, grasps the superiority of deprivation over the more ethnic notions of actual comfort and good food.

Now Ross Posnock, an emeritus professor at Columbia who has previously written thoughtfully on Philip Roth, among many other subjects, offers an encyclopedic study of this one, “American Sophistication: How the Casual Became Cool” (Princeton). The book is breathtakingly large in scope and purpose, tracking the ideal from pre-Revolutionary America to the postmodern age. Almost flamboyantly digressive and parenthetical—with long excursions into Henry James’s memoirs and the elegance, or lack of it, among the *Partisan Review* crowd—it will invite plenty of quarrels and cavils. A good thing, since a book of this kind should provide stimulation rather than what Humpty Dumpty would have called a knockdown argument. A big, comprehensive book on, say, the history of cancer or the evolution of astrophysics should give us irreproachable information and sound conclusions. But from a book on a general squishy human subject like sophistication or masculinity or eros we want something else. We don’t need to be persuaded; we want to be provoked.

And we are, so much so that we might come to think that the idea of sophistication, like that of intelligence, is a composite chimera, hardly worth analyzing. Yet we know what we mean when we use it. A Paul Simon song like “Something So Right,” with its jazzy dominant ninth chords, is sophisticated in a way that “Bridge Over Troubled Water” is not. The term seems to imply a mastery of all the resources of a form, displayed in a surprising context without self-conscious artfulness. That’s Astaire: a perfectionist with Mozartean skills as a tap dancer but no pretensions to ballet. Or Ellington, a genius of harmony, one of whose greatest surviving works is a dance-hall concert recorded in Fargo. No one would think to call Stravinsky or Mondrian “sophisticated” in this sense, since their reputations already assume it. Sophistication implies a rising from a simpler background. You could do it the obvious way; you chose another.

Posnock’s pages on Astaire and Ellington are among those in which the argument locks most satisfyingly into place while still striking some original notes. He sees Astaire as both “a glorious exception to the rule of American ambivalence about sophistication” and “a distinctive version of that anxiety.” One expression of that anxiety, he shrewdly points out, is Astaire’s almost invariable pairing in the classic R.K.O. films not just with Ginger Rogers but with a fussy, effete opposite number, often Edward

Everett Horton, Jr., whose presence marks Astaire's dancing more securely as masculine.

Posnock is equally good on Ellington's cultivation of "composure," an achieved serenity in music and life alike, and on the repressed anger that this presumably cost him. He tellingly quotes the photographer Gordon Parks on Ellington's "socializing of cool": "Ellington never grinned. He smiled. Ellington never shuffled. He strode. It was 'Good afternoon, ladies and gentlemen,' never 'How y'all doin'?' " He was extending into Black show business the strict code that he had learned in his Black bourgeois family, in Washington, D.C. Yet, Posnock notes, "his statement of transparent filial piety contains a wink within its sincerity, a reminder of the artifice involved in possessing a manner"—a truth that he could well have confided to Astaire.

Posnock is also strong on what someone must have named the Grant-Leach dichotomy, and he generally lands on the right people and the right points. He has a flair for aphorism: "Sophistication insists that being and appearing coincide. We do not express sophistication; we appear sophisticated." (True, certainly, of Astaire and Ellington.)

A persistent difficulty, though, is that Posnock seems to use "sophistication" to describe two very different categories of people, without ever quite distinguishing between them. There is the term as we use it of Astaire or Ellington. That's Sophistication One: effortless elegance and apparent ease. But he also uses it in another way, Sophistication Two, for people who are broadly erudite across a surprising range of subjects, such as the *New Yorker* critic Edmund Wilson, whom he greatly admires—but whom one can't imagine in a top hat, or even in a well-cut suit, or as an ornament at a dinner party.

The members of the first clan are hardly intellectual at all; indeed, the follies of intellect are part of what they mock or, in Grant's case, have to escape to become worthy of Katharine Hepburn (e.g., "Bringing Up Baby"). The members of the second clan, meanwhile, can't be relied on to dance or to wear clothes well—just look at the images of Wilson on the beach at Truro, holding forth in a dress shirt. A very few figures cross or combine the two types, most notably Leonard Bernstein, to whom Posnock

devotes some good pages. Bernstein was a know-it-all who was also a showoff, to put it bluntly, with both qualities neatly packaged as high style. If we need an ideal type of the American sophisticate, Bernstein is it.

And what, as Edward Everett Horton might have sighed sibilantly in one of those R.K.O. movies, of the distaff side? The book is a bit thin on sophisticated ladies. Several friends of mine, when prompted, gave Jackie O. as their first choice; she appears here only briefly, as an adjunct to J.F.K. Hepburn gets a single reference against Grant's multiple ones. Sadly scanted are the still underrated writers Dawn Powell and Anita Loos, whose genius for putting extremely canny judgments in the mouth of her seeming simpleton Lorelei Lee is exactly what we mean by a sophisticated joke. The novelist and journalist Mary McCarthy, by contrast, is discussed at length, though her inclusion even in the second sense seems unconvincing. What gives her work its bite is not so much assured knowingness as a persistently disingenuous sense of surprise. Florence, sex on trains, the Vietnam War, Lillian Hellman's dishonesty—McCarthy registers a kind of wide-eyed disbelief at everything she encounters.

The book does eventually reveal an arc and find a climax. Posnock firmly identifies the nineteen-fifties as the high-water mark of American sophistication. From there, he rises to a kind of grand unified theory of the subject, complete with a family tree: "Younger New York sophisticates coming of age in the 1950s and 1960s, among them Mike Nichols, Jean Stein, Sontag, Jason Epstein, Baldwin, Avedon, George Plimpton, and Stephen Sondheim, affirmed urbanity as if a birthright (and in some cases, it in fact was) and their inevitable subject matter." He continues, "Inspiring both generations were the Olympian models of national sophistication who had been reigning since the 1920s and 1930s: Astaire, Ellington, Grant, and Katharine Hepburn"—a "critical mass of sophistication as enacted ideal."

He rightly insists that the satirical duo of Nichols and Elaine May were the most rewarding and complex comedians of their time, or ours, because they built their act around a failed sophistication, in their improvised characters, that presupposed an achieved sophistication in their audience scarcely imaginable a decade earlier. They harvested the comic fruit of the great revolution in liberal education, which marked the period when, as Auden

wrote, soldiers who had stood up to the Nazi assault were now “shot to pieces by the shorter / Poems of Donne.” The great Nichols-and-May lines —“I can never believe that Bartók died on Central Park West,” or, on Albert Schweitzer, that he was “a lot of laughs” though “I personally have never dated him”—still ring as portraits of arrivistes eager to show that they know what everyone around them is expected to know. (The two met, it turns out, at the University of Chicago during its great heyday, though neither graduated, and May didn’t even enroll.)

Curiously, Posnock is cautious, even grudging, toward the apotheosis of this moment and this style in the brief Presidency of J.F.K., whose apparent display of sophistication he treats skeptically, as a kind of façade drawn up for the masses, a goatee painted on his face by Jackie. But, compared with his predecessors and successors, J.F.K. really does seem to incarnate both types of American sophistication: he knew how to dress and how to make a dry joke, and he was genuinely erudite, at least given the field. He didn’t entirely write the books he bylined, but his enthusiasm for David Cecil’s “The Young Melbourne” was very real.

In a work so dense with references, mistakes will sprout like crabgrass; write a big book on André Le Nôtre’s formal gardens and the earthworm experts will gather to deride your confusion. The more you know the ground, the more crabgrass you see. So *The New Yorker*, in developing its distinct sophisticated voice, wasn’t really trying to be “urbane”; its decisive turn came when the anti-urbane E. B. White and James Thurber became the magazine’s voice, insisting that nothing could be more chic than to reminisce about Columbus, Ohio, or escape to Maine. The magazine’s urbanity lay in the anti-urbanism of its singular voices. Its most characteristic contributor, John Updike, left New York as quickly as he could for the fleshpots of Ipswich, Massachusetts, and made that and its people his subject for half a century. (Posnock also makes perhaps unduly heavy weather of the opening scene of the 2022 movie “Tár,” treating a scripted exchange—in which a character bearing this writer’s name and impersonated by this writer interviews a fictional musician—as though it were a spontaneous metropolitan conversation.)

A larger idea survives these local confusions and is neatly summed up by Posnock's subtitle: casualness added to elegance is the particularly American contribution to the kind. Ellington and Astaire are surely instant winners by this definition. Like any general truth about a vast country and culture over a long period of time, it is bound to be a half-truth, but, then, all sociological truths are half-truths, and this one seems hardy enough to make its half as close to whole as we can hope to get.

But is a more illuminating idea missing from his account of American sophistication, one that perhaps most neatly distinguishes it from older European kinds? Since the Renaissance, the European ideal has rested on the pursuit, or, rather, the nonpursuit, of sprezzatura, unhurried grace, an ideal Posnock recognizes and celebrates. Certainly, the greatest image of sophistication ever conjured is Raphael's 1514 portrait, now in the Louvre, of Baldassare Castiglione, who gave the ideal its name. The work is a miracle of resourcefulness: a "Venetian" portrait, painterly, almost monotone, and shimmering, by an Urbinate trained in sharp-edged drawing. Its point, if a painting can be said to have a point, is that the perfect gentleman doesn't make a fuss, just as he doesn't overdress. It is a pasquinade against posing.

Yet Castiglione's sprezzatura, though humane, is not in itself charming. American sophistication has its sprezzatura—Astaire made an art of it—but characteristically turns effortlessness outward, into charm, something ingratiating and democratic-seeming. Charm is what turns the arriviste's effort into a social gift. As the Cambridge critic Adrian Poole and others have observed, Henry James uses "charm" over and over, almost obsessively, the way Shakespeare uses "sweet" as his highest term of praise. It belongs to James's own inescapable Americanness, and to his effort to delineate an American style. No English or French author would have used it in quite the same way. Proust uses "*charme*" often enough, but usually to mark the limits of an illusion. We are charmed by the charming Odette as a snake is charmed, held swaying in wonder, only to be disillusioned afterward.

American "charm," as James incarnates it in characters from Daisy Miller, in her own novella, to Isabel Archer, in "The Portrait of a Lady," is a kind of

weaponized naïveté: innocence about the rules joined to impatience with following them, which wins the hearts of those who know the rules and would secretly rather not see them followed. What James means by “charm” is naïveté married to aesthetic ambition. Behind American sophistication lies the charm of American ambition: not where we find ourselves effortlessly but where we’ve put ourselves purposefully. Daisy wants to see the Colosseum by moonlight; it’s a foolish, and ultimately fatal, ambition, but in its way a fine one. Astaire’s dance steps are always directional, carrying him somewhere and toward something—the girl, the boat, the park bench.

And that alloy of innocence and impatience connects Astaire with Grant, whose tone, though we call it “sophisticated,” is less hauteur than genial affability punctuated by exasperation. The balance is intelligence against impatience, warmth against energy: the physical restlessness of Gatsby and Astaire, or Whistler’s refusal of finish, the most American of painters in his very expatriation, who said that “completeness is a reason for ceasing to exist.” The late Calvin Tomkins’s “Living Well Is the Best Revenge,” a biography of Gerald and Sara Murphy, describes how an overeager American couple became, through a kind of wonderful unself-conscious bluff, the cynosure of European modernity. The Murphys went to the South of France off-season, both a terribly ingenuous choice and a shrewdly worldly one that everyone copied. That mix of wide-eyed naïveté and pragmatic nous does seem typically American. Even Ellington’s willed composure is the composure of the afterglow, to use a term he liked—the calm that follows exertion, rather than the grace that pretends exertion never happened.

Posnock ends, dourly but necessarily, on the inevitable evil figure: Donald Trump as the opposite of any kind of sophistication. Instead, this “graceless” figure reminds us that true sophistication can help immunize us against “the depths of the subterranean.” Yet America was once, and at moments still is, a place of passionate pilgrims and new arrivals; as the old advertising slogan put it, We try harder.

When my wife and I first arrived in New York, we went, as often as we could afford, to the Bemelmans Bar, then a dark, cool, largely unvisited

place at the Carlyle Hotel, with its beautiful, half-lit, uncleaned murals of children in an imaginary Central Park. (I went after my first seminar report and was so unprepared for the effects of a Black Russian on a grad student that I passed out and had to be lifted from the carpet by the Italian waiters.) It was our nearest approach to sophistication. Later, it became an object of amusement to our genuinely sophisticated friends, one of whom sent a photo of Ludwig Bemelmans with the slightly supercilious text “See you at the bar!” There was something naïve about our twentysomething readiness to try on so roomy an overcoat of sophistication, but, looking back, I suppose that this could have been . . . part of our charm. If there was doubtless something pathetic in the pursuit—we could have been down at CBGB, being punks—all culture begins in imitation, with the hope of growing into what one pretends to be.

Nowadays, the Bemelmans Bar overflows with tourists fresh off the bus and twentysomethings who have pre-screened it on Instagram, and has lost its old, beautiful emptiness, but doubtless the same pull that drew us draws them. Perhaps sophistication is not a way of feeling superior to the world but a wish that the world would itself *become* superior. Sophistication seems a shared longing more than a set style; it’s the desire to see the world shine brighter than it does while still knowing that all the light that shines from it is the light we bring to it. In a darkening time, maybe it isn’t so shabby an aspiration. The luminous Bemelmans himself began his life in New York as a busboy, was then promoted to waiter, and only afterward emerged as an artist: one more ambitious American arriviste, like Astaire, like Porter, like Gatsby, like the rest of us. ♦

[Adam Gopnik](#), a staff writer, has been contributing to *The New Yorker* since 1986. His books include “[The Real Work: On the Mystery of Mastery](#).”

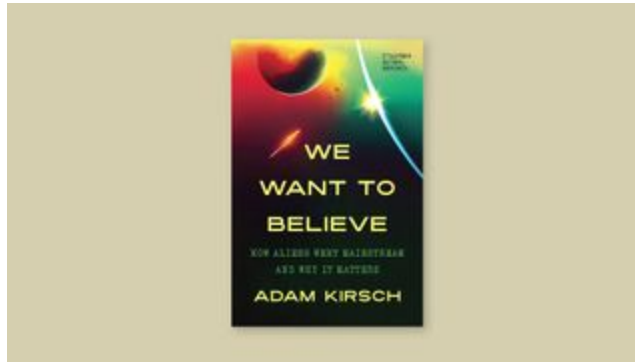
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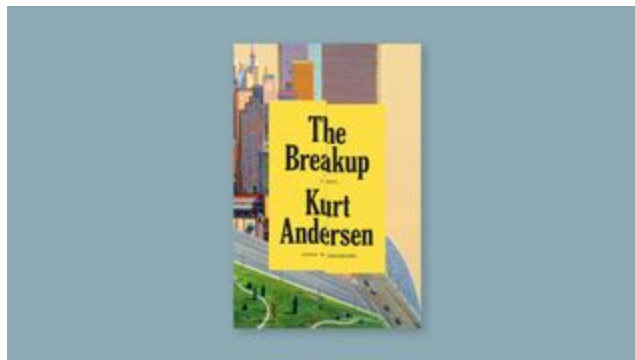
Briefly Noted

“The Breakup,” “All Them Dogs,” “Sex and Dissent,” and “We Want to Believe.”

September 7, 2026



The Breakup, by Kurt Andersen (Random House). This comic novel is set in a hysterical vision of the year 2045, in which what was once the United States has been split apart by a civil war between liberals and a *MAGA*-like rebel group. The country is now divided into the so-called Free American Republic and what remains of the U.S. In this tense, uneasy landscape, a separated couple, Natalie and Asher, reunite to take their child, Logan, on a trip to tour colleges in both territories. Asher and Natalie’s disunion serves as almost a microcosm of the country: he a rabidly engaged liberal and she a head-in-the-sand moderate. The book is enlivened by Andersen’s gift for satire, which plays up the comic potential of ideological extremes.



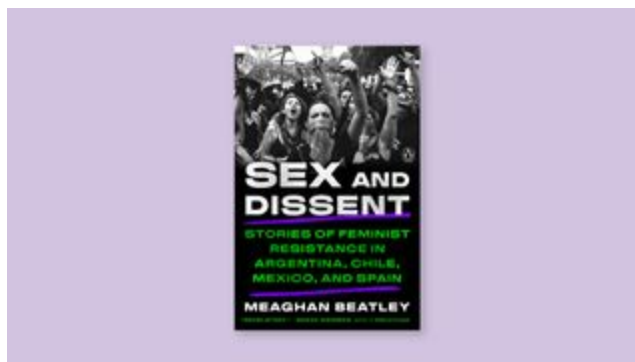
All Them Dogs, by Djamel White (*Riverhead*). “I was Wardy. Tony bleeding Ward. Lethal weapon forged in 1997,” the protagonist of this bold debut novel proclaims. The statement is mainly a reminder to himself, as he returns home to Dublin after five long years on the run. Tony had to flee after killing a member of a rival gang; now he has joined the ranks of another outfit, notionally in search of money and protection, but ultimately out of a longing to have “someone else do the thinking.” As Tony strains to navigate brewing street wars, the most intimidating battles he faces are still internal—between expectation and desire, between who he is and who he might want to be.

What We’re Reading



Illustration by Henri Campeã

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Sex and Dissent, by Meaghan Beatley (*Penguin*). This vividly reported book centers on recent feminist movements in Argentina, Chile, Mexico, and Spain. Beatley, a journalist, profiles women protesting abortion restrictions, sexual assault, and femicide—an act that, she writes, lies “atop layers of normalized and socially sanctioned abuse.” While documenting acts of resistance, she examines the way that these feminists’ cultural

contexts inflect their organizing. As she points out, many were influenced by struggles against military dictatorships of the twentieth century; some are the children of disappeared dissidents. “What sets Latin America apart is not violence itself but the clarity with which women understand its roots,” she writes.



We Want to Believe, by Adam Kirsch (*Columbia Global Reports*). In recent decades, technological advances have vastly expanded our knowledge of the universe and led to the discovery of thousands of exoplanets. This has coincided with a widespread belief that humans will inevitably confirm that extraterrestrials exist. But, Kirsch argues in this concise treatise, the fact that our search has so far yielded nothing decreases the probability that we’ll ever find intelligent life beyond Earth. Why, then, has public opinion moved in the opposite direction from the science? Kirsch contends that the rise of serious discussion about extraterrestrials has paralleled the decline of the “traditional religious vocabularies” that once helped people grapple with the deepest questions of existence. In the end, he writes, “all our thinking about aliens and how to find them is best understood as humanity’s evolving self-portrait.”

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[The Art World](#)

Willem de Kooning's Excavations of Intimacy

The first major show of the artist's drawings articulates his pain and anger and the frightful era he lived in.

By [Hilton Als](#)

September 7, 2026



The artist who made “Excavation” (1950) was inconsolable, wounded, wry, unforgiving. Art work by Willem de Kooning / Courtesy © 2026 The Willem de Kooning Foundation / ARS; Photograph by Robert Lifson / The Art Institute of Chicago

Drawings, like dreams, can often feel open-ended, prompting a multiplicity of thoughts. As painting's poor cousins, they usually command a lesser fee in the art market, and their position somewhat to the left of capital may account—at least in part—for the fantastic, unfixed energy you often find in them: an artist draws not in the service of a career but in search of a self. Drawings, for me, are a kind of calligraphy of the soul, and, as you take in “Willem de Kooning Drawing” (at the Art Institute of Chicago through September 20th), it's the enormous spirit behind many of the works—a searching spirit—that holds your attention, as do the artist's questions about line, volume, voice, what the eye sees, and what the hand is capable of.

De Kooning drew throughout his long creative life. (He died in 1997, at the age of ninety-two.) When he allowed the younger artist Robert Rauschenberg to erase one of his drawings for the piece “Erased de Kooning Drawing” (1953), he knew that part of the poetry of the work would be the idea of him watching himself disappear. It would have been a nice touch to include “Erased de Kooning Drawing”—a bridge between modernist and postmodernist thinking—in this first major show of de Kooning’s works on paper, but, even without seeing it, you can keep it in mind as you study de Kooning’s own ghostly markings.

De Kooning, who grew up with almost nothing and then had everything, struggled with both deprivation and abundance. His story? It’s such an American one, especially if you think of having grown up elsewhere as definitively American. Born in Rotterdam in 1904, he was the child of Cornelia and Leendert de Kooning. His father, closed off and remote, tried to make a living bottling beer. His mother, hemmed in by poverty and the limitations of gender, had a dramatic personality and thought nothing of expressing her rage. Her anger was the great event of her life—and of her son’s. De Kooning’s affable but aloof personality was formed in part in reaction to Cornelia’s volubility; as a young man, he became known for his ability to defuse fights in bars and for his interest in theatrical women. His parents separated when he was two, and he shuttled back and forth between them through his childhood and adolescence. Still, his destitution and his spiritual orphanhood did nothing to eclipse the pleasure that he found, from an early age, in drawing.



"Self-Portrait with Imaginary Brother," ca. 1938. Art work by Willem de Kooning / Courtesy © 2026 The Willem de Kooning Foundation / ARS

There was no explaining de Kooning's aptitude for art. Though he didn't get far in his formal education—he left school at the age of twelve, and that was that—his teachers noticed his talent, and so did Cornelia's second husband, Jacobus Lassooy, a barkeep. Because drawing was a marketable skill, Lassooy took the boy to various places to see if he could get work. He was accepted as an apprentice at a design firm that specialized in interior decoration. De Kooning's renderings there were strong enough that, after some time, his boss encouraged him to apply to the Academie van Beeldende Kunsten en Technische Wetenschappen, a technical art school in Rotterdam.

In the school's drawing program, de Kooning copied classical works, mostly from Greece. He was also trained in commercial art. The experience forever bonded him to artisans. As Mark Stevens and Annalyn Swan point out in their definitive 2004 biography, *"De Kooning: An American Master,"* the young de Kooning's development was unlike that "of many later artists, who grew up when becoming an artist was considered more a matter of

temperament than of know-how. De Kooning began by learning the hows, rather than the whys. His hand led his mind.” Rotterdam was a port town, and its red-light district, full of music and women—and conveniently situated near the Academie—was one of the jazziest in Holland. That scene, the energy of it, nourished de Kooning: the accidents of life, the meetings and partings in an environment dominated by sound, fed his imagination, as did his dreams of freedom, and of becoming an artist.

After finishing his fourth year at the Academie, de Kooning went to work as a commercial artist for Cohn Donnay and Company, a large department store. His supervisor, Bernard Romein, encouraged the restless youth to stay in school and helped open his mind to the world of art. The De Stijl movement, Mondrian, Bauhaus: Romein turned de Kooning onto all of this. But Holland was a backwater when it came to modern art. In 1924, de Kooning spent time in Belgium—to prepare himself, he said, for going to America—and while there he drew a series of cartoons. We see a bunch of them at the beginning of “Willem de Kooning Drawing”: light, all-on-the-surface illustrations. The best one, untitled and executed in Conté crayon and pencil (ca. 1924), shows a girl, perhaps in her early teens, holding a dark balloon, while a boy beside her grips a lighter-colored one, on a shorter stick—a not insignificant psychological detail. There are two younger boys to the girl’s left, but the girl is the emotional center of this piece. Stevens and Swan, among others, identify this drawing as an early example of de Kooning’s fascination with the female figure and power, but, at the show, I was less interested in the cartoons than in the part they played in his move to America.

The work that excited de Kooning in those years was the illustration he saw in American magazines. He wanted to be an illustrator, and in 1926, when he was twenty-two, without saying goodbye to his family he stowed away on a freighter and travelled to Hoboken, New Jersey. By 1927, he was in Manhattan, living in the kind of here-but-where limbo that characterizes the immigrant experience. At first, de Kooning found work painting signs and designing window displays. In 1935, he was hired by the Federal Art Project of the Works Progress Administration to create murals, and although the gig lasted barely two years, it was pivotal in helping him give up his commercial mind-set and concentrate on the difficult task of finding his

own voice as a visual artist. At the W.P.A., de Kooning could work on a larger scale, but what story would he tell to fill this new expansiveness?



Untitled cartoon, ca. 1924. Art work by Willem de Kooning / Courtesy © 2026 The Willem de Kooning Foundation / ARS; Photograph by Useful Art Services

New York opened the world of modern art to de Kooning. Admired for his seriousness and for his eagerness to learn, as well as for his movie-star face and sturdy body, de Kooning was a looker in a city full of lookers. He went from a paucity of love to a series of sometimes overlapping, complicated relationships. He was also porous, open to being claimed by older artists, as he had been by his mentors in Holland. The New York that he settled in was teeming with new, experimental talent, including Stuart Davis and Arshile Gorky, who had fled Armenia during the genocide and with whom de Kooning shared a close and uneasy friendship—but what other kind is there between mentor and protégé? De Kooning relied on the experience of more seasoned artists to tell him who to become. Gorky was using

European traditions—Roberto Matta’s Surrealism, Picasso’s neoclassicism, Cézanne’s explorations—to make work that captured New York’s sexiness, skittishness, and force. The mind-and-eye-expanding “Water of the Flowery Mill” (1944), like a number of his other paintings, builds on a series of lines that coalesce in an expanse of colors that shadow and seemingly swim away from one another. Gorky’s art not only presaged the Abstract Expressionism of which de Kooning would become a towering figure; it also pointed the way to color-field painting.

It’s moving to spend time at “Willem de Kooning Drawing” looking for Gorky; it’s like searching for any unknowable father. Gorky and Davis are evoked, rather than imitated, in “Three Studies of Men” (1938). The drawing shows one man sitting, one standing, and one almost fading into the background. The standing man waves an admonishing finger at the passive, seated one; he is perhaps an older man looking at a younger friend or a student. The drawing has the feeling of a dream—that dream in which you unwittingly let your mentor down. I believe that Gorky also shows up in the great “Self-Portrait with Imaginary Brother” (ca. 1938), which isn’t at the Art Institute, though you can find it in the show’s catalogue. In the drawing, two male figures are rendered in pencil. They stand together, their hands almost touching; one holds a ball, the other a pencil. The symbolism would be comical if they didn’t look out at the viewer with such tenderness, a tenderness that inhabits the drawing itself, which is faint, as though you were seeing it through mist or memory. At the Academie, de Kooning had learned to “smudge”—to rub the fine lines of a pencil drawing with his fingers—a way of visually marrying technique with what I see as the accident of feeling, a controlled mistake. By smudging himself and another male figure, perhaps inspired by Gorky, de Kooning brought his emotional life, his desire, to the page, just as Rauschenberg would do, fifteen years later, when he smudged de Kooning.

Again and again, I returned to works in which men were de Kooning’s focus, because I wanted to see the division in de Kooning’s art between the romantic and the sexual. I don’t think he was able to bring the two together, at least not with ease, given the romance of his drawings of men and the ferocity and the staggering sexuality he conveyed in his “Women” series, which he began in 1950. In an unpublished 1971 interview with the critic

Harold Rosenberg, de Kooning said, “I was painting those male figures . . . but I found out that that didn’t get me anywhere.”

Men had loved and helped de Kooning from the time he was a boy, but because of this he could go only so far with them as subjects. What was missing in most of his early work was not just the drama of resistance that his mother had supplied but the drama of psychological exile, coupled with actual exile. You may try not to be like your parents, but still you create situations in which you are their child, over and over again. De Kooning was forever Cornelia’s scorned and abused boy. Mother and son meet up again in the painting “Excavation” (1950), though the work isn’t a portrait of Cornelia; it’s a portrait of where de Kooning’s anguish about his mother led him, a canvas that articulates his pain, the intimacy of anger, and the frightful, destructive epoch he was living in. (The show’s curators, Kevin Salatino, Mel Becker Solomon, and Charlotte Healy, have included a number of major canvases and sculptures, which help to anchor the more than a hundred and fifty drawings.)

De Kooning parked his “nice” side in his pencil portraits of men. The artist who made “Excavation” was someone else: inconsolable, wounded, wry, unforgiving. “Excavation” is one of the ugliest and most gorgeous modern paintings I have seen, a monster that swallows you whole. The main colors here are black and white, with flashes of red and blue. The artist said that “Excavation” was inspired by the neorealist Italian film “Bitter Rice” (1949), a depiction of workers in northern Italy which is dominated by the bodies of women. The painting shows a world of bodies, too, but they are fractured, and seemingly feed on other bodies and on birds and on paint itself. The drama here is rendered in sharp and round lines that stop and start, leading to other lines and to fragments of figuration: gaping mouths, elongated necks. All of these—the abstracted figures, the colliding lines—look as though they’re trying to escape the painting. It’s an emotionally claustrophobic and, in a way, hopeless work, but at the same time one that is thrilled by its own newness, the newness of its language.



*"No, the boss is a real snake—he dropped from a tree through the sunroof."
Cartoon by Frank Cotham*

"Excavation" screams as excruciatingly as Picasso's "Weeping Woman" (1937) does, but in a different register. It was completed five years after the Second World War ended, in the intense early period of the Cold War. De Kooning needed that time to become more himself, so that the work could be more itself, too. There are no fully executed figures in it, no Cubist unity to pull the broken bodies together again. The painting exists as a whole because of the way de Kooning works and reworks the surface. It brings to mind newsreel images of Holocaust victims—prying camera eyes gazing at mountains of bodies, limbs tossed here and there, the dead shovelled on top of the dead. Abstraction was the mode of the fractured postwar world. But de Kooning, unlike his near-contemporary Jackson Pollock, believed that "even abstract shapes must have a likeness."

De Kooning was still poor in 1950, but his reputation among critics and painters was growing. Part of his poetic and dramatic genius was in bringing together pieces of the world that American art hadn't seen—or been willing to look at—before. He could do this because he was learning to face the complications of his adopted country, just as he faced the complications of his relationship to women. Psychoanalysis was a hip thing to talk about and sometimes experience in de Kooning's bohemian circles, but the artist, without necessarily being aware of it, showed us, in his "Women" series, what it actually looked like, and thus felt like, to uncover one's primal feelings. No doubt buoyed by the success of "Excavation"—which was included in the Venice Biennale and, the following year, in an exhibition of abstract painting and sculpture at *MoMA*—de Kooning wanted to delve deeper into this new psychic freedom, to find more of what he

knew or could face imagining. His ethereal drawing of his wife, the wily and captivating Elaine de Kooning—whom he married in 1943 and never divorced, although they were separated for decades—is as romantic as de Kooning gets, which is to say that Elaine, in that drawing, might as well have been one of his men. But in the works that followed de Kooning’s elegant, sure-handed lines were disturbed once again.



"Monumental Woman," 1953. Art work by Willem de Kooning / Courtesy © 2026 The Willem de Kooning Foundation / ARS; Photograph by Tim Nighswander / Imaging4Art.com

In the "Women" series, the real and the mythic, memory and reality, wrestle for pride of place in de Kooning's consciousness. He may be strong, but when he pushes these women they push back, and in that heated exchange the viewer is likely to get burned. In the fascinating charcoal drawing "Monumental Woman" (1953), a woman exists in a series of swirls; we see her belly, her breasts, but she seems to be asking if we're seeing enough of her. On the left side of the drawing are a series of markings that may be hair—or perhaps they're de Kooning trying to get the woman, and by extension himself, to shut up. Neither he nor the woman wins, and neither will be silent—about the soul's relationship to desire, at least, which can only be

misunderstood or misinterpreted. “Two Women” (1951-52) is less robust than “Monumental Woman,” and it affords us the opportunity to see the fineness of de Kooning’s hand in what at first appears to be a quieter sphere. The two women—but there seem to be three—are at the center of the field, with air around them. The main figure has a tiny head, while the others are a series of smudged pencil markings. The drawing is an abstraction of flesh, floating in a kind of amusement-park world: de Kooning’s New York. To spend any time with this magnificent piece is to see the body at work, a wall of stretched and stretching limbs, a modern version of the Three Graces, who stand there not to be admired but to be claimed by the only thing they understand: distance.

“Two Women” and other pencil drawings from the same period show us de Kooning in relation less to visual art than to theatre and dance: especially George Balanchine’s “plotless” ballets, such as “The Four Temperaments” (1946) and the ever-astonishing “Agon” (1957). The Russian-born Balanchine—another émigré artist who survived a brutal, forlorn childhood with his poetry intact—dressed his dancers in black and white leotards, the colors of New York cool. Like Balanchine, de Kooning made images for the mind about the body as it was expressed in the streets of the city. Sometimes, when I watch Balanchine’s choreography, I can’t help imagining “Monumental Woman” and other drawings from the “Women” series flashing behind the dancers as they embody de Kooning’s symphony of flesh. ♦

[Hilton Als](#), a staff writer at *The New Yorker*, won the 2017 Pulitzer Prize for criticism. He is the editor of “[God Made My Face: A Collective Portrait of James Baldwin](#).”

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[On and Off the Menu](#)

What Carla Lalli Cooked After Her Divorce

With “Food Is a Feeling,” the cookbook author joins a lineage of writers who have explored the appetites of the newly unmarried.

By [Hannah Goldfield](#)

September 7, 2026



Lalli wants to challenge the idea that “eating your feelings” has to be a bad thing. Photo illustration by Jason Fulford and Tamara Shopsin

In 2012, the poet Sharon Olds published a collection, which would later win the Pulitzer Prize, about the dissolution of her thirty-two-year marriage. She called it “Stag’s Leap,” after her ex-husband’s favorite wine label. In one poem, “Attempted Banquet,” she describes a summer meal they’d hosted not long before they split—“lugging of shellfish in coolers, boiling / and bouillabaissing”—and her realization, later, that behind his “joyless labor / in the heat” and the salmon that “undulated out the kitchen door in its / half-slip of thin cucumber scales” lay the fact that he’d been planning to leave her. Too few guests attended, she writes,

and the wasted food was like some kind of
carnage. We lived on it a week, as we'd been
living, without my seeing it,
on the broken habit of what was not lasting
love.

In Olds's poem, food is both poignant metaphor and quotidian backdrop, evidence that life happens even as it's falling apart. It plays an analogous role in Nora Ephron's 1983 novel "Heartburn," a seminal divorce text which appears to fictionalize the dramatic end of her marriage to the journalist Carl Bernstein. Ephron's narrator and alter ego, Rachel Samstat, writes cookbooks and hosts a TV show. Even as she divulges the humiliating circumstances that lead to the breakup—she discovers that her husband is cheating on her while she is seven months pregnant—she expounds matter-of-factly and almost cheerfully on food, weaving more than a dozen recipes into the narrative. Some encapsulate wistful memories (bread pudding eaten on a romantic trip to New Orleans); others Rachel's efforts to comfort herself: "Nothing like getting into bed with a bowl of hot mashed potatoes already loaded with butter, and methodically adding a thin cold slice of butter to every forkful." She includes instructions for the Key-lime pie she throws in her husband's face the night she realizes that the relationship is unsalvageable, and for the vinaigrette she teaches him to make on the surprisingly tender night before she moves out.

In the literature of divorce, food is often marked by its absence—by the rupture of routine, the disappearance of appetite, and the sudden weight loss that is almost inevitably framed as a morbid silver lining. "Maybe it's God's way of gearing you up to go back into the dating world," the actress and writer Isabel Gillies suggests in her 2009 memoir "Happens Every Day." Gillies's book, a tale of WASPY spousal desertion, was, perhaps, ahead of its time; it didn't capture the Zeitgeist in the way that Belle Burden's "Strangers" did this year. (Which is a shame—Gillies's book is vivid, funny, and self-aware where Burden's skews grim and self-serious.) Burden, too, grew thinner after her husband left. "I can see how you're suffering," she remembers an acquaintance telling her.

Yet the newly single woman—it’s almost always a woman writing a divorce book—is also prone to culinary epiphany. In many stories, the end of a marriage prompts the rapturous rediscovery of tastes, habits, carnal desires. Gillies recounts being miserable at brunch with her children and soon-to-be ex-husband until she takes a bite of a dish that seems to demand, she writes, “a culinary leap of faith”: pancakes made with asparagus, ham, and Gruyère, topped with fried eggs and served with maple syrup. “It was sublime,” she writes. “I called out, ‘Sweet lord, these are incredible!’ . . . At that very moment, my life was being saved. I thought if I could get such a kick out of these pancakes, I hadn’t died.”

Elizabeth Gilbert’s “Eat, Pray, Love,” the defining divorce memoir of the early two-thousands, is animated by a similar evangelism. If Gilbert’s soliloquy on Neapolitan pizza is insufferably cute—“I love my pizza so much, in fact, that I have come to believe in my delirium that my pizza might actually love me, in return”—a passage about needing larger pants is genuinely moving. “I came to Italy pinched and thin,” Gilbert writes. “I did not know yet what I deserved. I still maybe don’t fully know what I deserve. But I do know that I have collected myself of late—through the enjoyment of harmless pleasures—into somebody much more intact. The easiest, most fundamentally human way to say it is that *I have put on weight*. I exist more now than I did four months ago.”

This month, Carla Lalli, a former *Bon Appétit* editor and a best-selling cookbook author, will publish “Food Is a Feeling,” a cookbook-as-divorce-memoir. Though it resembles her other two books, “Where Cooking Begins” (2019) and “That Sounds So Good” (2021)—bibles of technique and inspiration for the busy yet ambitious home cook—Lalli announces, in the introduction, that she’s trying something different. Throughout her career, she’d been advised to maintain a consistent and upbeat writing voice, but she’d recently gone through a metamorphosis, prompted by the end of her twenty-four-year marriage. “With due respect to my former self and to anyone who has cooked my dishes before,” she writes, “it didn’t feel right that my recipe voice should stay the same, because I am not the same.”

Recipe development can be a self-effacing task, obliging the writer to anticipate the appetites and routines of her imagined reader. Lalli's new recipes, interwoven with essays, are proudly idiosyncratic, tracing the contours of a "tumultuous, pensive, painful, joyful, transformative, celebratory, solitary, and exciting time in my life." The book begins with a dish that Lalli improvised for dinner with her sister on the night that she moved into a sublet apartment: "Greens, Garlic, and Mom Rice," with the rice cooked in butter, as their mother prefers. She shares the "Separation Pork Chops" she served after she and her ex-husband broke the news to their children, and the heart-shaped chicken cutlets she made for herself and her younger son after their household cleaved in two. Lalli's ex hated tomatoes, especially raw ones with their "gooey guts," she tells us, before pointedly providing a trio of recipes that accentuate their "amniotic" juices and "messy, pulpy" flesh.

In her solitude, Lalli was "flooded with memories" of cooking and being cooked for, and felt inspired to eat whatever she felt like, whether that was popcorn for dinner or a spontaneous glass of sake (against the advice of her therapist). She told me recently that she bucks against the idea that "eating your feelings" is negative, because cultivating a reader's emotional connection with food is part of her job. "As food writers, we talk about how great it's going to be when you make this meal for other people, and how lovely of a time you're going to have—I love these feelings," Lalli said. Why, she wondered, have we remained attached to the image of "someone creeping down to the freezer at two in the morning to eat Dove bars in secret"?

Rather than feel ashamed of her private bedtime snack, Lalli canonizes it in an arch recipe for "Night Cereal"—a chic Brooklyn mom's alternative to Liz Lemon's "night cheese." It's made with ice-cold rice milk, a "heaping cup" of crunchy cereal, frozen blueberries straight from the bag, "a few whispers" of maple syrup, and a pinch of flaky sea salt. "The extreme coldness of the milk makes it hard to eat the cereal quickly, stretching the experience—layers of flavors and textures, the spoon, the bowl, the crunches, and the slurps," Lalli explains. "Night cereal had the power to turn my mood around." "When I finished," she adds, seeming to relish the innuendo, "I felt content, taken care of."

To sell the book, Lalli had to convince her editor and publisher that “the conversation had changed around divorce,” she told me. They worried about portraying food as something other than “the fun bits”; her aim to convey “that food exists in hard times, and as a form of coping” seemed to freak them out. The book’s tone can be frank and disarmingly raw, occasionally veering toward the woo-woo: “Breathe so your belly rises. Commune with animals,” Lalli intones in a list of mantras for anyone feeling out of sorts. “The thing about spring is that it always comes back, you just have to wait,” she recounts saying in a toast at a vernal-equinox party, which, she notes, moved one or two people to tears.

I didn’t cry reading “Food Is a Feeling,” though I felt validated, and a little relieved, by Lalli’s account of grieving a version of herself. After a close friend died earlier this year, I experienced some of what she describes in the book: a powerful, if painful clarity of want and need; a heightened, nearly euphoric bodily awareness. At first, I’d given myself a hard time about my sudden yen for my children’s chicken fingers and French fries, and my impulse to order a second margarita; through Lalli’s lens, these simply seemed like the things that I required. Luckily for the rest of us, what Lalli required was typically inventive and satisfying: caramelized Japanese sweet potatoes with labne, black vinegar, and chili crisp, to help her build muscle while strength training; a “personal pot of beans and greens,” seasoned emphatically with anchovies, fennel and coriander seeds, turmeric, and Aleppo pepper.

A few years ago, I adopted one of Lalli’s kitchen maxims, “always be downsizing,” or A.B.D.—she recommends continually moving the contents of your refrigerator and pantry to size-appropriate containers as you make your way through them, to keep the shelves uncrowded. As I read and cooked from “Food Is a Feeling,” the slogan started to seem, too, like a metaphor for life. “Every time you finish what you need to do with an ingredient and relocate it,” Lalli wrote last year in her newsletter, “You create space for yourself.” ♦

Hannah Goldfield, a staff writer covering restaurants and food culture, received a 2024 James Beard Award for her [Profile of the chef Kwame Onwuachi](#).

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[Pop Music](#)

The Prolific Storytelling of This Is Lorelei

Nate Amos writes songs that both embrace and lampoon dusty singer-songwriter tropes.

By [Amanda Petrusich](#)

September 7, 2026



Artists including Waxahatchee, Hayley Williams, and Cameron Winter have performed covers of Amos's songs. Photograph by Evelyn Freja for The New Yorker

In the summer of 2024, Nate Amos released a record called “Box for Buddy, Box for Star” under the sobriquet This Is Lorelei. (The name is a reference to an episode of “Star Trek: The Animated Series.”) The ten-song album felt like a kind of *début*, though Amos had already established himself as half of the art-pop duo Water from Your Eyes—his project with the musician Rachel Brown—and uploaded hundreds of scrappy, idiosyncratic folk songs to Bandcamp, starting in 2014, when he was a twenty-two-year-old college student living in Chicago. “Box for Buddy” is

suffused with heartache—the narrators of these tracks are choking on the backwash of poisonous relationships—but it’s also a playful, visionary album that both embraces and lampoons dusty singer-songwriter tropes. It seesaws between woeful love songs that are set to acoustic guitar and toy piano (“Where’s Your Love Now”) and woeful love songs that are laced with Auto-Tune and keening synthesizer (“Dancing in the Club”).

With *Brown*, Amos makes twinkly, off-kilter experimental songs that sometimes sound as though they’re being piped out of a cursed music box. “Box for Buddy” earned him comparisons to Neutral Milk Hotel and the Postal Service, artists beloved for their urgency and their tenderness. A “super deluxe” version of the album, released earlier this year, features covers by a murderers’ row of indie musicians, including Waxahatchee (“Where’s Your Love Now”), MJ Lenderman (“Dancing in the Club”), Snail Mail (“Two Legs”), and Power Snatch (“Perfect Hand”), Hayley Williams’s duo with the producer Daniel James. Last December, during a solo piano show in Los Angeles, Cameron Winter, the front man of the band Geese, performed a soaring and intensely plangent version of “Where’s Your Love Now,” a song about looking back with a mix of bitterness and clarity: “I said, where’s your love now? / Long after your song is over / You left me to drink, I thought I’d die in my sleep / But I’m healthier now.” Amos’s current popularity nods, seductively, to an earlier era, in which artists were discovered not via algorithmic meddling but by the endorsement of their peers and old-fashioned word of mouth.

“It’s been very trippy, getting to know all those covers,” Amos told me this summer, over lunch at a Himalayan restaurant in Ridgewood, Queens. “It almost feels like a proud-parent moment. The song survived adolescence, and now it’s its own functional thing.” This month, Amos will release “The Singer in My Band,” his second full-fledged album as This Is Lorelei, and his most elemental and concise work yet. “I love a forty-five-minute album,” he said. “But, honestly, that’s a lot of prolonged attention to ask of people, with things being the way they are. So I figured I would shave ten minutes off that and be, like, Come on, lock into my thirty-four minutes. You can do this!”

Amos wrote, engineered, performed, and produced the record himself, excepting some banjo playing by his father, Bob, and occasional backing vocals by both his sister, Sarah, and his fiancée, the bassist Al Nardo. It's the first release where Amos's Americana bona fides—he grew up in a family of bluegrass musicians, mostly in Winchester, Virginia, a center for Appalachian music—feel evident. “I didn't really attempt to play guitar until fifth grade,” Amos said. “By then, I had seven years of just sitting at bluegrass jam sessions and observing. The thing with bluegrass is that everything is a rhythm instrument—with the exception of the fiddle, sometimes—so it's as if everyone is operating a giant musical drum set, and if one person isn't holding their own then the whole thing completely collapses.”

“The Singer in My Band” sounds tighter and more expensive than Amos's previous LPs. His voice, which is grainy and earnest, is often doubled in the mix, though when he leaps into a higher register, as he does on the single “Oh No Now My,” it sounds airy, almost celestial. These are hooky, likable songs about rambling around, encountering oddball characters, receiving their wisdom and warnings, and then keeping it moving—part Robert Frank, part Robert Altman, with a minor but hallucinatory dose of Hunter S. Thompson. Many have the gentle, foggy quality of a Polaroid: dim, half remembered, fleeting. “I always think about this Mitch Hedberg joke, that photos of Bigfoot aren't blurry, they're actually in focus—he's just a blurry monster,” Amos said. He has come to think of the album's structure in literary terms, comparing it to Ray Bradbury's “The Martian Chronicles”: “It's a larger narrative, but it's told in short-story form.” His writing is unusually rife with proper nouns—Buddy, Sarah, Evie, Genevieve, Billy, Joey, Miss B. When I asked him if the work feels explicitly autobiographical, he paused. “I mean, there isn't anything on this album that I haven't experienced in some capacity,” he said. “But my approach toward writing is not so much trying to tell a specific story or communicate a particular thing but to create a kind of playground for the listener's subconscious to build their own story.” It struck me as a generous impulse—confessional songwriting is often framed as a kind of bloodletting for the writer. “The way I'm thinking about it is, I'm forcing the listener to do their end of the work,” he said.

As a kid, Amos listened to a lot of the Beatles and Stevie Ray Vaughan, though for the past two and a half months, he said, “I haven’t really listened to anything other than ZZ Top. I’m beginning to be slightly worried.” Amos has also been publicly ebullient about his devotion to Blink-182’s “All the Small Things,” a goofy pop-punk hit from 1999. “That’s a God-tier pop song,” he said. “I got really fixated on that song in a way that, honestly, in hindsight, was not normal. I wasn’t even listening to the original recording. I was just finding every cover of that song I could possibly find and putting it on a giant playlist.” He admired the track for its agility, its economy, and its ability to transcend genre (the lyrics, essentially a series of grunts, are incidental to its melodic pleasures). “A sign of a really tight pop song is that it translates to all these different formats really well,” Amos said. The same, of course, is true for Amos’s work—distilled to its essence, and free of affectation, it remains enormously poignant.

After lunch, we took an Uber to the Cage, a baseball complex in Middle Village, a quiet, mostly residential part of Queens. In 2005, the Cage was opened by Ross (the Boss) Friedman, a founding member of the pugnacious and seminal punk band the Dictators, stalwarts of the early CBGB scene. (In 1978, both the Dictators and Bruce Springsteen were recording at the Record Plant, a beloved studio on West Forty-fourth Street; per punk lore, Springsteen shouts the “One, two, three, four!” count at the top of the Dictators’ “Faster and Louder.”) Friedman, who also played lead guitar in the metal band Manowar, passed away in March, and the Cage is now operated by his son Jesse. There’s something sort of ineffably rock and roll about the place—maybe it’s the hundreds of fist-shaped craters punched into the ceiling, evidence of fly balls careening toward Heaven and meeting plaster. As we selected our equipment, I asked Jesse if he had any advice before we went in. He gave me the kind of withering look you can receive only in the outer boroughs of New York City. “Don’t die,” he said.

Amos and I set our machine to a moderate lob and started swinging. Amos is a good batter: steady, confident, strong. He got off some dingers. The Cage felt like a useful spot to work out any resentments lingering in your psyche, all the old grievances dissipating with the clang of aluminum on cowhide. Afterward, standing on the sidewalk, we agreed that it seemed as though we’d accomplished something important. “It’s like a step up from

bowling or mini-golf. How do we make mini-golf more extreme, so it's dangerous?" Amos joked. "I think we did really good," he concluded, lighting a cigarette. "We didn't die." ♦

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[The Theatre](#)

Seeing It All Hang Out at the Fringe

Twenty-odd shows from Edinburgh's annual avant-garde rumspringa.

By [Emily Nussbaum](#)

September 3, 2026



In “Classic Penguins,” Garry Starr celebrates literature in the buff. Illustration by Javi Aznarez

The strangest, most beautiful thing I saw at the Edinburgh Festival Fringe felt less like theatre than like mass hypnosis. In the silky, largely wordless “Dracula: Lucy’s Dream,” by the French-Norwegian troupe Plexus Polaire, Bram Stoker’s orange-haired Victorian waif Lucy, her body jellyfished into a loose nightgown, gets stalked and bitten by Dracula night after night as she darts among drifting monoliths. But the viewer is quickly disoriented, thrown by the presence of at least three Lucys onstage, not to mention a murder of Draculas, some of them hinge-limbed, human-size puppets eerily indistinguishable from the actors manipulating them. Each morning, after Lucy’s panicked helpers struggle to shake her awake, the cycle begins

again, punctuated by lurid tableaux: three Lucys cradle three babies, then bite their tiny necks; a tri-headed Lucy kicks and hisses at her nurses. When the show ended, the audience burst into rattled applause, as if we'd been woken from our own dream, still unable to tell the reverie from the real thing.

That kind of bracing communal experience is exactly why people attend the Fringe, an event that launched, in 1947, as a thumb in the eye of a mainstream arts festival in the city. This was my first time attending, and though I know that the Fringe has changed a lot—it's at once an avant-garde rumspringa and a bid for "Fleabag" fame—it was still a delirious spectacle, a choose-your-own-adventure of more than four thousand shows, featuring combo platters of standup, improv, clowning, drag, musical theatre, drama, circus performance, and burlesque. (Then, there's the occasional shock show in which a performer, say, drinks his own urine.) In four and a half days, I saw twenty-one shows—twenty-two, if you count ten minutes of standup in a pitch-black dungeon. But even the duds were worth it. By Sunday, I felt not unlike Lucy: drained but craving just a little more.

Of dozens of venues, the most unusual was a sauna erected behind Summerhall, where I slipped into a bathing suit, then reclined with six fellow-guests on tiered wooden benches that surrounded radiant rocks. As the heat softened us into linguine, we absorbed audio excerpts of "The Waves," Virginia Woolf's incantatory "play-poem," recorded by actors. Meanwhile, two sauna masters shovelled ice infused with fragrant oil onto the rocks and performed an Aufguss, a German ritual in which towels are twirled to spread scented air. During intermissions, we dipped into a frigid pool. I'm not sure how much the towel dance added, but the sensory overload hit me like a love drug, intensifying "The Waves," with its braided soliloquies, and heightening the feeling that our individual minds were lapping like waves within a broader consciousness. That rush of insights went unscribbled, since notebooks don't make sense in a sauna. But I left joyful and shocked, dizzy to my heels.

As it happened, both "Dracula" and "The Waves" also turned up in a very different context: Garry Starr's bawdy, disarming "Classic Penguins," a one-man show that is coming to New York this month, at the intimate

Studio Seaview. In Edinburgh, at the enormous Pleasance Grand, the audience filed in to find Starr—the alter ego of the Australian performer Damien Warren-Smith—seated and facing the back wall, naked but for a top hat, a huge ruffled collar, a gentleman’s tailcoat, and penguin flippers. He swivelled to face us, smoking a pipe, from which he calmly inhaled, “Masterpiece Theatre” style. Then he stuck the pipe into his asshole and, somehow, expelled smoke both from there and from his mouth. “The Aristocrats”!

The intro functioned as a jovial dare: all bets were off, for his body and for ours. A fit, middle-aged man with a twinkling, louche charisma, Starr swiftly laid out the show’s intent, which was to celebrate each of the Penguin Classics paperbacks, thereby elevating the glory of “literaturaaaah.” What followed was a sort of highbrow “Jackass,” an exhilaratingly silly cavalcade of slapstick, dad jokes, and audience participation, as Starr thumped each book on a desk, its cover displayed on a screen, and then performed a goofball gag, the style of which ranged all over the map. For “Dracula,” Starr slurped down “blood”; then, with his abdomen grotesquely distended, he swapped out the book for Sartre’s “Nausea,” then pulled on a white bonnet for “The Handmaid’s Tale.” His “Wuthering Heights” featured aerial gymnastics and an air cannon. These stunts may sound crude, but—hear me out!—the group experience felt liberatory and oddly innocent, a joyful dropping of taboos that erased any easy line between smart and dumb. A lot of the show’s effectiveness had to do with viewers eager to play along. At one point, some enthusiastic geezers embraced our nude m.c., and I teared up at the moment’s intimacy; it felt like a masterly trust game, although I guess that’s true of all well-made theatre, naked or not.

Clowning—the extreme sport of comedy—is deep in the DNA of the Fringe. Still, several of the best things I saw were small, earnest acts, such as the lovely “Jitters,” a scripted two-hander, by Ellen Robertson, about a wedding-day showdown between a wannabe trophy wife (a very funny Charly Clive, all evo-psych self-justification) and her soon-to-be stepdaughter (Robertson, wryly acidic). It was a clash between millennial feminisms that could easily have curdled into polemic but instead felt fresh and surprising. My other favorite was “Lions,” a more madcap but equally heartfelt show about fathers, starring Scott R. Sheppard and Alice Yorke,

the artistic directors of the gifted Philadelphia troupe Lightning Rod Special. “Our dads are dead! Thanks for coming,” they announced, as they stood before a table full of paternal detritus: a basketball, a record player. What began as an anarchic vaudeville act performed in dandyish masculinity drag (ascots, wacky mustaches) evolved, in smart, layered stages, into a bittersweet eulogy, as the performers used the props to reenact—and investigate—their fathers’ lives, down to their deepest disappointments, all while dramatizing the disorienting limbo of a family making end-of-life decisions.

I’d hoped to spot the next “Operation Mincemeat,” but instead the first musical I caught was a vapid, if impressively belted, princess tale, “Bliss,” a glittery bummer that resembled “Six,” minus the wit, or “KPop Demon Hunters,” only two notches hollower. Significantly better was “Evita Too,” a more gonzo girl-power celebration that was definitely not for kids. To be fair, Louise Mothersole and Rebecca Biscuit, the brassy duo behind Sh!t Theatre, could have booked a black box and still hooked viewers merely by reciting the surreal résumé of Isabel Perón, Juan Perón’s third wife. Instead, the pair wove incendiary themes of sex, fascism, and feminism into a clever meditation on the relationship between shaggy shows like this one and West End blockbusters such as the O.G. “Evita.” Like Garry Starr, they used every tool at hand, jumping merrily from nude roller-skating to investigative documentary, in a production that culminated with the alarming sight of a jumbo-sized Evita puppet corpse whose face bore a suspicious resemblance to Andrew Lloyd Webber.

Less developed, but still appealing, was “The Real Kyle McCarren,” a soulful homage to the dead friend and former bandmate of the show’s co-creator and star, Andy Roninson. Staged concert style, the musical had a cerebral mournfulness reminiscent of “Tick, Tick . . . Boom!,” with a killer cast and strongly crafted indie-rock numbers that found new angles on grief, many from the perspective of a man too awkward for a group hug. If the show faded toward the end—hobbled, perhaps, by an unwillingness to take big liberties with a true story—it had a throb of authentic, unforced emotionality.

On my final afternoon, I squeezed in another gutsy little musical, a drag-queen fantasia about climate change called “Acid’s Reign.” It ran late, so I race-walked across town to the King’s Theatre, excited to see Ivo van Hove’s five-hour minimalist deconstruction of Tony Kushner’s “Angels in America,” in Dutch, with subtitles, as part of the Edinburgh International Festival. Sadly, the production was a downer, draining Kushner’s masterpiece of color and humor and inserting, in their place, gloomy projections of cityscapes and, unaccountably, David Bowie songs. Maybe the idea was to strip away pageantry and get to a raw core, but now that Prior, the H.I.V.-positive gay man abandoned by his boyfriend, no longer wore drag, key jokes—“Ready for my closeup, Mr. DeMille!”—were incomprehensible. Bold edits, such as eliding the wild, mesmerizing “I— I— I— I” of the Angel and cutting the special effects that herald her arrival, left me cold—and it felt oddly untransgressive for Prior to be mystically aroused not by a terrifying female seraph but by a blond male hunk in nurse’s scrubs. Maybe because I’d rewatched the cult-classic Canadian TV show “Slings & Arrows,” which depicts a Shakespearean theatre festival, I was uncomfortably reminded of the show’s preeningly experimental director Darren Nichols siphoning the passion from “Romeo and Juliet” in favor of an arid landscape of signs and signifiers.

That let-down made me feel grateful for the many shows I’d seen at the Fringe that had sashayed down the bright path “Angels” had burned, in the nineties, by treating gay life as a default, drag as an art form, and queer humor and rage as paired, crucial qualities. Among these was a gloriously weird, mock-nihilistic act called “Creepy Boys: Slugs,” in which a queer Canadian clown duo struggle to stage a dazzling extravaganza empty of meaning, only to find that various *some things*—guns, the climate, gender anxiety, sexual desire—keep penetrating the razzle-dazzle. The show climaxed in a Bonnie and Clyde-ish stickup, a demand for arts funding at the point of a gun. That’s probably not an ideal solution, but “Creepy Boys” did leave me longing for a way for performers to take bigger, more ridiculous swings back in New York, where recent chatter has been about the difficulty of sustaining anything risky for long, let alone for about twenty dollars a pop. We have Coachella and Sundance; we have Burning Man, an immersive carnival that is far out of reach for most people.

Shouldn't there be a true, supersized Fringe in the U.S., a safe space that lets a hundred clowns bloom? ♦

[Emily Nussbaum](#), a staff writer at *The New Yorker* since 2011, is the magazine's theatre critic. Her books include "[Cue The Sun!: The Invention of Reality TV](#)."

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[The Current Cinema](#)

The Blockbuster Audacity of “Hope”

In Na Hong-jin’s monster movie, violent small-town comedy and big-budget Hollywood imperialism collide.

By [Justin Chang](#)

September 4, 2026



An alien invasion strikes a South Korean border town in Na Hong-jin’s film. Illustration by Chris W. Kim

At the start of the giddily entertaining monster movie “Hope,” the director and screenwriter Na Hong-jin serves up a load of bull. No, really. We’re on the South Korean side of the Demilitarized Zone, and a large male bovine has been found slashed to death near an open field. Flies buzz over the rotting carcass, which is riven by claw marks so unnaturally deep that no one can determine whomauledit. A bear? Unlikely. Maybe, one man suggests, it was that tiger from the north—the one that, flouting the rules of peninsular diplomacy, often steals across the border in search of food. This is a joke, but a telling one; the characters in this movie are used to living on high alert. The small town that they inhabit may be called Hope Harbor, but it exists in an everyday purgatory of barbed-wire fences, undetonated land mines, and signs urging residents to “*report spies*” and “*protect the nation*”

against infiltration.” Who could have guessed that their worst enemy would hail not from across the border but from the skies?

The people of Hope Harbor don’t know it yet, but an alien invasion is under way—and Na, a horror-thriller maximalist of uncommon patience, takes his time breaking the news. Subscribing to Spielberg’s law, definitively proved in “Jaws” (1975), that the predators we don’t see are the ones that scare us the most, the director spends the first of this movie’s two and a half hours methodically setting the scene—which, in this case, means laying waste to the scenery. Rattled by the mystery of the bull, Bum-seok (Hwang Jung-min), the bumbling, trigger-happy police chief of Hope Harbor, drives back into town and is confronted with a disaster zone. “A freaking huge monster,” in the words of an irascible eyewitness, has torn through the village, gutting shops and homes and leaving bodies strewn amid the rubble. The cinematographer, Hong Kyung-pyo (“Burning,” “Parasite”), slows the camera to an ominous crawl as Bum-seok draws his weapon and tiptoes through the debris: broken beams, caved-in ceilings, bloodstained tiles, and piles upon piles of precious, ordinary, soon to be forgotten stuff. Admirers of Na’s previous films, none more bewitchingly bonkers than “The Wailing” (2016), will recognize the cluttered crime-scene handiwork of his longtime production designer, Lee Hwok-young. Buildings, like bodies, have innards, too.

There’s a dread-soaked wit to the movie’s drawn-out approach, especially in this first hour. We may think that we’re seeing the aftermath of a creature’s rampage, but we are, in fact, being introduced to the creature itself: we are what we destroy, Na seems to be saying. From this particular trail of devastation, we can deduce that the perpetrator is colossal, fast, and possessed of a strange mix of clumsiness and stealth. As Bum-seok zeroes in on his target, Na lures us into a crafty game of predator peekaboo; we can track the monster’s proximity through the explosions that it triggers in the vicinity and the lethal projectiles that it lobs from afar. Na is so good at this brand of menace by misdirection that, by the time you finally lay eyes on the monster, you might wish you hadn’t. For one thing, the creature, whom the end credits call Va’migere (and who is played, via performance-capture technology, by Cameron Britton), is properly fearsome to behold: an unjolly green giant that chases after Bum-seok on all fours, shrieks like an

emphysemic banshee, and generally brings to mind the love child of the Incredible Hulk and “The Exorcist” ’s Regan MacNeil. But it is also, deflatingly, a computer-generated creepy-crawly, and unlike some other movie monsters—say, the amphibious kidnapper from “The Host” (2006) or the sharp-eared stalkers from “A Quiet Place” (2018)—Va’migere has a humanoid face and form, rendered with an almost hyperreal incongruity. It might have wandered, or crashed, into the movie from a decade-old zombie-apocalypse video game.

Na’s solution to this problem is speed: the faster he can keep his aliens moving—Va’migere, alas, is not alone—the less likely we are to scrutinize the malevolent jumble of pixels they are. The film’s first chase is a tour de force of kinetic delirium: Sung-ae (Hoyeon), a brave junior cop, drives Bum-seok through the streets of Hope Harbor, with Va’migere sprinting furiously after them. Hong, favoring a backward-facing view of the mayhem, shoots in lengthy takes that swerve and snake with rough-and-tumble precision; the energies of car and camera seem to fuse into one. Compare this with a similarly arresting later sequence, set deep within a magnificently mossy forest, where a band of hunters, led by Sung-ki (Zo In-sung, full of rascally charisma), do battle with Va’migere’s alien friends. If the street chase transplanted “Bullitt” to the D.M.Z., this earthier showdown, which puts Sung-ki and his fellow-fighters on horseback, has the verdant majesty of a woodland Western.

Here and elsewhere, Na stretches out the action to an almost luxuriant degree, and he makes a virtue of attenuation: a run-and-gun stunt that seems repetitive the third time is somehow smashing on the eighth. It helps that the aliens are almost as hard to kill as Wile E. Coyote, and, indeed, should you emerge from “Coyote vs. Acme” with your craving for comic violence unsated, you might consider going straight into “Hope,” which is something of a live-action cartoon writ large. (There’s a touch of the Tasmanian Devil to the way Va’migere crashes through walls, leaving behind vaguely Va’migere-shaped holes.) Yet Na also insists on treating his aliens as objects of contemplation and pathos—reflections of our own misshapen humanity. In one slow-motion scene, we peer into Va’migere’s wraithlike visage and see not just rage or monstrosity but an all too relatable terror. We are what we destroy.

All four of Na's features were shown at the Cannes Film Festival, but "Hope" was his first to appear in the main competition. Predictably, its selection triggered the kind of reflexive critical grumbling that often ensues when a gory genre movie, be it "Oldboy," "Drive," or "The Substance," is elevated to the highest of world-cinema pedestals. For some of us, though, Na's upgrade seemed overdue. His films, all of which have been critically and commercially successful, have long blurred the lines between the aspirations of the art house and the pleasures of the grind house. I still can't shake the grisly final moments of "The Chaser" (2009), a blisteringly cynical police procedural that takes a hammer to the mere notion of competence or integrity in law enforcement. Na's films are propelled by brutal individual acts, but they also swarm with systemic rot. His finest movie, "The Yellow Sea" (2011), strands a debt-ridden Korean Chinese immigrant in the midst of a mob war, forcing him to run and run—and kill and kill—in order to survive. It's bleak as hell; it's also exhilarating.

"Hope," which is Na's first film in a decade, represents both a step up in ambition and a step down in finesse. The movie has a goofy, galumphing beauty; it's a bigger, dumber, shinier object than its predecessors, yet it also manifests the crudely violent small-town comedy that is one of Na's signatures. The people of Hope Harbor speak almost exclusively in barked expletives and insults, and nearly all of them are packing serious heat; Bum-seok's irritation at the sheer glut of unregistered weapons becomes a sly running gag. One colorful customer spouts a fabulously ripe monologue about how the aliens nearly caught him mid-defecation—a close encounter of the turd kind. More disquietingly, several of Na's characters seem at least as fond of the art of disembowelment as their alien overlords are: witness an overeager coroner merrily firing up a chainsaw as she tackles her first alien autopsy, or a village doofus (Eum Moon-suk) whose unfortunate taste for taxidermy may have set this entire tragedy in motion.

Whom, exactly, are we supposed to root for here? Bum-seok, Sung-ae, and Sung-ki do find a shambolic Hawksian unity, after a fashion; Sung-ae, in particular, has only to step out of a car with a military-grade rifle to elicit spontaneous applause. But Na's most interesting countermove is to seed the enemy ranks with Hollywood actors, including Michael Fassbender, Alicia Vikander, and Taylor Russell—not that you're likely to recognize them

under their gobs of shape-shifting C.G.I. Belatedly, Fassbender and Vikander, sweetly cast as a sort of alien couple, are given the most soulful lines in the entire picture, though whether soul is called for is unclear; a script that boasts a five-minute soliloquy about diarrhea is suddenly rife with mythical earnestness and impenetrable last-minute world-building. Is Na, in merging unforgettable spectacle and unutterable dialogue, laying claim to the mantle of “Avatar”-era James Cameron? Does he yearn to put the “Na” in Na’vi? Perhaps this saga of planetary conquest is also a sly commentary on Hollywood imperialism, in which even the most far-flung of small-town tales must be overwhelmed by big-name stars in visual-effects drag. Na has clearly succumbed to the blockbuster mentality: as he confirmed at Cannes, a sequel is already written. Could the next movie begin to make sense of its predecessor’s hilarious and confounding final minutes? Hope springs eternal. ♦

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Worst

By [Dorothea Lasky](#)

September 6, 2026

I am the worst kind of person
Protecting my little male babies at every turn
Motherhood is ultimately hard on the mother
Green cherries hanging from the trees
It's by misspelling that I learn the real words

Protecting my little male babies at every turn
Green cherries hanging from the trees
It's by misspelling that I learn the real words
I am the worst kind of woman
Motherhood is ultimately hard on the mother

Hard on the mother motherhood is ultimately
Green cherries and the worst kind of woman
I am my little male babies
Only by protecting the words
Only by misspelling do I learn the real words

This is drawn from “[Mother](#).”

[Dorothea Lasky](#) is the author of several books, including the poetry collection “[The Shining](#).”

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[Poems](#)

Ode to Being Born with Teeth and Sharpening Them Every Day

By [Barbara Hamby](#)

September 6, 2026

If you like surprises, being born has to be the best,
 one minute swimming in nothing, and the next
popping out into a hot late July day in New Orleans
 like a gumbo of sweat and bad news,
because the war is over and your father has come home,
 but others are lining up, ready to take his place
in the murderer's row, rat-a-tat-tat and all that, the blood
 that spills like ketchup from a broken bottle in lands
so far away they seem like a dream or a book written
 by a mystic with time on his hands, and that's all
you had then, acres of time, your teeth biting off
 each day like a piece of rough bread and chewing it—
learning to eat, speak, walk, everything you needed
 to take on the days ahead, and going to school,
you had to sharpen your teeth for that, like the time
 in the third grade when some mean girls
were tormenting a boy who wore his pajamas under
 his pants, probably because it was cold at home,
and when I said, "Leave him alone," they ganged up
 and sang, "Barbara and Scott sitting in a tree,
K-I-S-S-I-N-G," which was so ludicrous that I turned
 and walked away, and the engine of their malice
sputtered, crashing on the wooden floor of the classroom,
 though how did I know to turn my back on them,
which is a question I ask myself every day, as in how

do I get from one to four, the hours when nothing
is syncing in my brain, and I feel as stupid as molasses,
but I still have my teeth, which are an asset
until the power grid in my brain box starts sending signals
to the thinking terminals, and I am myself again
instead of a wretched baby without teeth, crying
for my mama who has been dead for fifteen years,
but still lives in my heart, and why didn't I ask her every
question I could when she was still walking
around reading Revelation, because I knew she could die
at any moment, and so she did—*Pop!* went something
in her brain, and she was off to her next adventure,
as good a death as anyone could wish for,
though it left a hole in my little world, which has closed
inch by nano-inch but without her archipelago
of selves: the laughing policeman, the Bible-thumping
sun worshipper, maker of box cakes, diviner of mistakes,
right-wing lover of those with broken wings, despiser
of lies, queen of the dream wreck, O Mama,
thank you for my body, with its gears and switches,
its cannisters of blood and ooze, its "On" switch
for love and hate, its black bile and dance moves,
its slide to the left when the jackboots approach,
its party hats and hard candy when the lights go out
and the hurricane is swirling in the gulf,
when the monsters rip off their masks to snarl and tweet,
O giver of all gifts, thank you for my teeth.

Barbara Hamby has published seven poetry collections, including, most recently, "[Holoholo](#)."

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[Adam Aaronson](#) is a software engineer and a jazz musician whose crosswords have appeared in the New York Times and the Wall Street Journal.

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